



With gratitude to the wisdom and blessings of our teachers

A BEGINNER'S GUIDE TO HINDUISM

Hinduism Explained presents the essential ideas of Hindu Dharma in simple, accessible language - from the Bhagavad Gita, OM and Yoga to Dharma, devotion, self-inquiry and the infinite.

Drawing from timeless wisdom and modern life, Dr. Anupkumar Shetty distills profound concepts into clear explanations that anyone can understand. Whether you are new to Hinduism, a seeker, a student, or simply curious, this book offers a friendly guide to a rich spiritual tradition that continues to inspire millions around the world.

"There is divinity in everything and everybody."

THIRD EYE PUBLISHERS

HINDUISM EXPLAINED | ANUPKUMAR SHETTY, MD

HINDUISM EXPLAINED



With
Poems on:

Yoga,
Dharma
and Om

by Dr Raju

ANUPKUMAR SHETTY, MD

*Foreword by Swami Bodhananda Sarasvati
Edited by Suresh Srinivas, PhD*

Hinduism Explained: The Essence of Bhagavad Gita, OM, Yoga and Infinity

Beginner's Guide to Inner Peace,
Stress Relief, and Spiritual Clarity
from Classics on Indian Spirituality

Anupkumar Shetty MD



Third Eye Publishers

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Preface

There are many books on Hinduism. Why another book? The reason is to present a simple short book for the common person, kids, Hindus and others. I am not a saint. I am a common Hindu who hopes to simplify the concepts of Hinduism for a common person irrespective of his or her faith. This is not meant to be an in-depth review but is meant to be a short summary of scriptures in a common man's language. My knowledge comes from reading scriptures, listening to some experts in the field and listening to Yakshagana, a form of folk dance-drama popular in and around Udupi, a small city in the southern part of India known for the famous Krishna Temple, Jadadguru Madhwacharya (an exponent of 'dualism' concept of Hinduism) and Udupi cuisine. Udupi is also very close to Kerala and Kollur, where Adi Shankara (an exponent of 'non-dualism' concept of Hinduism and reviver of Hinduism) started his life journey.

In this era of flattening of the globe and easy dissemination of knowledge across the globe Hindus have spread all over the world. When I grew up in India, Hinduism was all around me and I never questioned my identity. Now that I am in America, I am surrounded by people from all other religions. There are less people around me who know Hinduism, there are less people around our kids who know about Hinduism. The fact that good people like Vivek Ramaswamy is unapologetic about his Hindu faith and Bobby Jindal, Ex-Governor

of Louisiana (a state in the US) chose to quit Hinduism to embrace Christianity suggest a need to educate young Hindus about the richness and the uniqueness of their religion. I have tried to present a simplistic view of Hinduism so a common person can teach his/her kids about Hinduism and an ordinary Hindu kid can read about Hinduism in a short period of time and feel proud of his/her heritage. This in a way presents my journey of understanding Hinduism. I am aware of the shortcomings of this book. I am painfully aware of my shortcomings in my knowledge of Hinduism. I hope to continue to be a student of the learned scholars as I share whatever I learn. I have not offered any new information. I have just tried to present a simplistic summary of what I felt everybody in the world should know about Hinduism. One can always go back to the original scriptures and the interpretations written by scholars in the field if one wants to know more. I also hope that this will be a simple reference for the Hindus and non-Hindus in the schools and the community who want to have a brief description of Hinduism.

Reasons to simplify and explain Hinduism are:

- To enable parents to explain Hinduism to their children
- To enable Hindus to educate themselves and their non-Hindu friends
- Every sixth person in this world is a Hindu and hence Hindus are very relevant to the world
- Correct the narrative of what Hinduism is and what it is not and also to stress the essential elements of Hinduism. Hinduism is not 'caste system' and 'idol worship'. It is important to stress that the essential part of Hinduism is seeing divinity in everything and everybody and seeing the ONEness in the

universe. It is important to educate people that worshipping and experiencing God with attributes and in attributes is a privilege and is not to be looked down upon. It is important to explain that the social issues such as 'caste system' is not Hinduism. It is important to explain the parallels and differences between 'caste system', 'jati', 'varna', 'racial discrimination', 'skin color discrimination', 'system of differentiating people based on their skills and profession'.

- Differentiate 'idol worship' from worshipping God with attributes. Most Hindus enjoy the privilege of experiencing and worshipping God with attributes and without attributes since limiting to only with attributes or only without attributes limits the scope of the 'God experience.' Many other religions do it, too.
- Hindu land is shrinking. At one time, 'Bharat', India's original name, extended from Persia (Iran) to Cambodia and Indonesia.
- The Hindu population is growing, but the proportion of Hindus worldwide is shrinking.
- Conversion of Hindus into Christianity and Islam religion is very rampant in India and elsewhere in the world.
- If you are hospitalized in the US or anywhere in the world, there is a high possibility of someone coming to your room to change your faith (it happened to me) and give you hope of getting better if you do so!
- Inter-faith and inter-racial marriages are becoming more and

more common, and there is a growing need to educate the in-laws about Hinduism.

- If you live outside India, there is a high chance that your son or daughter will marry a non-Hindu and there is a need to educate non-Hindu families about Hindus.
- Among the cultures which existed 1000 years before Christ, Hinduism is the only religion which has survived to date.
- Going by what happened to Roman, Greek and Mayan cultures, it is possible for any culture to vanish, and this makes it our responsibility to preserve a rich culture.
- ‘Hinduism Explained’ is our attempt to achieve this by providing the knowledge of essential Hindu principles in a common man’s language and separate them from the rituals that are non-essential.

‘There is divinity in everything and everybody’. I feel this is the most important and essential principle of being a Hindu. I have enjoyed repeating this time and again and I hope you will too. I think this is a solution to a lot of problems in the world. I hope I have created enough interest in the reader to read more and share this book with your family members, Hindu and non-Hindu friends and public libraries in your area.

Have a blissful reading,

Anup

Preface to the second edition:

This book comes as an update to the 'Hinduism Simplified', that I published in 2009. I added few details taking some of the inputs from the readers without deviating from keeping it true to the title 'Hinduism Simplified'. Some of you may think it is not simple enough, but I hope many will find it useful. The main addition to the new edition is about the meaning of OM and wisdom from the commonly read Hindu scriptures such as, The Holy Bhagavad Gita and Yoga. The meaning of OM is more of an experience that you have to go through, and it is not a scholarly activity, it is a meditational and transcending experience. It might take more reading and contemplation on OM from your side. 'Yoga' has been described in more detail from dualistic and non-dualistic point of view. I have added some information on 'Gayatri mantra' and some more scriptural teachings that are relevant to our day to day lives. There are few more small new chapters on 'Four Great Sentences of Hinduism', 'Swastika vs 'Hakenkreuz' and Six Philosophies of Hinduism. As I started writing some pearls from the Bhagavad Gita, it expanded and ended up becoming a good portion of this edition. This portion of Gita can be applied to our personal lives in this twenty first century and hence is relevant in our secular life as well.

In the process adding some important details, you get the introduction to Bhagavad Gita, OM, Yoga and Infinity, this book becomes a beginner's guide to inner peace, stress relief, and spiritual clarity from Classics on Indian Spirituality.

Have a blissful reading and Hari OM! Wishing you 'Infinity'!

Anupkumar Shetty

This work is dedicated to my mother, Shrimati Sushila Mahabala Shetty, a tireless Karma Yogi and my father, Shri Mahabala Shetty, who always upheld the truth.

Acknowledgements

I have a lot of people to thank for being what I am today. My thanks to my mother, an eternal karma yogi; father for teaching me to be truthful to the core always; wife Mala and children Eesha and Krishna for their unconditional love; brothers, Kishore and Ashok, for leading by example and showing me the way to be a compulsive hard worker; sisters Asha and Shakku for being the perfect unconditional God-sent sisters, grandmother, sisters-in-law, brothers-in-law and parents-in-law for their unwavering love; my best friend Dr. Raju for his unselfish love and un-measurable amounts of spiritual teaching including sharing his precious poems for this book; my elementary school teacher Late Sri Roman Serrao for teaching me 'Om sahanavatu....' in a Catholic school; my high school teacher Late Shri Balakrishna Acharya for teaching me 'Truth always wins, not the untruth' and my Hindi language teacher Late Shri K. A. Udupa for teaching Kabir's teaching suggesting the mind to go slow and steady till the fruit is achieved (Dheere dheere re mana). You will find the meaning of these verses later on in this book. My thanks to Suresh Srinivas for helping me with careful editing and improving this book. My thanks to my doctors for keeping me alive after having cancer at the age of 41 years and a second cancer at the age of 62 yrs so I could write this book.

My eternal gratitude to Swami Bodhananda Sarasvati, my spiritual Guru and mentor. Many thanks to Swami Sarvapriyananda of Vedanta Society of NY for his teachings that have enhanced my knowledge. My gratitude to Late Dr Shyamala Nair, Mrs Savitri Puram, Dr Madhusudhana Rao and also to many teachers and friends who have enhanced my knowledge by sharing theirs.

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Foreword By Swami Bodhananda

'Hinduism Explained - A Beginner's Guide' by late Anup Kumar Shetty MD is an easy-to-read primer of Hindu Dharma, one of the oldest living traditions of the world. Dharma is a complex concept that involves varied beliefs, values, and practices of a mass of people held together by a thread of commonality of purpose and motivation reflected in the stories they tell and dreams they share with each other. This book explores some of those complexities and unpacks the inner meaning of Dharma, which is generally understood as a sustainable way of community living.

The author emphasizes that Dharma is a way of thinking, feeling, and doing that promotes collective well-being.

There are many misconceptions about Hindu Dharma, especially in the West and even among educated Hindu youth: that Dharma ideals are archaic, that it supports rigid caste hierarchies, that it negates the existence of an objective world and is indifferent to worldly activities and material accomplishments. That the highest ideal of Dharma, which is moksha, is extinction of self and agency. That it is indifferent to women's rights and their leadership aspirations. That Hindus are idol worshippers. That they believe in many gods and a plurality of

divinities. That they are confused about the right path to God and hence offer a mishmash of paths that bewilders and distracts a serious seeker of truth. The Hindu ideal of radical oneness (Advaita) and universal love (ahimsa) is impractical in the daily life of strife, struggle, and choice making. That the idea that humans are immortal privileges humans compared to other life forms. The contention that human souls are immortal is against our common experience of finitude and mortality, etc., etc.

Dr. Anup takes up all those questions head on and addresses all such misconceptions about Hindu Dharma with a rare conviction and offers simple and credible answers, quoting Hindu scriptures and modern scientific discoveries. The author maintains that the true spirit of Hindu Dharma is pluralistic, inclusive, and progressive. That many Gods are only one God speaking through many masks, manifesting through many mediums, experiencing Himself in manifold ways. Life is immortal, but its expressions flower and fade. Many paths to God take into account the differences in individual temperament and tastes, so that all can start their journey from wherever they are. This is the Hindu ideal of spiritual democracy that circumvents institutional hegemony.

The spiritual practitioner in Dr. Anup doesn't see any contradiction between the divergent philosophical positions held by different Hindu masters. He sees Sankara (Advaita), Ramanuja (Visishtadvaita), and Madhva (Dvaita) addressing different levels of seekers and highlighting different aspects of the devotee/Deity relationship. They are all parts of a grand ensemble.

The author devotes considerable time to explaining the practical aspects of the four yogas — karma, bhakti, raja, and jnana — and their complementarity in spiritual life. He doesn't hesitate to express his discomfort with predatory proselytizing religions, whose champions

wait for weak moments in human life like disease, death, or deprivation.

The author's analysis of the Gayatri Mantra, AUM, and the four Mahavakyas (wisdom statements) is deep and profound.

Dr. Anup, who has gone through serious trials and severe physical pain in life, is a firm believer in the power of prayers, both individual and collective. He is basically a no-holds-barred devotee — helpless and childlike.

This book anchors its wisdom in the Bhagavad Gita and offers a bird's-eye view of this immortal text, picking nuggets from this vast treasure chest of Hindu wisdom.

I wholeheartedly recommend this book for the beginner as an entry point to the vast literature on Hindu Dharma, and also for experts to refresh their scholarship in the context of the ever-changing knowledge landscape.

A must-read for all spiritual seekers, regardless of their respective religious persuasions.

As I was completing this note, I got a call from Dr. Raju, Anup's close friend, that Dr. Anup had breathed his last after a prolonged battle with cancer.

I was stunned, though it was expected.

My salutations to this brave warrior of Truth, who loved God and all God's children.

SWAMI BODHANANDA SARASVATI

Chairman, Sambodh Foundation INDIA & The Sambodh Society Inc. USA

*The Sambodh Society Inc & Sambodh Center for Human Excellence,
Michigan*

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SECTION I

*T*his section has nine chapters

In the first nine chapters, you will learn what Hinduism is and why it calls itself the eternal way. You will see that it is an open religion — more like an open-source project than a franchise — with room for devotees, meditators, karma yogis, intellectuals, and even atheists. You will know people from every background who call themselves Hindu, from a Jewish-born priest in Sydney to a young graduate in Iowa who doesn't call it anything at all.

You will learn that many Hindu traditions believe in one God experienced in many forms, that the soul is immortal, that you are not a sinner but a spark of the divine, and that worship is an invitation. You will be introduced to dharma — the moral foundation that sustains everything — and you will know that the sacred images in Hindu temples are not idols but doorways to the infinite.

If you close the book after section I, you will already know more about Hinduism than most people in the world. You will know enough to hold a meaningful conversation with any Hindu in your life — your spouse, your friend, your neighbor, your colleague, your child. You will know enough to walk into a temple without feeling lost, to hear a Sanskrit verse without feeling excluded, and to answer the question "What do Hindus believe?" with clarity and confidence.

If the foundation stirs something in you — curiosity, recognition, or even a single question you didn't have before — I invite you to keep going.

As the Gita promises:

*"Even a little practice of this dharma saves one from great fear." —
(Bhagavad Gita 2.40)*

Much more in the subsequent sections.

Chapter 1

Definitions:

Open Religion,

Who is a Hindu?

Practicing

Hinduism,

What is

Hinduism,

Different

Paths to

Spirituality

An Open Religion

Hinduism is an open religion. Its teachings can be adapted to the needs of each era, which is one reason it has endured for thousands of years. Think of Hinduism less like a franchise with a single rulebook and more like an open-source project — the core code holds, but communities around the world adapt the practice to their time, place, and needs. No single authority controls it. Anyone can contribute. And the result, far from chaos, has been a living tradition that keeps renewing itself.

Since there is no single founder or single book, you can follow any of the holy books, learn from any guru or sage, and adapt practices within the broad umbrella of Hinduism's core principles. There is room for a wide range of beliefs and practices.

What does this openness look like in real life? A doctor in Texas might center their practice around reading and reflecting on the Bhagavad Gita most evenings at home. Her relatives in Karnataka, India, might visit the temple daily, offer fruits and flowers, and participate in rituals. A college student in New Jersey might practice yoga and meditation without ever entering a temple. A grandmother in Mumbai might spend her mornings chanting the thousand names of God Vishnu along with a YouTube recitation by a famous singer. A busy professional might listen to meditative devotional Krishna songs on the way to work. All of them are fully Hindu — no one is doing it wrong.

This results in great flexibility. That is why we see many different ways of practicing the religion in different parts of India and different parts of the world. Despite these differences, there are very few conflicts among Hindus over theology. There are many books, many

saints, many institutions, and many variations in practice — yet there is understanding, unity, and a sense of oneness. In fact, when families move, they often adopt new ways of practicing from their surroundings. A family from Tamil Nadu, India that moves to Karnataka, India might start celebrating Ganesha Chaturthi — a joyful festival honoring the elephant-headed remover of obstacles — right in their home.

The Rig Veda, one of Hinduism's oldest texts, captures this beautifully: "Truth is one; the wise call it by many names."

Who Is A Hindu?

Who is a Hindu? It's a surprisingly hard question to answer — precisely because Hinduism has no single book, no single founder, and no central authority deciding who's in or out. At its broadest, a Hindu is someone who identifies with the tradition and embraces its core principles.

Most Hindus share some combination of these beliefs (not exhaustive), though no one is required to hold all of them:

- There is one Supreme God, who may be understood and worshipped in many forms — or without any form at all.
- The divine is present in everything and everyone.
- The life force ('Atma') is immortal and moves through cycles of rebirth.
- One should perform one's duties wholeheartedly without worrying about the results. (This idea, called *nishkama karma**, is explored in a later chapter.)*

- Being true to one's nature ('Swabhava') and one's responsibility ('Swadharma').
- There are multiple paths to the divine — devotion, selfless action, meditation, and knowledge.

What's remarkable is that even atheists can be Hindu, if they follow the ethical and philosophical framework. No belief in God is required.

Hindus respect other faiths and do not condemn those who believe differently. There is no tradition of missionary conversion in Hinduism. Hindus are widely known for their tolerance and acceptance of differences across cultures.

Since there is no tradition of conversion, there is no official process for becoming a Hindu. There is no formal ceremony required. One can simply choose to identify as Hindu and begin practicing in whatever way feels right. This is one of the most welcoming — and most surprising — things about the tradition.

And people from all backgrounds have done exactly that. Consider Rami Sivan, born in South Africa to a Jewish mother and Christian father, baptized as a Christian, who embraced Hinduism at the age of fifteen. He went on to study Yoga-Vedanta philosophy, Sanskrit, and Vedic ritual at traditional learning centers across India. Today, he is an ordained Hindu priest (Acharya) in Sydney, Australia — formally inducted into the South Indian Srivaishnava lineage — where he has served the Hindu community for over forty years, conducting ceremonies, counseling families, and teaching philosophy. He is also a registered nurse, living what the Gita would call karma yoga — the path of selfless service.

Or consider Devala Rees (now Devala Gupta), an American raised in Fairfield, Iowa — not of Indian descent, yet Hindu from birth. Both of his parents were practicing Hindus. He became a disciple of

the renowned spiritual teacher Mata Amritanandamayi at the age of twelve and spent nearly two decades learning from traditional Hindu teachers, including the priest of his local temple. Today he works as an Educational Researcher at the Hindu American Foundation in Chicago, writing and teaching about Hinduism with a depth of knowledge that would be the envy of many born into the tradition. His story is a living reminder: Hinduism belongs to anyone who sincerely seeks it.

These are not exceptions. Across the United States, Australia, Europe, Africa and Latin America, people of every ethnicity and background are finding their way to Hindu practice — some through marriage, some through yoga, some through reading the Gita, and some simply because the philosophy resonated with something they already felt to be true. Hinduism has room for all of them.

Practicing Hinduism in Day-to-Day Life

Hinduism is not something you practice only in a temple or prayer room. It is designed to be lived — in your home, your workplace, and your relationships. There are four paths, and most Hindus blend them in varying degrees rather than choosing just one.

Devotion in daily life means carrying love beyond the prayer room. When you treat a colleague with genuine kindness, when you listen to a friend with your full attention, when you care for an aging parent — you are practicing devotion. When I touch each patient's feet to look for swelling, I am seeking blessings from them. When I agree to take care of a patient whom nobody in the city wants to accept, I am practicing devotion. When I non-judgmentally take care of patients who may have been incarcerated for years in the past, I am practicing devotion. The idea is simple: see the divine in every person

you encounter, and let that shape how you treat them. You don't need a temple for this. Your kitchen table, your office, your morning commute — these all become places of practice.

Selfless action (karma yoga) in daily life means doing your work skillfully and wholeheartedly, treating it as a form of service rather than just a way to earn a paycheck. A doctor treating patients as though she is serving God — seeing the divine in every person on her examination table. A teacher preparing a lesson with the same care he would bring to a sacred offering. A software engineer writing clean code not for praise, but because doing good work is its own purpose. This path turns every workday into a spiritual practice — and it is available to anyone, regardless of profession or belief.

Focused mind (yoga) in daily life is not about doing poses on a mat — it is about bringing total presence to whatever you are doing. When you are so absorbed in cooking a meal, writing a report, or playing with your child that you lose track of time, that focused state is a form of yoga. The ancient yogic tradition describes ethical practices (called *yamas* and *niyamas*) — guidelines for how to live, such as truthfulness, non-harm, and contentment — that shape daily behavior. (These are explored in the chapter on Yoga.) At its highest level, this path leads to *samadhi* — a state of complete absorption where the boundary between you and your activity dissolves. But it begins with something as simple as giving your full, undivided attention to the task in front of you.

Knowledge (jnana) in daily life means recognizing that at the deepest level, every person — including you — carries a spark of the divine. It is the practice of looking past surface differences and seeing the same consciousness in your neighbor, your rival, and your own reflection. This doesn't require belief in a particular God. It requires

a shift in perspective: from "I am separate" to "I am connected to everything."

If spirituality and daily life are kept separate, spirituality becomes merely academic — interesting to think about, but disconnected from the life you actually live. Hinduism invites you to close that gap. You don't have to wait for an afterlife to experience the divine. You can experience it today, right now, in how you love, how you work, how you pay attention, and how you see the people around you.

In fact, Hinduism has always taught that the divine is closest to us in the people we encounter every day. The Taittiriya Upanishad, a sacred book, captures this in one of Hinduism's most beloved teachings:

Treat your mother as God (Matru Devo Bhava), treat your father as God (Pitru Devo Bhava), treat your teacher as God (Acharya Devo Bhava), treat your guest as God (Atithi Devo Bhava).

This is practicing Hinduism in daily life. Not in some distant heaven. Not in a future rebirth. Right here, in how you treat the people at your dinner table.

If this feels like a lot, here is the good news. You don't have to master all four paths tomorrow. The Bhagavad Gita itself offers this reassurance:

"Even a little practice of this dharma saves one from great fear."
[Svalpam apyasya dharmasya trāyate mahato bhayāt (Gita 2.40)]

Start with one small thing. This week, try one of these:

- Before a meeting or a difficult conversation, pause for three breaths and silently acknowledge the person in front of you as worthy of respect.
- Do one task today — washing dishes, answering an email, driving your child to school — with your complete, undivided attention. No phone. No mental multitasking. Just full

presence.

- At the end of the day, think of one person who helped you and silently offer them gratitude — a teacher, a parent, a friend, a stranger.

That's it. That is practicing Hinduism. The Gita promises that even this much matters.

What Is Hinduism?

Hinduism is believed to have existed since the earliest human civilizations, which is why its traditional name is Sanatana Dharma — 'the eternal way.' It is one of the world's oldest continuously practiced religious traditions. It is the third largest, with over a billion followers worldwide. Most live in India and neighboring countries like Nepal, Bhutan, Burma, Indonesia, Sri Lanka, Mauritius and Malaysia.

Hinduism is not a one-book religion. There are many holy books for Hindus. Bhagavad Gita ('Divine Song'), is one of its most beloved texts. Traditional Hindu chronology places the events of the Mahabharata several millennia BCE, while modern scholars generally date the composition of the Bhagavad Gita to the last few centuries BCE. There are many interpretations of these books written in an attempt to apply the concepts to the current world. Hinduism is also not a one-man religion. There is no single founder, just as there is no single founder of mathematics or physics.

Because the religion is very ancient, its teachings were transmitted through generations by oral tradition before the practice of writing on palm leaves and then paper evolved. Because the religion believes in divinity in everybody, many experts have taught and interpreted the

teachings depending upon the circumstances. Another reason for ongoing interpretation is that some scriptures were written as aphorisms and need commentary for people to understand. Such interpretations have been welcomed and appreciated by the broader community. This has helped the religion stay eternally current.

Swami Vivekananda, in his famous speech at the World Parliament of Religions on September 11, 1893, offered a vivid description of Hinduism. Here are two excerpts:

- "I am proud to belong to a religion which has taught the world both tolerance and universal acceptance. We believe not only in universal toleration, but we accept all religions as true."
- "As the different streams having their sources in different places all mingle their water in the sea, so, O Lord, the different paths which men take through different tendencies, various though they appear, crooked or straight, all lead to Thee."

Different Paths to Spirituality in Hinduism:

There are different ways of practicing Hinduism. Three of them are most common:

1. Theistic or faith-based or devotion-based practice. This is also how most of the Western religions are practiced too.
2. Non-theistic 'self-inquiry' or experience-based practice.
3. Non-theistic knowledge-based practice, rooted in the understanding that 'the self is divine.'

Each of these paths is explored in the chapters ahead.

A large portion of Hindus believe in dualism, where a person is devoted to and in love with an almighty God, and the devotees request and pray for healing and betterment of life. These theistic approaches emphasize a transcendent God distinct from the individual. Devotees relate to God through faith, prayer, surrender, and love. Christianity, Judaism, and Islam are generally theistic traditions in which God is understood as distinct from the individual.

Other Indian traditions—including Buddhism, Jainism, and Sikhism—also developed distinctive approaches to spiritual practice and liberation, although their understandings of God, self, soul, and ultimate reality differ significantly from one another and from Hindu traditions.

There are **non-theistic or 'self-inquiry' based** ways of practicing religion by some sects of Hinduism. They are based on self-enquiry and the experience of the divine within the self. The advantage is that 'self' is a fact and cannot be questioned. It is experiential; hence, it is available today, and one cannot question it if one experiences it. The only problem is that not many people might experience it. Hence, the non-experiencer still has to live with the hope that someday he/she will experience 'it'.

There is a third way, **Non-duality**, a large part of Hinduism. This is an experience of 'infinite consciousness is Brahman/God', 'you are that divine reality', or 'I am that divine reality.' It has shades of duality with devotion, love, and faith leading to self-inquiry and self-experience, leading to the knowledge and experience of 'I am the divine reality', and 'I am part of infinite consciousness, Brahman.' This is also experiential and is available in this life, right now, to all of us. One does not have to wait to die and have an after-life experience of visiting heaven. Hence, once you know the infinite consciousness within you,

you have it, and it cannot be questioned. It is less experience-based and more knowledge-based and, hence, is available to those open to acquiring this knowledge.

Non-duality is the knowledge that real 'I' is an inseparable part of the 'Infinite Consciousness' who is addressed as Brahman or God or Infinity just like how a wave is inseparable from the ocean, clay is inseparable from the clay-pot and gold is inseparable from the golden necklace. It is as true as the water molecule in the wave or the ocean and as true as the unchanging truth of the clay-pot is made entirely of clay. While the pot can change shapes and forms, clay will always be clay. It is as true as the gold in the ornaments, no matter what shape it takes. I have admitted to this belief unapologetically throughout the book and in my real life.

Different shades of 'non-dualism' in secular life: Just like how God and I are inseparable, 'infinity excellence' and 'humanistic performance' can be inseparable in secular life. This is especially expressed in our quest of seeking excellence in life. We see this in people who are unveiling excellence in their lives. We see this in people who profess excellence. We see such different shades of 'non-duality' in the teachings of legendary business leaders, legendary coaches like Phil Jackson, and legends in different fields of life. The teachings like, 'unleash the power within' by Tony Robbins, 'go and express yourself', 'do your best', 'go and enjoy the game', 'be yourself' are some such examples. 'Power of now' (of Eckhart Tolle fame), 'power of ONE', 'Ik Onkar', and 'Inner Engineering' are all different shades of 'non-duality' written thousands of years ago in the Upanishads, the ancient Hindu texts percolating in various names to suit today's consumer.

"If there is God, I must see God!"

"Religion is not a matter of belief; it is a matter of experience."

-Swami Vivekananda

Chapter 2

Hinduism: Inclusive, Pluralistic, and Progressive

All-inclusive and pluralistic

Hinduism makes room for an extraordinary range of spiritual expression. If you want to worship God through sacred images (murtis) — touching, seeing, and speaking to the divine — you can. If you see God in your mother, father, teacher, or guest, that is honored. If you seek God through self-knowledge and inner experience, that path is here. If you are an atheist who simply believes in doing good work as a fulfilling practice, Hinduism considers that a valid spiritual path too. If you believe God is in heaven and can only be known after death, Hinduism accepts that. And if you simply want to be in the eternal loving company of God without seeking heaven or liberation, that is welcomed as well.

Few traditions in the world offer this range. Hinduism doesn't ask you to choose one door. It opens all of them and lets you walk through whichever one calls to you.

For those who want to follow the path of meditation with or without seeking God, Hinduism has a valid path for such practitioners too.

Progressive

Hinduism is one of the few major world religions that worships God in feminine form. Goddess Durga is revered as the all-powerful divine by millions of Hindus, and the Devi Sukta — one of the most ancient Hindu hymns — celebrates the Supreme Feminine. This is not a minor tradition within Hinduism; it is central.

Hindu scriptures also include characters who transcend conventional gender categories. In the Mahabharata, the warrior Shikhandi plays a pivotal role in the climactic battle — a character whose gender identity defies simple classification. These stories have existed for thousands of years, long before modern conversations about gender and identity.

On the environment, Hindu teachings emphasize moderation in consumption and warn against hoarding. The idea that all of nature is sacred — rivers, trees, mountains, animals — runs throughout the tradition, making environmental stewardship not a modern add-on but an ancient principle.

This is not just ancient history. Hindu organizations are putting these principles into practice around the world today. The ISHA Foundation's "Rally for Rivers" campaign has mobilized millions to protect India's depleting rivers — treating waterways not as resources to exploit but as sacred living systems to preserve. The Art of Living Foundation brings meditation and mental health programs into

prisons, offering inmates tools for inner transformation regardless of their faith or background. ISKCON temples across the United States and around the world serve free vegetarian meals (prasadam) to anyone who walks through the door — no questions asked about caste, religion, or ability to pay — much like the langar tradition in Sikh Gurudwaras.

In fact, that last example illustrates something important: Hinduism continues to evolve and learn from other faiths. The spirit of community service embodied in the Sikh langar has inspired Hindu organizations to expand their own traditions of feeding the hungry. This willingness to learn — rather than compete — is itself a form of progressiveness that sets Hinduism apart.

A tradition of intellectual inquiry

Hinduism has a long tradition of intellectual inquiry that extends well beyond theology. Ancient Hindu texts include sophisticated works on medicine (Ayurveda), mathematics, astronomy, grammar, metallurgy, and law.

Some of these achievements are physically visible today. The iron pillar of Delhi, constructed by Chandragupta II (375-415CE), still stands without significant rusting — a feat of metallurgy that modern scientists have studied with admiration. The massive temples of South India, built centuries before modern engineering tools, demonstrate extraordinary knowledge of architecture and structural design.

Hindu cosmology also contains ideas that resonate with modern science in striking ways. The Sanskrit term *Bhoo-Gola* literally means ‘earth-sphere’ and reflects an ancient Indian understanding of the Earth as spherical. Some scholars have noted an intriguing parallel between the ten incarnations of Vishnu, which progress from aquatic

life to more complex beings — and the general pattern of biological Darwinian evolution, though this is a retrospective observation rather than a claim of ancient scientific knowledge. God Vishnu's 10 incarnations were in the form of (1) Fish (Matsya), (2) Tortoise (Koorma), (3) Mammal (Varaaha = The Wild Boar), (4) Man-Lion with lion face with human body (Narasimha), (5) Dwarf man (Vaamana), (6) Ancient angry man (Parushurama), (7) Perfect man who experiences life problems (Shri Rama) like any human being, (8) The Statesman (Shri Krishna), (9) Some mention Krishna's brother Bala Rama as the ninth incarnation and others consider Buddha, 'The Enlightened One' as the ninth incarnation and (10) The Mighty Warrior (Kalki, who is yet to come!).

The word avatar itself has entered the English language — a reminder that Hindu ideas continue to influence global culture in ways most people don't realize.

Scientific:

Modern readers have sometimes drawn parallels between descriptions in Hindu texts and later scientific or technological developments—for example, the Hanuman Chalisa and the Earth–Sun distance, astras and modern weapons, the Pushpaka Vimana and aircraft, and unusual birth narratives and assisted reproduction. These are interesting modern interpretations rather than evidence that the ancient texts described these technologies in the modern scientific sense.

Chapter 3

Holy Books

Hinduism has a vast library of sacred texts spanning thousands of years. If that sounds overwhelming, here is the good news: you don't need to read them all. Think of the scriptures as a family tree — the Vedas are the ancient roots, the Upanishads distill their philosophical essence, the great epics bring the teachings to life through story, and the Bhagavad Gita is the most accessible summary of it all. Most Hindus start — and many stay — with the Gita.

The Vedas

The Vedas are the oldest and most revered texts in Hinduism — a vast collection of hymns, prayers, philosophical insights, and ritual instructions composed in Sanskrit. There are four: the Rig Veda, Sama Veda, Yajur Veda, and Atharva Veda. The Vedas were transmitted orally for centuries before being written down — the Sanskrit word *Shruti* ('that which is heard') reflects this origin.

At their heart, the Vedas teach a set of ideas that have shaped Hindu thought ever since:

- There is an infinite, unchanging reality beneath the finite, changing world.
- This infinite being lies at the core of every human being — also called the soul.

- The purpose of life is to discover and experience this reality, through meditation, prayer, self-discipline, and love.

- Ego and excessive attachment are the biggest obstacles to spiritual awakening.

- Love, kindness, forgiveness, humility, service, and compassion are the highest virtues.

These five ideas run like a thread through every Hindu scripture that follows.

The Upanishads

The Upanishads are the philosophical heart of the Vedas — exploring the nature of reality, the self, and the divine through dialogue, metaphor, and inquiry. There are over 200, but ten principal Upanishads form the core of Hindu philosophical study. If the Vedas are the ocean, the Upanishads are the distilled essence. Many of the ideas you'll encounter throughout this book — the divinity of the self, the oneness of all existence, the paths to liberation — come directly from the Upanishads.

The Great Epics (Itihasas)

The Itihasas ('thus it happened') are Hinduism's great epic narratives — sweeping stories that bring the abstract teachings of the Upanishads to life through vivid characters, moral dilemmas, and battles between good and evil. The two most important are the Ramayana and the Mahabharata.

Ramayana

The Ramayana tells the story of Lord Rama — a noble prince exiled from his kingdom — and his journey to rescue his wife Sita from the demon king Ravana, aided by the devoted Hanuman. But it is far more than an adventure story. Rama is portrayed as the ideal human being: ethical, dutiful, and compassionate, even as he faces the kinds of loss, betrayal, and hardship that any person might encounter. The Ramayana has been adapted into countless forms of art, literature, dance, and theater across Asia, and remains one of the most beloved stories in the world.

Mahabharata

The Mahabharata is the longest epic poem ever written — more than ten times the length of the Iliad and Odyssey combined. It tells the story of a royal family torn apart by rivalry: the righteous Pandava brothers pitted against their treacherous Kaurava cousins. Lord Krishna aids the Pandavas, and on the eve of the climactic battle, the warrior Arjuna finds himself paralyzed by doubt — he is being asked to fight against his own teachers, uncles, and cousins. Krishna's response, delivered right there on the battlefield, unfolds into one of the most profound spiritual dialogues ever recorded. That dialogue is the Bhagavad Gita — the 'Song of God.'

Devi Mahatmyam and Bhagavatam

The Devi Mahatmyam (also known as Durga Saptashati) tells a powerful story: when evil threatened to overwhelm the world, the gods pooled all of their powers into a single, supreme Goddess — Devi — who rose to defeat the demons and restore righteousness. It is one of the most important texts in the Shakta tradition, which worships the

divine feminine as the ultimate reality. For many Hindus, particularly during the festival of Navaratri, this text is recited daily.

The Bhagavatam (or Srimad Bhagavatam) is a treasury of stories about Lord Vishnu and his incarnations. It is the heart of the Bhakti (devotion) tradition and explores how the divine can be experienced through many forms of relationship — as the mischievous child Krishna stealing butter, as a wise teacher, as a loyal friend, as a protector against evil, and as the beloved companion of the devotees of Vrindavan. This text opened the door to one of Hinduism's richest traditions: experiencing the divine through intimate human emotions like love, tenderness, and play.

The Bhagavad Gita

The Bhagavad Gita — known simply as 'the Gita' — is one of the most widely read and influential Hindu scriptures. In the section of the Mahabharata, it is the dialogue between Lord Krishna and the warrior Arjuna on the eve of a great battle. Arjuna is paralyzed by doubt: how can he fight against his own family? Krishna's response unfolds into a complete guide to living — covering duty, selfless action, meditation, devotion, knowledge, and the nature of the self.

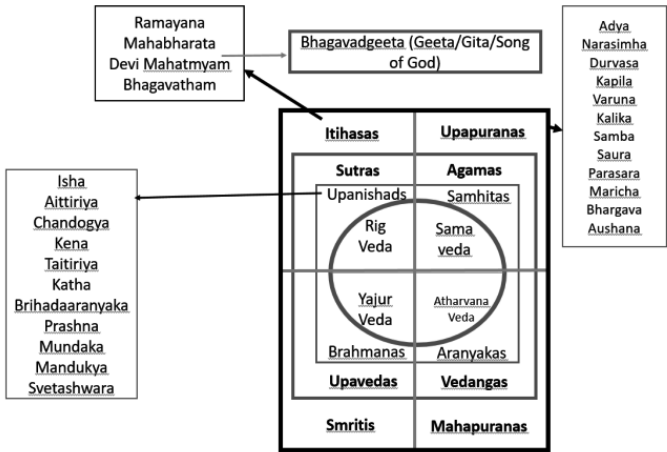
The Gita teaches that there are multiple paths to the divine, and that the path of action (Karma Yoga) — doing one's duty skillfully, as an offering, without attachment to the result — is available to everyone, including those leading an ordinary worldly life. It addresses how to solve problems, how to face fear, how to work with integrity, how to eat, how to meditate, and how to find peace in the midst of chaos. It is, in the truest sense, a practical handbook for navigating life's toughest decisions — and its teachings remain strikingly relevant today.

Most of the Gita's teachings come directly from the Upanishads, making it the most accessible entry point into Hindu philosophy. If you read only one Hindu scripture in your life, make it the Gita.

Other important texts

Beyond these central texts, Hinduism has an extensive body of specialized literature. The Yoga Sutras of Sage Patanjali lay out the theory and practice of yoga in concise aphorisms. The Brahma Sutras offer a systematic summary of Vedantic philosophy. The Upavedas include works on medicine (Ayurveda), economics (Artha Shastra), and other practical sciences. Commentaries on each of these have been written and rewritten by scholars and saints across the centuries — and one is free to follow any of them.

What unites all of these texts is a shared promise: the divine can be experienced in this life, in this world — not only as an afterlife hope, but as a living reality available right now. And they share a recurring theme: whenever righteousness declines in the world, the divine manifests in some form to restore it. That belief — that the universe bends toward justice, and that help will come — runs through every layer of Hindu scripture.



Holy Books (The Devi Mahatmyam and Bhagavatam are discussed here alongside the Itihasas, although they belong to the Purana tradition.)

Chapter 4

Life Is Immortal

"Ye Children of Immortal Bliss!" — Swami Vivekananda

One of Hinduism's most powerful and comforting teachings is this: you are not your body, mind, or intellect. The physical body is born, ages, and eventually wears out — but the true self, the soul (Atman), is immortal. It was never born, and it will never die. The body is like a garment: when it becomes old and worn, it is set aside, and the soul moves on.

This is not a metaphor the tradition takes lightly. It is the foundation of how Hindus understand life, death, and everything in between. And it changes everything — because if the real "you" cannot be destroyed, then there is nothing to ultimately fear. This is why Swami Vivekananda addressed audiences not as sinners or mortals, but as "Children of Immortal Bliss."

What does this mean in practice?

This belief transforms how you face the hardest moments of life. For those who are seriously ill, it offers a ground to stand on — the knowledge that no disease can touch the true self. For families grieving a loss, it reframes death not as an ending but as a transition — a reason to celebrate a life rather than only mourn its absence. For anyone living

through difficult times, it is a reminder that the real self is immortal, no matter what happens to the body or the circumstances around it.

It also frees you to live more fully. When the fear of death loosens its grip, you can perform your duties to yourself, your family, and the world with a steadier hand. You can take risks in pursuit of what matters. You can face uncertainty with a kind of peace that doesn't depend on everything going well.

A personal note:

When I was diagnosed with cancer at the age of 41, this teaching was not an abstraction — it was the ground I stood on. The knowledge that my true self could not be destroyed by any disease gave me the courage to face treatment, to keep working, and to eventually write this book. I am alive today because of my doctors — but I was at peace because of this teaching. For those who wish to explore this idea more deeply, my book *The Power of Infinity* goes into greater detail about how the concept of an infinite, immortal self can be a source of strength, clarity, and inner peace in daily life. Later, when I was diagnosed with dangerous cancer, it gives me peace to know that my true self is immortal. It gives me comfort in knowing that everybody's body is walking towards and negotiating with the God of death.

Rebirth and liberation

Many Hindu traditions teach that the soul moves through many lives — being born, living, dying, and being born again in a cycle called *samsara*. The circumstances of each life are shaped by the actions (*karma*) of previous lives. The ultimate goal, shared across Hindu traditions though understood differently by each, is liberation (*moksha*)

— the point at which the soul is freed from this cycle entirely. Some traditions describe this as merging with God; others as realizing that the self was never separate from the divine to begin with. But all agree: liberation is possible, and it is the highest purpose of human life.

Other religions that originated in India — Buddhism, Jainism, and Sikhism — also share the belief in rebirth, though each tradition understands its mechanics and goal somewhat differently. The idea of an immortal soul journeying through many lives is one of the great contributions of Indian spiritual thought to the world.

The Bhagavad Gita captures this teaching in one of its most famous and beautiful verses:

"As a person sheds worn-out garments and puts on new ones, so the soul sheds worn-out bodies and takes on new ones." — Bhagavad Gita 2.22

Chapter 5

How Many Gods Are There In Hinduism? Which God should be worshipped?

One God, many forms

This is probably the most common question people ask about Hinduism — and the answer surprises most people. Many Hindu traditions believe in one Supreme God, called Brahman. One. Not thousands.

Then why do we see so many deities — Brahma (the creator), Vishnu (the preserver), Shiva (the transformer), Lakshmi (goddess of prosperity), Saraswati (goddess of knowledge), and many more? Because many Hindu traditions teach that the one God can be experienced in

many forms — just as water is the same substance whether you call it water, jal, pani, or aqua. The different deities are not separate gods competing with one another. They are different expressions of the same infinite reality, each one offering a different way to connect with the divine.

Hinduism makes a beautiful distinction here. You can worship God with attributes — a name, a form, a face you can see, touch, and speak to. This is called Saguna Brahman ('God with attributes'). Or you can worship God without any form at all — the formless, infinite, all-pervading consciousness. This is called Nirguna Brahman ('God beyond attributes'). Both are valid. Both are celebrated. And many Hindus move between the two depending on the moment.

In Hinduism, God is both immanent (present right here, in everything) and transcendent (beyond all form and comprehension). That is a rare and powerful combination.

Which form should you worship?

The answer is simple: whichever form you feel most connected to. There is no wrong choice. Personally, I feel drawn to Mother Goddess Durga and Lord Hanuman — but your connection may be entirely different, and that is as it should be.

What makes Hinduism distinctive is that you can turn to different forms of God for different situations — not because the gods are separate beings with separate departments, but because focusing on a particular quality of the divine helps you access that quality within yourself:

- Nervous before an exam, interview, or negotiation? Invoke Goddess Saraswati, the embodiment of knowledge, clarity, and wisdom.

- Worried about your finances or starting a new venture? Turn to Goddess Lakshmi, the goddess of prosperity and abundance.

- Feeling physically weak or facing a health crisis? Invoke Goddess Shakti (Devi) or Lord Hanuman — both are epitomes of strength and healing. Hanuman is known for carrying an entire mountain of medicinal herbs to save the life of Lakshmana, Lord Rama's brother.

- Moving into a new home? Pray to Lord Ganesha, the remover of obstacles, for domestic harmony and new beginnings.

- Facing cancer or serious illness? When I am in pain, I invoke Goddess Durga — in her fierce Kali form, who destroyed the demon 'Raktabijasura' without allowing a single drop of his blood to proliferate — and Lord Hanuman, who brought Lakshmana back to life. These are not abstract symbols to me. They are sources of real strength.

Other ways to connect

Not everyone connects through images and forms — and Hinduism makes room for that too.

Some people prefer chanting the names of God. It is believed that this is the simplest form of worship in the current era. A common practice is to chant the thousand names of Lord Vishnu or Goddess Durga — a devotion that takes about thirty minutes and can be done anywhere, even on your morning commute.

Some don't feel comfortable worshipping a God they have not seen, but they feel a deep connection to a teacher (guru) or a saint. That is honored too. The tradition teaches: see your mother as God, your father as God, your teacher as God, your guest as God*.

I would add one more: see your friends as God (Mitr Devo Bhava). I made this up! But it is deeply true for those of us who moved far

from our families for career or life reasons and have been blessed with friends who became family.

And some people don't believe in any form or shape of God at all. That is perfectly fine. One can believe in the formless God or even be an atheist and still live as a Hindu, following the ethical and philosophical framework without worshipping any deity. Hinduism makes room for this too.

Many routes, one destination

Think of it this way: just as there are many different routes to travel from Dallas to Mumbai — some direct, some scenic, some faster, some slower — there are many routes to experience the divine. Some worship God with attributes. Some worship God without attributes. Some combine both. The destination is the same.

Across all faiths and all cultures, human beings have found ways to make the divine tangible — through images, symbols, sacred spaces, music, and ritual. Hinduism simply makes this practice explicit and celebrates it as a privilege rather than a limitation. The ability to see God, touch God, speak to God, and experience God in this life — not just as a distant hope for the afterlife — is one of Hinduism's most distinctive and joyful gifts.

Worshipping God with attributes does not limit God. Worshipping God without attributes does not make God distant. Embracing both — experiencing the divine as both transcendent and immanent, both beyond all form and present in every form — makes God truly infinite. Hinduism gives us the opportunity to experience both, in this life, right now.

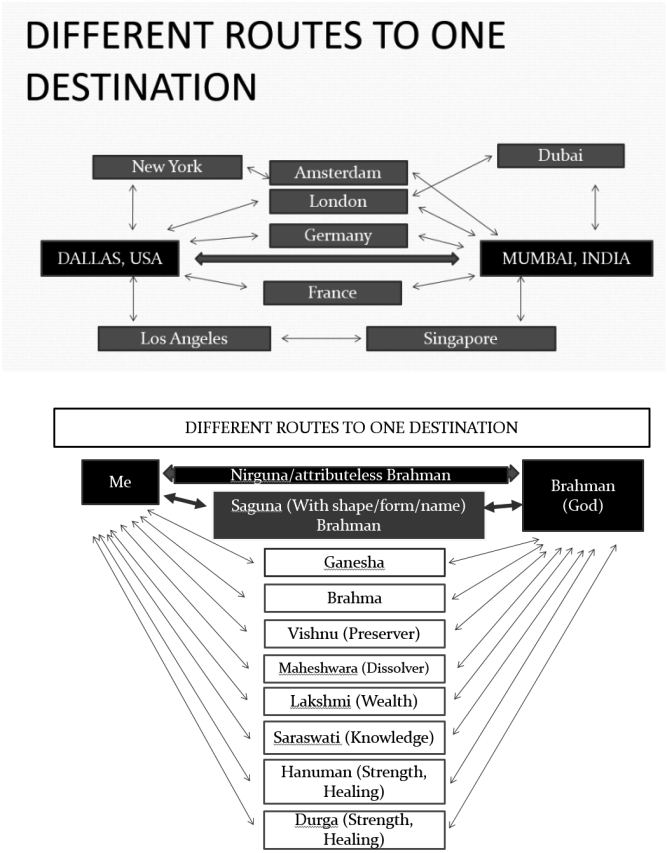


Figure: Just like there are different routes to go from Dallas to Mumbai, there are different routes to God (Brahman), some worship God with attributes and some worship God without attributes. Those who wish to experience God with their senses prefer to worship God with attributes. Many prefer to worship God without attributes. But many people find it hard to worship God without attributes and choose to worship God with attributes.

Worshipping God without attributes alone limits God as a transcendental God. It limits the application of God to very few people

who get that transcendental experience or simply as a hope of an after death 'experience'. Believing God only with attributes also limits the expression of God to certain space and time. Believing God both as transcendental and immanent experience makes God truly omniscient and 'Godly'. Hinduism gives us that opportunity to experience both transcendental and immanent God in this life.

In fact, every religion worships God with attributes in one form or another. Even many sections of Hinduism that are against 'idol worship', carry pendants of inanimate signs of God. There are idols of Buddha everywhere in Hindu, Buddhist and other households and there are huge idols of Buddha in many holy Buddhist places. There are huge idols of Mahaveera in holy Jain places. Sikhs worship in front of the Holy Book, Guru Granth Saheb. Christians wear the Holy Cross with the 'idol' of Jesus Christ in it with reverence. Muslims worship multiple times a day facing one direction and make it a mission to visit Mecca at least once in their lifetime as though God lives there. My point is worshipping God with attributes makes it easier for the devotees and it is a privilege to experience God in this life.

Chapter 6

Do We Need to Worship God? If So How Often?

The short answer: It is a personal choice — there's no set schedule and it is not necessary if you do not wish to worship.

This may surprise people accustomed to traditions with mandatory weekly services or daily prayers. In Hinduism, there is no required frequency of worship. There is no commandment that says you must pray a certain number of times per day or attend a temple every week. Worship is encouraged, valued, and celebrated — but it is not the only way to experience God, and it is never forced.

As we've explored in earlier chapters, worship (Bhakti Yoga) is just one path among several. Selfless action, meditation, and the pursuit of knowledge are equally valid ways of connecting with the divine. You can be a fully practicing Hindu without ever chanting a single mantra — if you are living your life with integrity, awareness, and service to others, you are already on the path.

But if you do worship — here's how

For those who are drawn to worship, Hinduism offers a rich variety of forms. You can contemplate God silently — simply sitting with the awareness of the divine. You can recite holy verses, known as mantra or japa. You can sing devotional songs (bhajans), dance to devotional music, or play musical instruments as an offering. You can perform a structured prayer ritual (puja) at a home altar or in a temple. If you have the habit of worshipping, it is reasonable and beneficial to do so on a regular basis — daily, if possible.

There is also a practical dimension to this. Contemplation and prayer are forms of meditation, and meditation is one of the most well-studied methods of stress relief. Since stress is a contributing factor in many illnesses — both physical and mental — a daily practice of even a few minutes of quiet devotion or contemplation can have real benefits for your health and wellbeing, regardless of your beliefs.

A progression, not a hierarchy

Within the tradition of worship itself, there is a natural progression that mirrors the growth of any relationship. Just as Maslow described a hierarchy of human needs — from basic survival to self-actualization — Hindu prayer traditions move through a similar arc.

At one level, people come to God asking for help — healing from illness, success in a venture, protection from harm. This is entirely valid. There is no shame in asking. Hindu scriptures are full of devotees who came to God with specific requests, and God responded with grace.

At another level, people worship not to ask for anything, but to express gratitude, devotion, and love. They seek God's company, not God's favors.

And at the deepest level — particularly in the tradition of Krishna devotion — many devotees want nothing from God at all. Not enlightenment. Not liberation. Not the end of the cycle of rebirth. All they seek is the love and company of God, in this life and in every life to come. This is worship in its purest form — love without conditions, without transactions, without an agenda. It is the spiritual equivalent of loving someone not for what they can give you, but simply because you cannot imagine life without them.

The full picture

Worship is one beautiful way to experience the divine — but it is not the only way. Doing your duties with sincerity and skill is worship. Swami Bodhananda refers to this as 'Workship'. Raising your children with patience and love is worship. Serving your community without seeking recognition is worship. Sitting quietly and recognizing the divinity within yourself is worship. Hinduism sees all of these as equally sacred.

The question, then, is not "do I need to worship?" but "what does my practice look like?" Whatever your answer — chanting, serving, meditating, studying, or simply trying to be a good human being — Hinduism says: that is enough. Begin there.

"Four kinds of virtuous people worship Me, O Arjuna: the one in distress, the one seeking knowledge, the one seeking prosperity, and the one who has realized the truth." — Bhagavad Gita 7.16¹

1. *Chaturvidhā bhajante mām janāḥ sukrīno 'rjuna āro jijñāsura
arthārthī jñānī cha bhāratarābha*

Notice: Krishna calls all four "virtuous". The person crying out to God from a hospital bed is as welcome as the sage who seeks nothing at all. There is no wrong reason to begin.

In the very next verse of the Bhagavad Gita (7.17), Krishna does say that the one who has realized the truth (jnani) — is dearest to Him, because the jnani loves God without wanting anything in return. But this is not a rejection of the other three. It is an invitation. Krishna is showing us the direction of the journey: you may come to God in distress, or seeking success, or driven by curiosity — and all of that is good. But if you stay on the path, the relationship deepens, the asking falls away, and what remains is love itself. Every seeker starts somewhere. The Gita promises that wherever you start is the right place.

Chapter 7

Four-fold Wealth/Qualification for Self- Realization and Transcend Suffering

These are the four-fold wealth/qualifications (or Saadhana Chathushtaya Sampattih) as the means for liberation as told by Adi Shankara. These can also be the steps to transcend suffering and the steps to be unconditionally happy irrespective of the conditions:

To be in the state of bliss with no suffering, one has to have the following four-fold disciplines:

1. Discriminative knowledge (Viveka) of the divine Self from

the non-self. This is the knowledge that the real 'I' is the immortal soul/Atma and not the physical body,

2. Dispassion (Vairaagya) to the sense objects, fruits of action and to the opposites (disease and health, pleasure and misery, pain and comfort, etc) of life. This is the discriminative ability to differentiate between impermanent material happiness or distress and the eternally permanent bliss,

3. Sixfold wealth of:

- Tranquility of mind (Shama): determination of control of your mind, intellect, and ego to be unconditionally calm irrespective of the conditions,
- Training of the senses (Dama): the discipline of the sense organs,
- Withdrawal (Uparati): cessation of and withdrawal from worldly desires,
- Forbearance and tolerance (Titiksha): endurance and tolerance,
- Faith (Shraddha): firm faith in the infinite nature of the self,
- Focus (Samaadhaana): the concentration of the mind

4. Intense longing for our default divine infinite blissful nature (Mumukshutvam): This 'desire' is considered a good quality to 'experience' and be in the ultimate goal of life. To align with the 'simplified' theme of the book, this chapter is not explained in more detail.

This four-fold discipline is the prerequisite for unconditional happiness or infinite bliss or experiencing 'Infinity' and no suffering. For the enthusiastic reader wanting to read more on these profound

four-fold disciplines, I would refer you to *TattvaBodha* and *Viveka Choodamani* by Adi Shankara. There are really great commentaries written in English by Swami Chinmayananda and there are excellent YouTube videos by Swami Sarvapriyananda.

Chapter 8

Various Paths to Achieving Liberation (‘Moksha’ or ‘Realizing God’)

In Hinduism, the ultimate goal of every human being is to achieve ‘Liberation’ from worldly affairs and experience God. ‘Liberation’ is also called ‘Nirvaana’ or ‘Moksha’ or ‘Eternal Bliss’. In academics, one can choose different tracks to success. Some chose educator-scholar track, some chose research-scholar track and others chose clinician-scholar track. Some chose combination of these. All tracks are good depending upon the need, skill and the interest. Similarly, in Hinduism there are different tracks to attaining ‘Moksha’.

In **Karma Yoga**, one chooses the track of doing action without attachment to the results. These are people who work sincerely trying to fulfill their duties as parents, children, spouses, executives, community leaders, etc. Teachers and scientists also fall in this category.

Gandhiji and Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. could be considered some of the all-time great Karma yogis. Karma, a Sanskrit word, has now become an English word as well.

In **Jnana Yoga**, a person spends a lot of time in studying and doing research to develop more knowledge about the self. The first step in this yoga is 'know yourself'. They also teach what they study and experience. There is a large number of Hindus who have followed the path of knowing the divine self and pursue liberation by the following non-duality track.

Hindus have, from age immemorial, been a powerhouse of knowledge. The book, 'Hindu Culture and Dharmic Traditions from India' has several pages on the specifics of contributions of Hindus in various fields.

Some of the examples are description of infinity in Yajur Veda, weight and height scale in Indus scale between 3000-1500 BCE, description of zero in 200-400 BCE, pi (π) in 499 CE by Aryabhata, motions of earth and sun in 1800 BCE by Shatapatha Brahmana and Vedas, atoms (paramanu) in the Vedas (before 2500 BCE).

In 600 BCE, Acharya Sushruta and Acharya Charaka wrote two ancient medical books, 'Sushruta Samhita' and 'Charaka Samhita' respectively. Acharya Sushruta is known for Rhinoplasty, which is a form of plastic surgery on the nose.

Hindu's skill level in artwork including sculpture is obvious from the artwork in the old temples and palaces in India. It is to the Hindus' credit that they are succeeding in different walks of life all over the world.

But the real path of knowledge is knowing the self. 'Self-Inquiry' was recommended by a 20th century saint called Ramana Maharshi. This works on the premise that real truth is ever unchanging and whatever changes over time is not the real truth. If you keep asking

‘Who Am I?’, you will realize that you are not the body, mind, ego, intellect because they are impermanent. You will realize that you are not what the sensory organs can perceive because they are not permanent. If I am neither of these, ‘Who Am I?’. What is left after negating all these is the real ‘I’. That ‘I’ transcends time, space and object. That ‘I’ is the fearless, all loving, all compassionate ‘I’ that transcends birth and death.

In **Bhakti Yoga**, the path of single pointed love towards God, one spends a lot of time in devotion. Some say that Bhakti yogis do not seek liberation. They just seek eternal love and company of God.

Raja Yoga, considered the path of mental concentration has some overlap with Bhakti Yoga. The ‘founder’ of this yoga is Sage Patanjali. Raja yoga is usually called ‘Yoga’. The living legend of Yoga, Swami Ramdev Maharaj, continues to influence millions of people by teaching the technique of ‘breathing/life-force meditation’ (Pranayama) to improve the health status of general public. He brought yoga to the common public of India. He is a true Raja Yogi and a Karma Yogi. Buddha, Swami Vivekananda, Sri Mahesh Yogi, *Swami Nithyananda of Ganeshpuri*, Sadhguru and Sri Sri Ravishankar are legendary Raja Yogis who have promoted meditation among large number of people all over the world. Saurabh Bothra, an engineer by training is doing a great service by choosing to have a career of yoga training using technology and train millions across the world.

Most of these people I have mentioned belong to more than one category. List of these people is very incomplete because of space constraints. One can do all these methods of achieving liberation in different combinations at different times of their lives depending upon ones’ interest, expertise and priorities. More is written about these paths in the later chapters.

Chapter 9

Four Phases of Life

Hinduism describes four phases of life. One could put roughly 20-25 years in each phase.

First phase is the student life (*Brahmacharya*) when one studies hard to build a career to fulfil desires.

The next phase is the family (*Grahasta*) phase when one gets married, have children, work hard and save for family.

The third phase is *Vaanaprastha* phase when one would meditate, retire from materialistic world and help people.

The final phase is *Sanyaasa* phase when one gives up all the worldly pleasures and meditates to achieve 'liberation' or '*Moksha*'. After performing the different kinds of avocations of holy life one's soul progressively gets energized.

Sometimes one has to go through several births and rebirths before achieving 'liberation' and escape from the cycle of births and rebirths. Some people such as the sages chose to skip the family phase and directly go to the *Sanyaasa* phase after they complete their studies. There are people who start family phase by mistake and go to *Sanyaasa* phase without fulfilling the responsibilities of a family leader. For the

sake of family members, this is better avoided. Hinduism does talk about controlling desires, not necessarily suppressing desires.

There is a good time and right time for everything in life. It is an important quality to have discipline in life and control the natural desires instead of the desires controlling our lives. We see many celebrities destroy otherwise very successful lives by failing to control their desires.

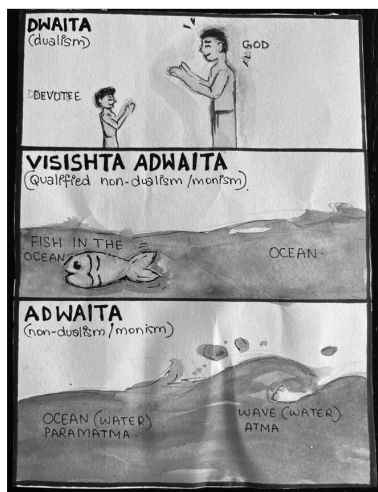
Meditation and contemplation are very useful tools in controlling one's desires and following a righteous path in life. These are also ways of avoiding smoking and alcohol.

SECTION II

Part Two goes little deeper into the philosophies that shape Hindu thought — the detailed paths of devotion, knowledge, action, and yoga, and the stages of life that the tradition maps out for each of us.

Chapter 10

Non-Dualistic, Dualistic and Qualified Non-Dualistic Philosophies



Non-Dualistic, Dualistic and Qualified Non-Dualistic Philosophies (My gratitude to Prita Shetty for the artwork)

Non-dualistic philosophy* believes that the self is divine. It believes that soul (Atma) is a part of God (Brahman) just like how a wave is part of the ocean and the 'truth' of both the wave and ocean is the same water. Purists would argue that the word 'soul' does not adequately translate into the word 'Atma'. There are many words in Sanskrit language that cannot be adequately translated into English. This is based on 'knowledge' of the 'pure self' and this experience is available in this life for all of us to experience. This path stands to logic and is palatable to many scientists and even 'spiritual but not religious people', 'non-theists' and atheists. Non-dualism believes that what is not permanent is unreal and what is permanent, imperishable and unchangeable is the ultimate truth. Hence the perishable body, mind and the intellect are considered not the real truth and the soul that is imperishable is the real truth. It goes on describing that the 'real self' is the 'soul/Atma'. When 'I' am experiencing my body, that 'I' refers

to the true self, soul or Atma. 'I' (Atma) is the experiencer of the body and my body is the object of experience. In this path, God is available to me today, right now without having to die and go to heaven. Also, knowing that the real 'I' is part of the Universal almighty God is very empowering. (Author's comment: I feel that non-dualism has given me lot of strength when I was seeking strength and healing during my difficult days dealing with cancer and pain. I would rather experience God today, in this life rather than after death)

Dualistic philosophy** believes that a person (Soul), the world and God are different. It believes that one can receive God's grace/love and experience Bliss (liberation) after death through self-less devotion to God. Christianity, Taoism, Islam, Judaism and many theistic religions also follow such philosophy. Most faiths of the world are dualistic and are heavily institutionalized, hence are considered mainstream with plenty of resources. Unlike direct experiential approaches, claims about God or an afterlife are matters of faith and are not empirically testable by current scientific methods. One needs to have faith that God and heaven exists. Some dualists do not seek 'merger with God', 'going to heaven', 'liberation', or 'spiritual enlightenment; they just seek company, love and grace of God for ever. Some of such devotees go to the extent that they deliberately do not want 'liberation' and they just seek eternal love of God.

Qualified non-dualism*** philosophy is a blend of dualistic and non-dualistic philosophies. It is like a fish in the water where you are the fish in water and God is the water. You are in water, but you are not water. You are in God and a portion of God but not the whole.

In non-dualism, your truth is the same water that God is as well. These philosophies are not mutually exclusive. Often most of us go through all these philosophies at different stages of our lives. It is common for one to start with the simple dualistic philosophy and

experience the non-dualism later on in life. Even Shankara, probably the greatest non-dualist ever known, has been a devotee of the God and has practiced non-dualism.

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1. **Called 'Advaita' Philosophy: Advaita means 'not two'. Advaita philosophy was promoted by Adi Shankaracharya in around 800 CE. Shankara was a child prodigy and apparently started writing commentaries on scriptures at the age of 8 years. He wrote extensively and travelled all over India to resurrect Hinduism before his body died at a young age of 32 years. Some believe that he was a reincarnation of God.*

Chapter 11

Path of Devotion- Prayer: What? Why? How? Transactional vs. Non- transactional!

‘Love, light, and education are the biggest multipliers; the more you share, the more it multiplies’ - Anupkumar Shetty

“When I walk, I think I am circumambulating God; when I work, I think I am serving God; and when I sleep, I think I am offering him

obeisance. In this manner, I perform no activity other than that which is offered to him.” -Kabir Das

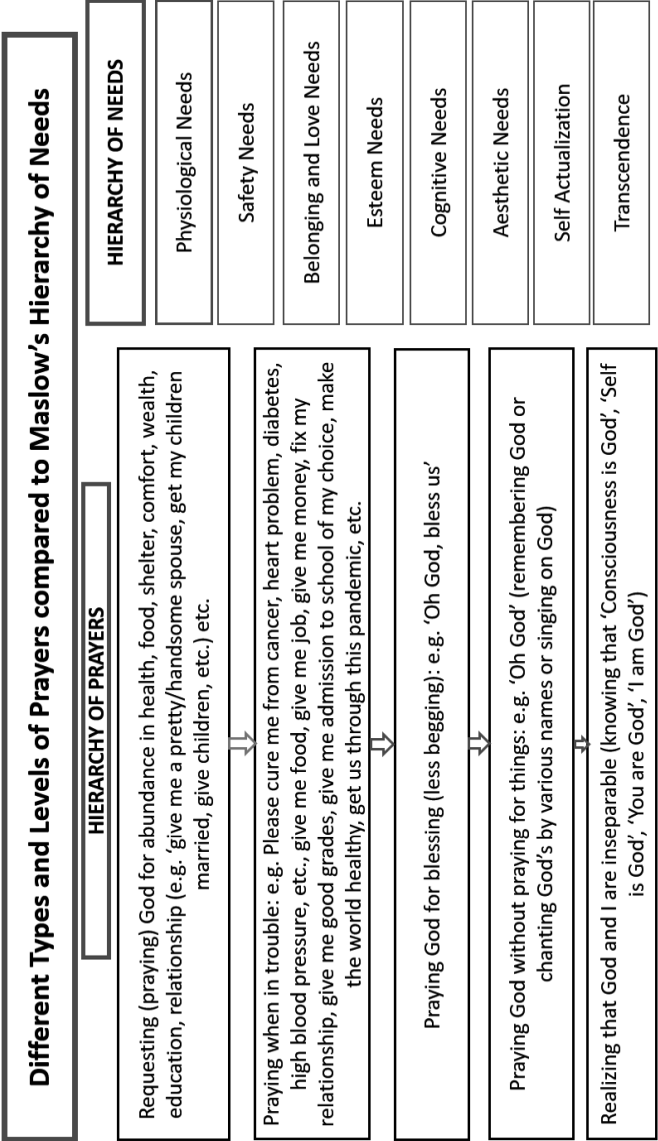
This chapter is going to be presented as my experience with prayer, as a practising Hindu. I have found integrating science, positive psychology and spirituality very helpful in my own life. Traditionally, prayer is requesting God to do something good to help us. It could be ‘curing of cancer’, ‘the next meal’, ‘some money’, ‘lots of money’, ‘love’, ‘lover’, ‘rain’, ‘better crops for a farmer’, ‘more business for a shopkeeper’, ‘life’, or ‘an organ that does not work in your body’. Patients sometimes pray to get a good doctor! I know many who are grateful to God for giving them compassionate and skilled doctors. I am grateful to God for sending the best doctors, nurses, and other healers to heal me and save my life. When you are practicing a dualistic religion, which includes most of the world religions including Christianity, Islam, Judaism, and a large number of Hindus and possibly Sikhs, Buddhists, and Jains, it is common to ask God for favors. However, a large number of Hindus are also non-dualists and ‘qualified non-dualists.’ I do not know enough about other religions like Bahá’í and other religions. There are some non-dualists in every religion. Many switch back and forth between non-dualism and dualism. Non-dualism can be very empowering in difficult situations because you are a small portion of God. In other words, non-dualists believe that ‘Pure Consciousness is Brahman’, ‘the Self is Brahman’, ‘You are that’ (you are that divine reality; ‘That Thou Art’), and ‘I am Brahman (God).’ When God is in you or when you are God, there is no reason to worry. When you are God, whom do you pray? I pray to the God inside me! I pray that I realize the God in me! I pray to the God in me to take over my care! I completely surrender to the God in me and offer everything I do and eat to God. Historically the greatest scholars of non-dualism have been the greatest devotees of

God. Hence devotion to God, knowing the 'I', and the knowledge of non-dualism are not mutually exclusive. But a non-dualist prayer can be non-transactional, in that you don't have to pray for favors from God. All you pray for is for God to be in you, manifest in you, run your life. You will automatically have bliss. But, to be able to do this, you have to have the convincing knowledge that Brahman (God/Infinity) is in you. You have to have that conviction and confidence that the real 'I' is Brahman. To have that 'self-knowledge', one has to listen to divine teachings, one has to study it to ruminate on it, meditate upon it and internalize it. But if you don't have that divine self-knowledge with conviction, you can always fall back to love and devotion to God and worship God to help you and heal you. There is nothing wrong with it and that is what most people do. But, it is the beauty of Hinduism that we have those dualistic and non-dualistic options.

Prayer should not be transactional if you are comfortable with it...

"Exploring the possibilities in life is trying to experience the God/Brahman/Infinity in this life."

This figure in the next page depicts the different ways and examples of prayers. Note that as we evolve spiritually, we stop begging God for favors and just desire to be closer to God till we realize that God is within us. It becomes easier once our basic needs are met. There is a parallel between the hierarchy of prayers that I have described here and the hierarchy of needs described by Abraham Maslow in his 1943 paper "A Theory of Human Motivation" in the journal, Psychological Review. Maslow's hierarchy of needs include physiological needs followed by safety needs, belonging and love needs, esteem needs, cognitive needs, aesthetic needs, self-actualization and finally transcendence. Even positive psychology follows the hierarchy of needs!



Hierarchy of Prayers vs Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs

Hierarchy of prayers and Maslow's hierarchy of needs

Nine kinds of devotion:

In one of the holy texts called *Srimad Bhagavatam*, one of the greatest devotees called Prahlada has described nine kinds of expressing the love of God (nine kinds of '*bhakti*'). They are

- 'listening' to the names and glories of God,
- 'chanting' the glories of God,
- 'remembering' God,
- 'serving' God,
- 'worshipping' God,
- 'offering obeisance' unto God,
- 'serving' as God's servant,
- developing 'friendship' with God and
- 'total surrender' to God.

A given individual can express the love of God in more than one of these nine ways. Scriptures have examples of different people who have expressed and practiced these different methods of devotion.

I will repeat some concepts of prayer to reinforce them so you can meditate on them. The physical body in me tries to survive the risks of destruction from the different dangers in this world. The physical being in me wants to play a team sport by building the best team in the world to give me the best chance of conquering my cancer—best doctors, best nurses, best family, best friends, best hospital, etc. The physical person in me surrenders to the superpower in me to disown my body including cancer and my mind so I don't have to worry about it. The mental being in me acquires all the knowledge to do whatever it can be done to save my body from cancer. But the spiritual being in me itself is the omnipotent, omniscient Brahman/Infinity and hence I do not have to worry about cancer or any bodily problems.

To be able to trust in what scriptures and teachers tell us is, in itself, a wonderful blessing. Because only this trust will make it possible for us to be able to understand who we in fact are. That which is one, free, all-pervasive, and eternal. Trust is very important for those who pray. Trust is love and devotion. In fact, devotion to God is not that difficult because all you need is trust and love towards God. Shree Krishna says in the Gita (4:39) that those whose faith is deep and who have practiced controlling their mind and senses attain divine knowledge. Through such transcendental knowledge, they quickly attain everlasting supreme peace, the peace that God will take care of everything.

I am deliberately mixing up non-dualism and dualism because they don't have to be mutually exclusive. Earlier, I said that trust is paramount in dualistic prayer. But even in non-dualism, you have to utterly, totally, absolutely relinquish the one who you take yourself to be, striving to feel your light of lights within you. To let the body go, you need trust. The one and only reliable one to place your trust in is the divine. Everything and everyone will fail at some point. But, please pray if you wish. It does not matter how. There are no rules of prayer. Pray in a way that empowers you. Sometimes surrendering to the Supreme God/Brahman and allowing yourself to be small empowers you. Sometimes, knowing that you are inside God empowers you. Sometimes, knowing that you are God, that you are magnanimous, will empower you. Be small, be big, or be magnanimous depending upon the situation, as God Hanuman did. In Ramayana, a Hindu epic, God Hanuman became small like a mosquito and big like a giant, depending upon the situation. He lived as a servant of God, a part of God, or simply as God himself, depending upon the situation.

You can be thankful for every little thing and every big thing you have and you don't have. You can be thankful to your family and

friends you have; you can be thankful to your healthcare providers. You can count every blessing. When you practice gratitude, you will learn to be happy with what you have and not be unhappy with your problems. You will always find reasons to be happy when you start counting your blessings. When you learn to practice gratitude to the Consciousness, Brahman, God, Infinity, you will learn to love God. You will not be angry at God despite having problems.

You will find peace within yourself. You will find that infinite consciousness within you. You will find spiritual healing. You will find God right within you, right now, right in this life. God ceases to be an after-death dream. It becomes an experience in this life. Swami Dayananda says: "Prayer is invoking grace as well as an act that is a simple autosuggestion." Prayer does help. Try yourself in whichever way suits your beliefs. I have an army of family and friends praying for me daily to beat cancer the second time. I am very grateful to them.

Path of love towards God: prayer and devotion to God to experience Infinity

Prayers are really powerful. I have deliberately repeated many sentences to make a point. I pray every day. Different people pray differently. Some pray for themselves and don't believe in others praying for them. Many believe in their own prayers and also derive strength in others praying for them. Lots of shrines have a system of praying for people to get better. And some simply don't believe in prayers, they just believe in actions (karma path to realizing God). Some others believe in praying to God, surrendering to God, and asking God to heal. They get the strength to heal from total surrender to God. Such people 'beg' God either for themselves or others. These are mainly 'dualists' who see God and themselves separate from each other and pray to God for favors. There are 'dualists' in almost every faith in the

world. It is the fundamental response from every person who believes in God as their ultimate savior.

Many people just meditate upon and invoke the 'eternal strength' within them. I believe that the belief in non-duality is very strong; those people will only invoke the 'strength' within them without begging God to heal them. Such people should not be worried. Worrying about the outcome would be questioning their very belief. Finally, some people just believe they have the infinite strength to heal and do all the right things to get better. Among these different approaches is one better than the other? I do not know. Whatever works for you is fine. Whatever you feel comfortable with is fine. Whatever gives you strength is the right approach. There is nothing much to choose between the 'dualistic approach' and 'non-dualistic approach'. I feel I benefited from both approaches. I like to believe that I am a non-dualist. But I also know that I go back and forth between being a dualist and non-dualist. Even the saints professing non-dualism like Adi Shankara and others have been the greatest devotees practicing dualism in some ways.

The Hindu philosophy recommends one or all of the different paths to experience God. Those different paths are paths of devotion (bidirectional love towards God, *bhakti*), work (*karma*), contemplation (*Raja yoga*), and path of knowledge (*jnana*). Any one or all the paths are fine depending upon your strengths, weaknesses, comfort level, and experience. But there is a reference to the greatest of the 'enlightened saints' eventually becoming devotees of God in every era of mankind. Some of these examples are Adi Shankara in the current era who surrendered to God with attributes and names like Vishnu, Shiva, and Devi after writing extensively on attribute-less God and non-dualistic philosophy, Saint Shukha who became Lord Krishna's devotee after being the greatest saint, King Janaka who worshipped

Lord Rama, and Sanat Kumara and his three associates who became great devotees of God despite establishing themselves as the enlightened saints of their respective eras. There is a lot written about worshipping God with a name and repeating the name of God in your favorite way. People refer to God by different names such as Krishna, Rama, Vishnu, Shiva, Devi, Hanuman, Brahman, and many others if you are a Hindu. Christians may refer to God as Jesus Christ, Mother Mary, or Jehovah. Muslims may refer to God as Allah. Jews, Jains, Buddhists, Sikhs, Bahais, Shintos, native Indians of the US and Canada, Mayans and Aztecs of Central America and Mexico, Samoans, Incans, Polynesians, and all the different people of the world have their own unique ways of worshipping and addressing God in their own way. Lots of people of all faiths simply refer to God as the 'Man up there'. In other words, even the faiths professing worshipping God without attributes refer to God as 'Man up there' and not as 'Woman up there'! Knowingly or unknowingly, everyone goes back and forth between worshipping God with and without attributes. Hindus do not just refer to God as the 'Man up there', but they get the credit for worshipping God with women's name and form, man's name and form, animal's name and form, and without attributes. Hindus refer to God as a baby and also as a lover with divine love. Sometimes God comes to us as a parent, teacher, or friend. I have heard Swami Bodhananda say that God's name is always available to us to recite and repeat even if we may not know how to feel and see God ourselves. Hence many believe that repeating God's name is extremely powerful. If you study Swami Prabhupada, he taught people to repeat the Hare Krishna maha-mantra thousands of times till they experienced ecstasy. Many people were able to quit hard recreational drugs like cocaine, heroin, and 'ecstasy' by reciting this maha-mantra thousands of times every day because they were able to experience ecstasy without using

‘Ecstasy’. That was the power of repeating God’s names, that is the power of meditation, that is the power of single pointed devotion.

At a personal level, I feel that I believe in the ‘non-dualistic approach’ and invoke God within me and leave the rest to God. But I have gone through a lot of pain during different phases of my life. I tried hard to ‘not experience the pain’ by trying to separate my body from my ‘Self’ and trying to convince myself that I am the Atma/Self/soul and pain is in my body which is not the real me. I meditated, prayed, and invoked the God within me. The pain was nerve-wracking sometimes and I felt that I was not strong or evolved enough to separate ‘me’ from my physical body. During these hours I did become dualistic and begged God for strength. I begged God to take away my pain. I have caught myself screaming for my mother, crying out aloud ‘*ammaaa...*’ when I was in pain!

If this means I did not believe in God within me, I feel that I did believe that there was a ‘Big God’ who was stronger than the God within me. I may have separated the water in the wave from the water in the ocean! I don’t know. All I know is pain really hurts and it is alright to seek help from God.

Back to the issue of whether prayers help, I believe they do. I believe that it helped me. Research has shown that support groups help improve the outcomes in those who participate in them. My suggestion is to personalize your way of praying. If you feel comfortable, allow or request others to pray for you. If you feel uncomfortable with strangers knowing about your personal life, ask for anonymous prayers. If you feel that prayer is strictly personal communion between you and God, discourage the mass prayers and pray alone in your privacy.

One thing that I am very certain of is that you don’t fall sick because you belong to or do not belong to one faith, you don’t fall sick because

you did not pray. You can make your own choices! Hindus do not believe that God is judgemental. God does not punish!

Let me quote one universal prayer that is a healing, transformational and meditative prayer that I chant every day.

“Lead us from untruth to truth, lead us from darkness to light, lead us from mortality to immortality.”

Chapter 12

Path of Action (Karma): Do Your Duties Fully Engaged in Action and Detached from the Outcome

This chapter comes from the famous 47th verse of the second chapter of the Bhagavad Gita. It is one of the famous and powerful teachings that should not be mis-understood.

"Control the controllables"

'Your right is only to perform your duty but never lay claim to its fruit.

Let not the fruit of action be your object, nor let your attachment be to inaction'

Ref: Gita Chapter 2/47th verse, (rearranging the numbers, this is a 24/7 verse for everyone!)

Another way of looking at what God Krishna says is "Your duty is to act. Work with full engagement to your duty and skill without attachment to the results. Leave the results to Me. Do not give company to inaction. Don't be lazy. Do action with the best skill you have and offer your action to Me. I will take care of the results."

Our duty is to do our duties in an efficient and responsible manner. When we do our duties, we should not be attached to the results. The good result will automatically follow. We should be attached to the action itself and offer the results to God and be detached to the results of action. We see this all the time in real life.

For students, their duty is to study hard, learn the information needed to perform well in the examinations and prepare for future independent life without getting distracted by other activities for immediate pleasure.

They do well if they have to focus on their duties without thinking of the consequences of their actions. Many students don't do well if they have too much peer pressure or parental pressure. In sports, often the difference between the champion and the second best is not the skill level. One who can exhibit his skill without attachment to the final result comes out as the champion.

The one who plays without thinking of the end result (the trophy or the consequences of missing the ball or consequences of winning or losing the championship) will do better. If one thinks of the end result of his action, more than likely he will miss that crucial shot and lose.

We see the same thing in interviews. If you think of what will happen after the interview, there is more risk of making mistakes during the interview. We see this in interviews, exams, sports, negotiations and every field of life. When you are sick, your duty is to get the best treatment that is available by going to the best doctor and the best hospital available and leave the results to God or destiny. You have no control over the outcome. In fact, even doctors don't have control over the outcome. We often see different results from the same treatment in different patients.

We are in an outcome-based society. It is hard not to think of the outcome. But you get the best outcome if you concentrate on the action without worrying about the results. You only have control over your action. My son, Eesha taught me, 'control the controllable'.

The last segment of the verse from Gita explains about inaction and this is an important part of the verse. Inaction refers to idleness, laziness and excessive sleep. In some situations, lack of action is the wrong action. In other words, an act of omission can be as bad as an act of commission. In the epic war Mahabharata, the just war was the right thing to do when non-violent means to fight for justice failed.

This verse should not be interpreted out of context. One of the subsequent verses suggests to be 'skillful in action'. It is important to be fully engaged in skillful action and fully engaged in the world and yet fully detached from the result of action.

My Guru, Swami Bodhananda of Sambodh Society explains this beautifully, succinctly, and comprehensively as '**be fully detached and be fully engaged**'.

1

1. *'Karmanye Vaadikaaraste Maaphaleshu Kadaachana Maa Karma phala Hetur Bhuh maa te Sangostv Akarmani'

Chapter 13

Path of Yoga According to Dualistic and Non-dualistic Approach

The primary text of Yoga is 'Aphorisms of Patanjali (Yoga Sutras of Patanjali). It is believed that Sage Patanjali described these around 200 BCE – 200 CE. But Yoga has been described in texts that are believed to be much older, including in Bhagavad-Gita and Buddhist texts. The path of Yoga described in Patanjali's text is considered dualistic, where the 'divine self' (called 'Purusha') is considered a different entity than the Universal Divinity (called 'Ishwara').

Yoga is not a collection of exercises. 2nd to 5th aphorisms of Patanjali define what yoga is and what it is not.

What is Yoga? The cessation of changing states of the mind is yoga. (Water will be still, and there will be no turbulences)

What happens when one is in 'Yoga'? The 'seer' in me will be established in the (divine) Self (Water will be still and see through so that we can see the bottom of the water tank)

What happens when one is not in 'Yoga'? Then (at other times), the 'seer' is established in the changing states of the mind. (Mind will be like the turbulent water, where you only see the turbulences)

The term yoga is used in different contexts. Part of this chapter is reproduced from the book, 'The Power of Infinity' by the same author, Anupkumar Shetty. The literal meaning of the term yoga is 'union with', implying that 'living in union with divine consciousness'. In this chapter, I mainly refer to practicing eight limbs of yoga as described by Sage Patanjali as a means to experience or better still, be in 'Infinity'. Yoga is not just stretching and doing some exercise learned in the yoga studios, even though it is one of the eight limbs of yoga. These eight limbs are not mutually exclusive. These are like eight steps on the ladder of 'Infinity'. The eighth limb of yoga is called *samadhi*, which is a state of bliss. It is a state of unconditional bliss. It is a state of unconditional happiness. Advancing through these eight steps culminates in a state of unconditional bliss. According to yoga aphorism 2:2, the goal of yoga is not to achieve something that is lacking. It is the realization of something that is already present. Yoga helps us remove the obstacles that cover the experience of bliss, *samadhi*, a state of pure consciousness. It is believed that you do not achieve bliss. It is not something that is achieved. It is something that you already are in. It is something that you discover that you already are and you already were. Hence it is something that is your default state. It is something that you uncover and unveil. It is as though you always had the sweet and soft fruit in you, but it was covered by several sheaths and shells. When you learn to remove the sheaths and shells, you discover that you always had a sweet and soft fruit.

The seven limbs of yoga preceding the stage of bliss are the sheaths and the shells. Another example to convince you that 'blissful state' is your default state is the example of little kids and adults. Little kids are always smiling. They smile for no reason. They smile even before we understand why they are smiling. The different limbs of yoga help us rediscover the 'bliss' that once was our default state.

The eight limbs of yoga or the eight steps to the ladder of bliss are as follows.

1. Moral codes (*yama*):

- Non-violence
- Truthfulness
- Non-stealing
- Abstinence
- Non-receiving

2. Self-purification/rules (*niyama*):

- External and internal cleanliness
- Contentment
- Mortification
- Self-study
- Worship of God.

3. Postures/exercise (*Asana*): These are called yoga by many studios

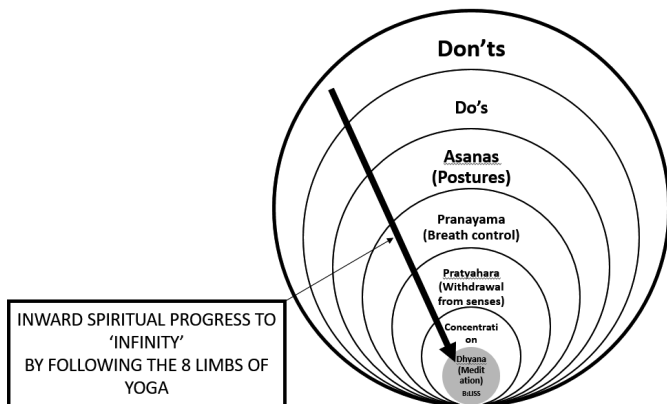
4. Breath control (*prAnAyAma*)

5. Withdrawal from sensory pleasures (*pratyAhAra*)

6. Concentration (*dhArana*)

7. Deep Meditation (*dhyaAna*) and

8. Union with the object of meditation (*samAdhi*)



Representation of eight limbs of Yoga as the means to be in 'Bliss/Infinity'

Going along these eight steps is a lifelong process. If you believe in rebirths, it could take more than one birth. The physical and mental components of these eight steps can be accomplished in one life, but the seventh and eighth steps are experiential and could take more evolution. Steps one to six are things you do consciously and the seventh and eighth steps happen unconsciously. To maintain the purity of the practice, it is recommended that you learn this from a trained person and do plenty of self-study and contemplation. Since certain parts of yoga may not satisfy the materialistic definition of scientific truth, this state of bliss may not be palatable and/or accessible to some people. That experience is available to you, waiting for you to try, explore, invoke and experience. Please give yourself an opportunity for this profound experience of the fearless, all-compassionate, birthless,

deathless, self-effulgent, and eternal ONE truth that is beyond birth, death, and time.

FIFTEEN STEPS TO SAMADHI ACCORDING 'NOT INDIRECT EXPERIENCE (DIRECT EXPERI- ENCE)' (*APAROKSHAANUBHOOTI*)

Aparokṣa Anubhūti is a profound concept in **Advaita Vedānta**.
The term literally means “**not indirect realization.**”

Word Meaning

- **A-parokṣa** → *not indirect, not mediated, immediate*
- **Anubhūti** → *experience or realization*

So **Aparokṣa Anubhūti** means: **Direct realization of the Self (Ātman) without the mediation of thought, reasoning, or scripture.**

1. Three Levels of Knowing (Vedantic Context)

Vedānta often distinguishes three ways of knowing truth:

1. Indirect Knowledge

Knowledge obtained through scriptures, teachers, or reasoning.

Example: “*Brahman is the ultimate reality.*” — you understand it intellectually. Another example, ‘if I see smoke, there is fire around’

2. Direct Realization

The truth is **seen directly in one’s own senses**. Example: ‘I see fire’

It is no longer philosophy.

3. Not-indirect experience

The realization becomes **stable and natural without the uses of senses, transcending them**. Example: I see the fire with closed eyes, or I hear OM when nobody is chanting.

2. Meaning in Non Dualism

“Not indirect realization.” is the moment when one realizes: **“I am not the body, not the mind — I am pure awareness (Ātman), which is Brahman.”**

The fifteen disciplines described here are the means by which a sincere seeker gradually reaches the highest goal of realization. When earnestly practiced, these steps guide the aspirant from intellectual understanding to **direct experience of the Self**.

The **Ātman**, which is absolute existence and pure knowledge, cannot be realized without sustained contemplation and practice. Therefore, the seeker of truth must constantly meditate upon **Brahman**, the supreme reality.

These **fifteen steps**, described in **verses 100–134 of Aparokṣānubhūti**, form a path that leads the aspirant toward **Samadhi—the direct knowledge of the Self**.

1. Restraint of the Senses (Yama)

Yama is the discipline of restraining the senses through the knowledge that **“All this is Brahman.”**

When this understanding becomes firm, the senses naturally lose their tendency to wander toward objects.

In the Yogic tradition, Yama includes ethical restraints such as:

- non-injury (ahimsa)
- truthfulness (satya)
- non-stealing (asteya)
- self-control
- non-possessiveness

These restraints purify the mind and prepare it for higher knowledge.

2. Cultivation of the Right Thought (Niyama)

Niyama is the continuous flow of a single uplifting thought that excludes all other distractions.

The highest form of such thought is contemplation of the identity between the individual Self and Brahman.

Examples include:

- **“This Self is Brahman.”**
- **“I am Brahman.”**

According to Patanjali, Niyama includes practices such as:

- purity
- discipline
- self-study
- devotion to the Divine.

Through these disciplines the mind becomes steady and luminous.

3. True Renunciation

True renunciation is not merely abandoning actions or withdrawing from society.

Real renunciation arises when one recognizes that **the entire universe is nothing but the all-pervading Self.**

When everything is seen as the Self, the desire to possess anything disappears.

The scriptures declare:

"Renounce and enjoy the world by seeing everything as God."

(Isa Upanishad)

Such renunciation leads naturally toward liberation.

4. Inner Silence

True silence is not merely refraining from speech. It is the state where the mind itself becomes quiet and merges into the reality from which words and thoughts arise.

The Upanishads declare that Brahman is that **from which words and mind return, unable to grasp it.**

External silence may help beginners, but the real silence known to the wise is **the silence of direct awareness.**

5. The Auspicious Place

The true place for meditation is not merely a physical location.

The highest "place" is **the state of solitude in which only Brahman exists.**

Brahman alone is truly solitary because it admits **no second reality**.
Wherever this realization dawns, that place becomes sacred.

6. The Auspicious Time

The supreme “time” is the timeless reality of Brahman.

From this infinite consciousness arises the entire universe in an instant.

Just as a dream world appears suddenly in the mind, the universe manifests within the supreme consciousness. Realizing this timeless presence is the highest understanding of time.

7. The True Posture

The real posture is not merely a physical arrangement of the body.

True posture is that condition in which **meditation on Brahman flows naturally and effortlessly**.

A steady and serene body supports a steady mind.

When the mind rests in Brahman, that state itself is the highest posture.

8. Returning to the Root

This step is the recognition that **Brahman is the root of all existence**.

When the mind rests in this fundamental reality, it becomes re-strained and peaceful.

True control of the mind arises not from force, but from **absorption in the source of consciousness itself**.

9. Balance of the Body

Deha-Samya means the harmonious balance of the body.

Yet its deeper meaning is **absorption in the uniform reality of Brahman**.

Merely sitting rigidly like a tree is not true balance.

True balance is the state in which the body and mind become naturally steady through knowledge.

10. The Vision of Knowledge

True vision is not merely fixing the gaze on the tip of the nose.

Real seeing occurs when the world itself is perceived as **nothing but Brahman**.

When the distinctions between

- seer
- seeing
- seen

begin to dissolve, the highest vision arises.

11. Mastery of the Mind

In the highest sense, Prāṇāyāma is the restraint of the mind by recognizing all mental states as expressions of Brahman.

In this Vedantic interpretation:

- **Rechaka (exhalation)** – rejection of the phenomenal world
- **Puraka (inhalation)** – affirmation: *“I am Brahman.”*

- **Kumbhaka (retention)** – steady abidance in this realization.

When the mind is controlled, the breath naturally becomes calm.

12. Withdrawal of the Mind from external objects

This occurs when one perceives the **Self in all objects**.

When everything is recognized as consciousness itself, the mind no longer runs outward.

13. Supreme Concentration

Supreme Concentration is the steadiness of the mind established through the knowledge that **everything is Brahman**.

Wherever the mind moves, the seeker recognizes only the underlying reality.

Names and forms fade in importance as the essence alone is perceived.

14. Meditation on the Self

Meditation on the Self is the uninterrupted awareness of one's identity with Brahman.

The thought **"I am Brahman"** becomes continuous and unshakable.

From this meditation arises profound peace and bliss.

15. Direct Knowledge

Direct Knowledge or samadhi is the complete stilling of thought and its absorption into Brahman.

In this state, the mind becomes changeless and merges with the Self.

This is not merely concentration but **direct knowledge of reality**.

Samādhi is therefore identical with **true wisdom of the true divine Self**.

The culmination of these fifteen disciplines is direct realization of the Self.

The seeker discovers that:

The Self that was sought is the very awareness in which the search appeared.

In that realization:

There is no seeker.

There is no path.

There is only **Brahman**.

The aspirant should carefully practice this (meditation) that reveals his natural bliss until, being under his full control, it arises spontaneously, in an instant when called into action.

Chapter 2 of the Yoga Sutras describes five obstacles to the experience of bliss. I thank my friend and teacher, Dr. Sriram Sarvotham for giving me clarity on these obstacles.

Five obstacles in life are:

1. Ignorance
2. Ego
3. Attachment
4. Aversion
5. Clinging to life

Ignorance: This refers to the ignorance of awareness of the truth, truth of the 'Self'. The truth of the self refers to the eternal truth that the 'Self' is not the flesh and blood of the body. The true self is not the body that can be affected by cancer! It is not the mind that thinks that the body is the self, that the mind is controlling, it is also not the intellect, it is the pure consciousness that is over and above the body, mind, and intellect. The true self is the 'Infinity'.

Ego: Ego gives us the labels, the adjectives that tag us to a certain gender, ethnicity, race, skin color, education, occupations, faith, country of origin, income category, type of dress we wear, type of car we drive, size of the house we live in, people we associate with. When we slowly peel off these tags and identities we refer to a person by, we lose our limited identity and we realize that we are all human beings. If we go beyond our identity as human beings, we realize that we are just living beings. If we remove that identity that we are living beings, we realize that we are a portion of the infinite world. If we go further ahead we realize that we are the 'Infinity'.

Attachment: This is the third obstacle to the realization of the self. This could be about the desire to possess something. It is about a desire to possess wealth, a desire to possess a status, a desire to possess certain goals, and certain outcomes in life. Desires give more desires which in turn give more desires. We sometimes have to grow from expecting a 'perfect problem-free life' to being happy in the middle of problems. In chapter 2: 62-63, The Holy Gita says that attachment to the objects of senses leads to desire, desire leads to anger, anger leads to clouding of judgment, which results in bewilderment of memory. The bewilderment of memory leads to the destruction of intellect which ruins the individual. As we detach ourselves from desires we discover the happy self that already was in us and we experience 'The Infinity' in us.

Aversion: Aversion is dislike towards something. Often we identify ourselves with our dislikes. We may dislike certain kinds of people, we may dislike certain ways of worshipping, we may dislike certain kinds of food, we may dislike certain colors, certain music, certain topics, certain political parties or certain politicians, etc. If we commit to going beyond these dualities of likes and dislikes, we realize harmony, we realize universal love, we realize universal divinity, we realize ONEness, we realize and experience the 'Infinity'.

Clinging to life: Clinging to life comes from fear of death. This comes from the incorrect identification with the temporary body as the real self. As we practice the do's and don'ts of life, withdraw from the finite things in life, practice meditation to experience the divinity within us, we will learn to detach ourselves from our mortal, temporary body and will experience our default state, the 'Infinity'.

Some Life Lessons from Patanjali's Yoga Sutras

1. Yoga is the cessation of the fluctuations of the mind.

(Sutra 1.2)

- Cultivate inner peace by calming your thoughts.

2. Practice and detachment are the means to yoga. (Sutra

1.12)

- Consistent practice and letting go of attachments are key to spiritual growth.

3. The mind is restless, but it can be stilled through practice. (Sutra 1.6)

- With consistent effort, you can quiet your mind.

4. Self-study is the path to self-realization. (Sutra 2.32)

- Introspection and self-awareness lead to deeper understanding.

5. Non-violence, truthfulness, non-stealing, celibacy, and non-possessiveness are the ethical practices. (Sutra 2.30)

- Ethical living is the foundation of a spiritual life.

6. Purity, contentment, austerity, study, and surrender to the divine are the self-disciplines. (Sutra 2.32)

- Self-discipline leads to inner strength and clarity.

7. Postures should be steady and comfortable. (Sutra 2.46)

- Find a balance between effort and ease in your yoga practice.

8. Breath control is the restraint of breath. (Sutra 2.48)

- Conscious breathing can calm the mind and body.

9. Withdrawal of the senses from their objects is the absorption of the senses in the Self. (Sutra 2.54)

- Focus inward to connect with your true nature.

10. Concentration is the sustained application of the mind on a single object. (Sutra 3.1)

- Develop focus and mindfulness through meditation.

11. Meditation is the unwavering focus of the mind on a single object. (Sutra 3.2)

- Deepen your meditation practice for a transformative experience.

12. When the mind becomes one-pointed, it attains the state of Kaivalya, or liberation. (Sutra 3.53)

- Ultimate liberation is achieved through a clear and focused mind.

13. Dispassion, reversal of the flow of consciousness, and restraint are the means of attaining powers. (Sutra 3.54)

- Let go of desires, cultivate awareness, and practice self-control to awaken your potential.

14. The wise see the Self in all beings. (Sutra 4.7)

- Develop compassion and empathy for all beings.

15. The wise renounce the fruits of action. (Sutra 4.14)

- Let go of attachment to outcomes and embrace the present moment.

16. The wise are established in the Self. (Sutra 4.15)

- Cultivate a strong sense of self and identity.

17. The wise are free from doubt. (Sutra 4.16)

- Trust in your inner wisdom and intuition.

POEM ON YOGA

Dr Raju

YOGA

What is 'Yoga'?

'Yoga' means 'union with God', derived from the root word - "Yuj" -
to Yoke.

It's "Detached Engagement" - Engaging fully in action - Detaching
completely from effects of action.

'Yoga' means,
Equity in interaction,
Equipoise in every action,
Dexterity in each expression.

'Yoga' means,
Self control,
Constant self patrol,
And Self regulating will.

Restraining thoughts,
Retraining thoughts,
Streamlining thoughts,
Calmness of mind in acts.

Moderation as
Mantra of adoration.

'Yoga' means,
Evolution in life,
Elegance in work,

Eloquence of speech.
Moving out of Ego space,
Living in an Eco space.

‘Yoga’ means,
Convincing gesture,
Comfortable posture,
Living the values and virtues.

‘Yoga’ means,
Controlling our senses,
Which are like horses,
Conquering ‘anger force’
And other internal foes.

Revelling in joy,
Not expecting joy at work
Yet, joyously expressing work,
Not working for Happiness, but Happily working.

Living ‘child like’
But, not being childish.

Yoga is
Working with focus,
With Self as the locus,
For self purification
And world glorification.

‘Yoga’ means,

Detachment from
attachment to sorrow,
Living life today,
Not buried in yesterday ,
Nor worrying about tomorrow.

Chapter 14

Which Path is Right For You?

Hinduism doesn't ask you to fit into a single mold. Over thousands of years, its thinkers developed many approaches to the same fundamental question: *How do I end suffering and experience the divine?*

The beauty is that you don't have to pick just one — most Hindus blend several. But here's a rough guide based on what resonates with you:

If you're drawn to a loving, personal relationship with God — the path of devotion (*Bhakti*) offers that. This is a familiar approach for those coming from other faith traditions — prayer, surrender, and trust in a higher power.

If you believe the best way to grow spiritually is through your work and duties — *Karma Yoga* is your path. Do your work as an offering, without attachment to the outcome. This path can be practiced with or without belief in God.

If meditation and inner stillness call to you — *Raja Yoga* offers a structured, experiential approach. This resonates especially with people who identify as "spiritual but not religious" — a growing group in the United States and around the world.

If you're intellectually inclined and want to understand the true nature of reality — the non-dualistic (*Advaita*) path invites you to explore the idea that your true self and the ultimate reality are one and the same.

If you feel that you carry a spark of God within you, but that God is also something greater and beyond you — qualified non-dualism (*Vishishtadvaita*) holds that space. You are part of God, and God is more than the sum of the parts.

These paths are not mutually exclusive. Many Hindus practice devotion in the morning, karma yoga at work, and meditation before bed — all in the same day. The paths of action, focused mind, and self-inquiry can each be practiced with or without belief in a personal God — making Hinduism one of the few traditions in the world that genuinely accommodates both theists and non-theists under the same umbrella.

What does this blend look like in real life? Here are three very different people, each practicing Hinduism in their own way:

A medical doctor chants the *Hanuman Chalisa* — a devotional hymn to the god of strength and healing — on her drive to the hospital each morning. At work, she treats every patient with the same care she would offer to the divine, not chasing recognition or promotions but simply doing her best work as an offering. After dinner, she sits for twenty minutes of silent meditation before bed. In a single day, she has walked the path of devotion, the path of selfless action, and the path of focused mind — without once stepping into a temple.

A nuclear scientist begins his day by reciting the thousand names of God Vishnu, a practice his grandmother taught him as a child. During the day, he works on advancing science for the benefit of humankind, bringing the same discipline and rigor to his research that the Gita asks of any person performing their duty. In the evenings, he writes a

blog exploring the nature of consciousness and reality, drawing connections between quantum physics and non-dualistic philosophy. His day moves from devotion to karma yoga to the path of knowledge — seamlessly.

A young graduate, freshly out of college, doesn't chant or meditate — at least not yet. But she carries with her a single idea that she picked up from a friend's copy of the Upanishads: that she is a spark of the divine, and that the divine is something greater and beyond her. She carries that awareness into her first job, her friendships, and her quiet moments of self-doubt. She doesn't call it Hinduism. She doesn't call it anything. But she is walking the path of qualified non-dualism (*Vishishtadvaita*), without knowing its name.

That is the flexibility of Hinduism. There is no single correct way.

The *Bhagavad Gita* itself offers this promise. Krishna tells Arjuna:

"In whatever way people approach Me, I meet them in that same way." (Bhagavad Gita 4.11)

In practice, this means something profoundly simple: take a single step, and the divine will take a hundred to meet you where you are. You don't need to have it all figured out. You don't need to chant perfectly, meditate for hours, or understand every philosophy in this book. You just need to begin — in whatever way feels true to you. Hinduism promises that it will be enough if you feel connected to how you practice spirituality.

SECTION III

Section three takes on the real-world questions people ask most often: What does Hinduism say about other religions? Seeing divinity in everyone, Proselytization, Genesis, Healthy eating, Idol worship? Dharma and adharma, About women? About non-violence? Stark difference between Swastika and Hakenkreuz! Significance of Bindi. Gayatri mantra?

Chapter 15

What about Other Religions? Is Anybody Welcome to Hinduism?

Hindus see divinity in everything and everybody. Hindus are known for their acceptance (of other cultures. Hindus don't believe in converting non-Hindus into Hinduism. Hinduism does not believe that you are a sinner. The author does not claim expertise in various religions of the world. Hinduism, being one of the oldests living religions, did not evolve criticizing the other existing religions. God has to be ONE for all the humanity, if God is God. Some historic facts might help the reader about the Hindu philosophy. Hindu kings have largely defended themselves, but have not invaded or colonized other

countries and have not supported regime changes. That principle is still alive in the foreign policies of the main Hindu land, India, even though India is a very secular nation.

These are some of the fundamental differences between Hinduism and other major religions of the world such as Islam and Christianity. Jainism, Buddhism and Sikhism were derived from Hinduism and they have more commonality with Hinduism than differences.

When Jews and Zoroastrian Persians were persecuted in their land, Indian Hindu kings gave them shelter and made provisions for them to practice their religion in India unconditionally. Even now, there are Zoroastrians and Jews in India and are thriving in whatever they do. Tatas, a Zoroastrian family, is one of the most successful families in business in India and they have contributed to the society a lot. There are many illustrious physicians from Zoroastrian community in Mumbai, India.

Hindus respect and accept every religion. Hindus teach that, 'If you are a Hindu, be a good Hindu; if you are a Christian, be a good Christian; if you are a Muslim, be a good Muslim. You don't need to change your religion to be a good person'. Hindus love everybody.

It is the richness of Hindus that they allowed Muslims and Christians to be part of their society even though Hindus in India and their temples were looted by the Muslim rulers and the British (Christians) looted India's wealth and re-wrote Indian history to suite their narrative.

Gross domestic product of India came down from around 20% to less than 1% of the world during the 800 years that the Muslim kings and the British ruled India. Literacy rate of India was around 15% when India got independence from the Brits in 1947. It has gone up to 75% in the last 75 years. It is a myth that British helped India by

occupying India even though few good things may have come from them!

It is to the credit of Hinduism that they fought the British and got independence without violence (by non-violence). The very fact that there have been great people in every religion indicates that every religion has great virtues. For that reason, there is no organized system to convert people to Hinduism.

If anybody wants to be a Hindu, they are welcome to be Hindus. If they wish they are welcome to attend any Hindu temple and worship. Few years ago, under the guidance of an American Hindu priest in Nebraska, Sri Frank Morales, and some new Hindus celebrated thread ceremony similar to 'Upa Nayana' or 'Baptizing'. This is a new phenomenon, but it is not a necessity to be a Hindu. If one wants to celebrate being a Hindu, one can go to any temple, apply the holy Gandha Prasad (red powder called KumKum or sandalwood paste) on their forehead or wear a holy thread around the wrist or neck.

Some people wear a necklace made of certain beads called Rudrakshi beads. Rudrakshi means Lord Shiva's Eye. Lord Shiva is believed to have a Third Eye in the forehead which has supernatural powers. None of the Hindu temples need you to be a member to enter the premises and worship. There is no fees to enter a temple.

There are many Hindu organizations which do charity, but none of them do so to convert people to Hinduism. There are many Hindu temples in India which fund and administer Universities and educational institutions without attempting to spread the religion. There are no Hindu organizations which convert people to Hinduism by force as well.

Chapter 16

What Makes Hinduism Different From Other Religions?

Sometimes we hear people saying that all religions are equally good. It is true that all religious scriptures have good components. It is true that there are some very divine people in all religions. Does this mean that all religions are equal? I don't think so for the following reasons.

- First of all, Hinduism is not a one book, one founder religion.
- Hinduism offers different paths, both theistic and non-theistic, to experience God.
- Non-dualism: Good portion of Hindus practice non-dualism. Hinduism believes that there is God 'in' all of us (Ac-

tually our body is in God). Most other religions separate God from human beings. Most Hindus look for experiencing God within them, more accurately they realize that 'real self is God'; most other faiths look for God away from and outside them. This allows us to experience God in this life and in this world. One does not have to die and go to heaven to experience God. God is not 'the man up there', God is here and everywhere.

- Hinduism does not believe that we are sinners. On the contrary, Hinduism believes that we are divine, 'Pure Consciousness is God', 'You are God', 'I am God' and 'I am not the body and mind'.
- Hinduism teaches that nonbelievers of Hinduism are divine as well as Hindus. Since it is the oldest living religion, other religions did not exist when it started and hence does not compare with other religions. This gives no opportunity for condemning or comparing with other religions. Hinduism gives all the different routes to approach and experience God. Hence it is all-inclusive. You can follow the path of love towards God (Bhakti yoga), the path of unselfish action (Karma yoga), the path of contemplation and experience (Dhyana or Raja Yoga) or the path of knowledge that 'The self is divine' (Jnana Yoga).
- Hinduism gives the option to worship God with attributes and without attributes. Hence, Hinduism accepts any kind of worship and a plethora of options to seek God. This makes the religion inclusive. There are also Hindu schools which allow practicing Hinduism in a non-theistic manner.

- There are subsidiary Hindu texts that discuss moral code, education, ethics, law, healthy living and medical practice thereby merging spirituality with day to day life.
- Finally, there is no organized system of converting non-Hindus into Hindus.

Chapter 17

You Are Not A Sinner, You Are Divine, There is Divinity in Everything and Everybody

A different starting point

Many of the world's major religions begin with a fundamental premise about human nature: that we are fallen, flawed, or born into sin — and that we need salvation from outside ourselves to be made whole. Hinduism begins from the opposite premise. You are not a sinner. You are divine. You have always been divine. The purpose

of life is not to earn your way back to God — it is to realize that God has been within you all along.

This is not a metaphor, a compliment, or a motivational slogan. It is the foundational teaching of Hindu philosophy — and it changes everything.

The scriptures say it plainly as four great sentences of Hinduism from the four Vedas

The Upanishads — the philosophical core of Hindu scriptures originating from the Vedas — state this truth in sentences so concentrated they have been contemplated for thousands of years:

"Consciousness is Brahman" ('Prajñānam Brahma' from Aitareya Upanishad of the Rig Veda)

"You are that Divine Reality." ('Tat tvam Asi' from Chandogya Upanishad of the Sama Veda)

"The Self is Brahman (God)." ('Ayam Ātmā Brahma' from Mandukya Upanishad of the Atharva Veda)

"I am Brahman" ('Ahaṁ Brahmāsmi' from Brihadaranyaka Upanishad of the Yajur Veda)

The Isha Upanishad goes further: "One who sees divinity in the self and in all others, loves everybody." And the Bhagavad Gita echoes this in Chapter 6, Verse 30: "One who sees Me everywhere and sees everything in Me — I am never lost to them, and they are never lost to Me."

These are not abstract philosophical propositions. They are invitations to see yourself — and every person around you — in an entirely different light.

Equal divinity, different manifestation

If everyone is divine, why don't we all act like it? Hinduism has a clear answer: all of us carry equal divinity within us, but we manifest it in different degrees. Think of electricity flowing through different appliances — a lamp, a heater, a speaker. The electricity is the same in each, but it manifests differently depending on the instrument. In the same way, the divine consciousness within each of us is identical, but it expresses itself differently depending on our actions, our awareness, and our effort.

Through our choices — how we treat others, how we do our work, how we handle adversity — we allow more or less of that inner divinity to shine through. This is not a judgment on anyone's worth. Everyone's worth is infinite and equal. It is simply a recognition that spiritual growth is a process, and we are all at different points in that process.

When a person manifests their divinity to the fullest extent — through love, service, knowledge, or surrender — they achieve moksha, liberation from the cycle of rebirth. But even before that, every step toward recognizing your own divinity makes life richer, calmer, and more connected.

What this means for how you live and world would live

If you truly believed that every person you meet today — your colleague, your neighbor, the stranger at the grocery store, even the person who cuts you off in traffic — carries the same divine spark that you do, how would it change the way you treat them? When you see divinity in everything, everybody, every situation, there would only be love, peace and happiness, no confrontation, no unfriendly competition, only collaboration! When world leaders see divinity in each other, there would be no wars, only more collaboration to uplift the world.

If you truly believed that you yourself are divine — not broken, not fallen, not in need of rescue from some external force — how would it change the way you talk to yourself on your worst days?

This is the practical power of this teaching. It is not just theology. It is a way of moving through the world. When a Hindu says "Namaste" — pressing both palms together and bowing — the gesture literally means "the divine in me honors the divine in you." It is this chapter, lived out in a single word.

Imagine

Imagine if everyone in the world — regardless of their faith — truly believed in the divinity of every person. There would be collaboration instead of competition. Love instead of hatred. Mutual trust instead of suspicion. Understanding instead of war.

It may sound idealistic. But the teaching is not asking you to change the world. It is asking you to change how you see it — one person, one interaction, one moment at a time.

You are divine. You have always been divine. And so is everyone around you.

Bhagavad Gita, in Chapter 6, verse 30, describes this in different words, i.e., 'He who sees Me everywhere and sees everything in me, he never gets separated from Me, nor do I get separated from him'.

All of us have equal amount of divinity within us. But we manifest divinity in different degrees. By our actions we can have the divinity manifest. When we manifest the divinity to the fullest extent we get liberated from the worldly affairs and achieve 'Moksha'.

Won't this make this world a better place to live? Please say again, 'Self is God', 'You are divine', 'There is divinity in everything and everybody'.

Chapter 18

Predatory Proselytization

There is nothing written on this topic in the Hindu scriptures probably because they precede the scriptures of the other currently living religions of the world. The Holy Gita has a verse on practising one's '*Dharma*'. (Dharma is loosely translated as faith for the context here) In Chapter 3: 35, God Shree Krishna states that 'it is better to perform one's own '*dharmā*', though tinged with imperfections, than perform another's '*dharmā*', though perfectly. It is better to die discharging one's duty like soldiers do at times, than to follow the path of another, which is fraught with danger'.

'Dharma' is used in different contexts to imply different things and hence is difficult to translate to English. The various meanings described are: 'faith/religion', 'righteousness', 'duty', 'good conduct', etc. If we take it to imply 'faith/religion', one can say that God suggested not to change your 'faith'. Some state that changing faith is like changing your parents. Most commentaries state that, in this verse, God was asking his devotee and friend to follow his call of duty and abide by his duty as a warrior prince to protect righteousness.

Many times, I thought of not writing this chapter to avoid becoming controversial. But I decided to keep it to bring up this issue of social

injustice. It does not affect most parts of the western world. It is largely a problem affecting those belonging to the Hindu faith. I have very good friends from all faiths. I am a Hindu, but my best friend in school was a Catholic. I studied in Catholic schools. I have been treated by a Christian oncologist, a Muslim oncologist, a Hindu oncologist, a Jewish surgeon, a Christian surgeon, a Jewish Radiation Oncologist and two Muslim cardiologists in the US. Doctors, nurses, dieticians, respiratory therapists of all different faiths of the world have been my health care providers and I am grateful to them. My most respected mentor was a Greek-Canadian who was a devout Catholic. Faith is a personal thing. I have been taught that different faiths of the world offer different ways of reaching the same ONE God, one ‘Truth’, and that all these paths are valid. Large parts of the world from all the faiths honor this. But there is some ‘organized system’ in the world that does not honor other faiths. I call proselytization an ‘organized system’ because it is not done randomly by random people. It is very organized and in some parts of the world, it is an industry, a business. People get compensated for converting people’s faith.

“Truth is one, but the wise men know it as many; God is one, but we can approach Him in many ways.”- Rig Veda

I have to share my painful experience with a missionary who unsuccessfully tried to change my faith while I was in the hospital. Hindus are probably the most affected by proselytization in the history of mankind. India was ruled by Muslim kings from the middle-east and the Christian viceroys of the United Kingdom for about 800 years. During this time thousands of temples were looted and destroyed. A lot of wealth was looted from India. The GDP of India came down from around 20% to less than 1% of the world’s GDP during these 800 years. Millions of Hindus were forced to change their faith, many were raped or killed. Since the independence of India in 1947, forcible

conversion has gone down. But the conversion by coercion and by approaching the vulnerable people has increased. I thought this happened only in India. But when I was admitted to the hospital, I was in a lot of pain and was getting narcotics for pain control. I was told that I was a little bit confused due to having an infection and getting narcotics. But I remember being in a lot of pain and I also remember arguing something with my sister. My family probably was panicking. One missionary saw my worried brother outside my room. She asked him if we would like her to pray for me. He readily agreed. I have always appreciated people praying for me and I am grateful to them. I know that many of my patients and friends have prayed for me in the churches and temples in Dallas. After she came to my room I agreed for her to pray for me, but I told her that I am a Hindu and I am fine being a Hindu. I think I must have sensed what was coming. She went on ranting how she did not come to my room on her own and that she was sent by Jesus. I was fine with that. Then to my astonishment, she kept repeating, 'this is the time to change your faith'. More surprisingly, my nurse was in the room and she participated in the 'prayer' and 'chanting'. I was not alright with this. I felt encroached and more. I felt that my faith was questioned at a very vulnerable time in my life. I felt that I was taken advantage of. I reported to the Pastoral department of the hospital and they agreed that it was wrong on the part of the missionary to approach me to change my faith. They also reminded me that the missionary was not a hospital staff and was just a visitor and that they have seen this happen in the past. When the missionary called me back after two-three days to see if we wanted her back in my room we told her that there was no such need. Missionaries do a lot of good services when there is a crisis. But in return, many of them ask the victims of the crisis to change their faith. Whenever you help a vulnerable person and expect something in return, it no longer

becomes a service. It becomes a deal! When you do this to a vulnerable person, it is disrespectful and it is an abuse of the vulnerable, a social injustice.

The Bhagavad Gita, the sacred book of Hindus explains three kinds of ‘charity’, one expecting nothing in return, one for fame, and one for something in return. Proselytization falls in the third category, the most inferior among the charities. I feel that this is an insult to God. I think that this is an insult to Jesus Christ. I have not read the Holy Bible fully, but I highly doubt that Jesus Christ suggested this. I think that this is a misinterpretation of the teachings of spreading love from the Holy Bible. If anybody believes that they have a better God, they are limiting the scope of God. If God indeed exists, there can be only one God for all living beings of all faiths of the world. God is omnipotent and omniscient. Just like all rivers join the same ocean, different faiths have different ways and paths to reach the same God. If any faith claims exclusivity to God, I consider them ignorant. I can disregard someone else’s ignorance. At least that is what some of my good friends suggested. I have been told that I am overreacting to this incident. I don’t think I am overreacting. In fact, I think that I have not done enough. I continue to reject and condemn this social injustice to thousands of vulnerable people across the world. I have moved on. But that does not take away the social injustice that is happening to thousands of vulnerable patients across the world who are being abused in the name of religious freedom. I still don’t appreciate it after so many years. I did not appreciate that the hospital did not take ownership of the problem even though it is true that these missionaries are not hospital employees. Anything that happens within the hospital building should be the hospital’s problem. I had a meeting with the head of the Pastoral department, but it did not go too far. Some appropriately call this ‘predatory proselytization’ because these

predators are waiting in the hospitals and refugee camps to invite their victims when they are most vulnerable.

My message to all the patients of the world is that you did not get sick because you don't worship God, it is not because you did not worship God the right way, it is not because your God is not as good as someone else's God, it is not because you do not belong to a particular faith, it is not because God is upset with you, it is not because God is punishing you. There cannot be a disciplinarian God and God is not a 'punishing body'. You do not get cured just because you changed your faith. In a Christian majority country such as the US, most cancer victims are Christians. In Hindu majority countries such as India, most cancer victims are Hindus. In Saudi Arabia, most cancer victims are Muslims, and in Israel, most cancer victims would be Jews. If someone tells you that his/her God is better than yours, I feel sorry for his/her ignorance. You don't have to be God-fearing; you just have to be God-loving.

I am going to quote part of Swami Vivekananda's speech at the World Parliament of Religions 1893 in Chicago in which he recognized this problem of leaders of one religion claiming superiority over the other. He said, "*Brothers and Sisters of America, much has been said of the common ground of religious unity. I am not going just now to venture my own theory. But if anyone here hopes that this unity will come by the triumph of any one of the religions and the destruction of the others, to him I say, 'Brother, yours is an impossible hope.' Do I wish that the Christian would become Hindu? God forbid. Do I wish that the Hindu or Buddhist would become Christian? God forbid. It has proved to the world that holiness, purity, and charity are not the exclusive possessions of any church in the world and that every system has produced men and women of the most exalted character. In the face of this evidence, if anybody dreams of the exclusive survival of his own religion and the*

destruction of the others, I pity him from the bottom of my heart, and point out to him that upon the banner of every religion will soon be written in spite of resistance: 'Help and not fight', 'Assimilation and not Destruction', 'Harmony and Peace, and not Dissension.'"

The proselytization industry has only gotten bigger and richer since then. The movie, *The Kashmir Files*, shows another criminal version of proselytization in Kashmir, India.

More needs to be done about this social injustice. I, unfortunately, have not done enough to stop this or expose this to the public. I should have. One problem is that those who have not gone through this don't get it. I could not even convince some of my family members that this is a serious problem. Missionaries claim that they are advocating religious freedom. My problem is that, why are you doing it on these vulnerable people at a vulnerable time? Nobody has approached me to change my faith when I was not in pain.

I also want to quote two verses from the Holy *Vivekachoodamani* that is self-explanatory and relevant here:

"There is only one God, not the second; not at all, not at all, not in the least bit."

"Supreme God (Brahman) itself is real, non-dual, extremely pure, the essence of knowledge absolute, taintless, supremely peaceful, without beginning or end, beyond all activity, always of the nature of bliss absolute, transcending all diversities created by illusion, eternal, the essence of joy, indivisible, immeasurable, formless, unmanifest, nameless, immutable, and self-effulgent". (Ekamevaadviteeya Brahma... from Vivekachoodamani, Verse 237 and 238)

Scriptures are often misquoted and mis-interpreted out of context depending upon the situation and the intention of the interpreter. My suggestion to anybody who wants to change their faith, irrespective of their faith, is to study your scripture first in full before you make a

decision. If you are Hindu, at least study The Bhagavad Gita from an authentic teacher, before you critique it by seeing how a particular Hindu is following a ritual or a particular Hindu is quoting a scripture out of context. If you are Christian, study the Holy Bible from a knowledgeable person. You will generally find good in most scriptures if you look for it.

Chapter 19

Creation or Genesis of Life and Evolution

Genesis is creation of life. Evolution is transformation of the body. Evolution starts from unicellular organism like Entamoeba to bicellular to multicellular organisms. Multicellular organisms start from fish, to amphibians, to mammals. Mammals evolve from four-legged animals to two-legged primitive human beings to more evolved human beings.

in Hindu scriptures, description of evolution is clearer than the description of genesis. This is mentioned in one of the oldest scriptures called 'Rig Veda', which is believed to be more than three thousand years old. The various incarnations (avatars) of God Vishnu are fish (Matsya), tortoise (Koorma), wild boar (Varaha), half human-half lion (Narasimha), dwarf man (Vaamana), primitive barbaric human being (Parashu Rama), more sophisticated and less violent human being (Rama), still more sophisticated human being (Krishna), enlightened human being (Buddha) and finally human being who is going to be destructive (Kalki). Among these Buddha as the ninth incarnation is controversial and tenth incarnation, Kalki, is yet to come. Some believe

that Balarama was the ninth incarnation instead of Buddha. Some scholars have noted an intriguing parallel between the ten incarnations of Vishnu, which progress from aquatic life to more complex beings — and the general pattern of biological Darwinian evolution, though this is a retrospective observation rather than a claim of ancient scientific knowledge.

Genesis of life is more complex. It is described in the Hymn of creation (Nasadiya Sukta) of Rig Veda in cryptic ways. Rig Veda states, 'then there was neither non-existence nor existence', 'neither death nor immortality was there, then, no sign of night or day', 'that which, becoming, by the void was covered', 'that One by the force of heat came into being', 'Seed bearers there were, mighty forces', 'The Universe emerged from this complex interaction, and from it arose the breath of life', 'The Gods came afterwards, with the creation of this universe', 'The One who looks down on it, only He knows, or perhaps He does not know'. This indicates that Universe started first, then the God (The ONE) and then the breath of life. This is also consistent with the Big Bang theory described more recently.

Bhagavatam, in chapters 10, 12 and 20, describes genesis of life. According to this text, genesis of life begins with the Supreme Being, Vishnu, who in a deep state of meditation, creates the creator, Brahma. Brahma generates the Universe, all living beings of all species including celestials and then human beings within it based on interaction between three modes of nature (Purity, Passion and Inertia).

Chapter 20

Principles of Healthy Eating

Match your food with your personality: Match the different kinds of foods with similar kinds of personalities. In chapter 17 of *The Bhagavad Gita*, God talks about three kinds of food, three kinds of offerings, and three kinds of characters. He talks about ‘selfish and lazy (*tamasik*)’, ‘passionate (*rajasik*)’, and ‘peaceful (*saatvik*)’ people. Lazy (*tamasik*) nature is that which fulfills one’s desires, which are centered on the physical self. Passionate (*rajasik*) character aims at achieving one’s ambitions and seeking material comfort. The peaceful (*saatvik*) character focuses on peace and noble thoughts and actions. In reality, the link between the kind of food and the character/nature of the person is mutual. The type of food affects the nature of the person and the people of certain nature eat their kind of food.

The Gita recommends food in the mode of goodness (*saatvik*), probably vegetarian foods: “Foods dear to those in the mode of goodness increase the duration of life, purify one’s existence, and give strength, health, happiness, and satisfaction.” The Gita also says that such foods are “wholesome and pleasing to the heart.” (BG 17.8)

At the same time, the same book says, “Foods that are too bitter, too sour, salty, hot, pungent, dry, and burning are dear to those in the mode of passion (*rajasik*). Such foods cause distress, misery, and disease.” (BG 17.9)

And, it continues, “Food prepared more than three hours before being eaten, food that is tasteless, decomposed and putrid, and food consisting of remnants and untouchable things is dear to those in the mode of darkness” (BG 17.10). In modern science, the field of probiotics is gaining popularity. Probiotics are ‘healthy germs’. Foods such as pickles, yogurt, and buttermilk are natural sources of probiotics. These are some ‘putrid’ foods that may be healthy and hence are exceptions to this teaching.

‘Make eating a spiritual experience and a spiritual exercise. Feed yourself as though you are feeding God.’

Eat as though you are feeding the ‘God’ in you: Regardless of the food, eat with gratitude, a prayerful attitude, and mental poise. Pray before eating and eat with family without any TV or audio background. A common prayer from the *Bhagavad Gita* (BG 4.24) is recited before eating.

The English translation of that verse goes as follows:

The whole creation, being the gross projection of God, the Cosmic Consciousness itself; the food too is God, the process of offering it is God, it is being offered in the fire of God. He who thus sees that God in action reaches God alone. (Bhagavad Gita: 4:24)

The simpler interpretation and application of this verse is to prepare and eat food as an offering to God. Feed yourself as though you are feeding God. When you are feeding God, you are likely to choose only healthy food in a healthy proportion. The 14th verse of the 15th chapter of Gita is also commonly chanted before eating making eating a spiritual experience.

The Bhagavad Gita and several other scriptures teach us that our body is a temple. Considering food as an offering to God makes a lot of sense. It allows us to surrender to God before eating, but more importantly, it allows us to express gratitude to the food, the people who cultivated food, the people who prepared food, the people who served food, and finally God for making the whole process possible. It also is an opportunity to sit together with family and friends and appreciate the divinity in the food and people involved in the food coming to our plates. This is very well practiced in the east and the west in all faiths. Americans have a popular nursery rhyme:

‘Thank you, God, for the world so sweet,

Thank you, God, for the food we eat,

Thank you, God, for the birds that sing,

Thank you, God, for everything.’

This sounds biblical, simple, and easy.

‘We thank you, Lord, for giving us the food we need for living.

So bless us while we eat it because we really need it.’

‘We thank you for the food, Lord. For Mom and Dad and you, Lord, the food, the fun, the friendship, of your big Family.’ All these are exceptional, simple, and powerful. Pick one or all of them and practice every day. All these are ways to practice gratitude daily in our lives. If you are not doing it already, please try it yourself. You will love it.

The seventeenth chapter of the Gita elaborates in detail on healthy eating. Healthy eating habits are also mentioned in other parts of the Gita and in other scriptures, such as the Upanishads. Since most health problems are related to improper diet and stress, many can be prevented if we follow these guidelines and meditate on a regular basis.

This can be summarized as follows.

- Pray before eating

- Thank God and people before you eat.
- Vegetarian food is likely better than animal-based food.
- Fresh and juicy food is healthy.
- Putrid, overcooked, re-cooked, burnt (*kabab* or *barbeque*), pungent, bitter, very sour, very salty, very hot and very pungent foods are unhealthy.
- Eat in moderation.

It is no wonder that fresh vegetarian food has more heart-healthy and cancer-protective elements. Vegetarian diets are gaining popularity in the Western world as well. The book 'What is Hinduism?', published by the Himalaya Academy, has some very convincing arguments to support vegetarianism, including health benefits and reducing global warming. My recent book, 'The Power of Infinity,' covers a lot about healthy diet and lifestyle.

A simple way to pray before eating is to just thank God before eating. Some examples of traditional prayers before eating are:

1. Bhagavad Gita 4:24*: For those who are completely absorbed in God-consciousness, the oblation is Brahman, the ladle with which it is offered is Brahman, the act of offering is Brahman, and the sacrificial fire is also Brahman. Such persons, who view everything as God, easily attain Him. *My simplest interpretation of this prayer is, feed yourself as though you are feeding God. You can never be wrong if you do so.*
2. Bhagavad Gita 15:14**: It is I who take the form of the fire of digestion in the stomachs of all living beings and combine with the incoming and outgoing breaths to digest and as-

simulate the four kinds of foods. *My way of paraphrasing this is, 'Thank you God for providing me food, the ability to digest and assimilate food and the ability to breathe in and out'*

3. Oh, Mother Goddess of food fullness/abundance (Anna Poorneshwari), the darling of Shankara, give me alms, or knowledge and renunciation, forever. *My practical paraphrasing of this prayer is, 'My gratitude to my God, who came as Mother in my life for feeding me, providing me knowledge, and teaching me life lessons including the power of sacrifice.'*

1

1. *Gita 4:24: *Brahmaarpanam Brahma havir brahmaagnau
brahmanaabutam*

Chapter 21

Idol Worship Is Not Really Worshipping the Idol

The most common misunderstanding

If there is one thing about Hinduism that is most frequently misunderstood by outsiders, it is this: people see a Hindu praying before a stone or bronze figure and conclude that Hindus worship idols. They don't. Hindus worship God. The image — known as a murti — is not the object of worship. It is the medium through which worship is directed, the way a telephone is not the person you are speaking to but the instrument that connects you to them.

The family portrait

Think of it this way. Most families keep photographs of loved ones at home — on the mantelpiece, on a desk, in a wallet. No one looks at a family portrait and thinks "that is a piece of paper with some ink on it." You see the face of your mother, your child, your spouse. You feel

love, connection, memory. You might even speak to the photograph, kiss it, hold it close during difficult times.

Does anyone accuse you of worshipping a piece of paper? Of course not. Everyone understands that the photograph is a symbol — a tangible reminder of someone real and beloved.

A murti works in exactly the same way. It is a tangible form through which a devotee connects with the formless divine. The stone is not God. The bronze is not God. But God is experienced through them — just as love is experienced through a photograph.

What makes a idol (murti) sacred

There is, however, one important difference between a family photograph and a temple idol. A murti is not simply carved and placed on a shelf. It undergoes a sacred ceremony called prana pratishtha — literally, "the establishment of life breath." Through specific rituals, prayers, chanting of mantras, and meditation, the divine is formally invited to inhabit the image. After this consecration, the murti is treated as a living presence.

This is why, in Hindu temples, the deity is woken each morning, bathed, dressed in fresh garments, offered food, adorned with flowers, presented with music and incense, and put to rest each evening. These are not rituals performed to a statue. They are acts of love and devotion offered to a living divine presence that has been invited to dwell in that form — so that ordinary people can see, touch, and experience God in their daily lives.

Why form helps

Most human beings think in images, not abstractions. If someone says "think about love," your mind doesn't produce a philosophical definition — it produces a face. A moment. A memory. Hindu sages understood this about human psychology thousands of years ago. They knew that while the ultimate reality (Brahman) is formless and

infinite, most people need something concrete — a face, a name, a story — to anchor their devotion.

That is what the idol provides. It is not a limitation of God. It is a gift to the human mind — a way to make the infinite accessible to finite beings.

Prayer at home and in the temple

Many Hindu families dedicate a corner, a shelf, or even an entire room in their home for prayer. Some build a small temple (mandir) inside the house. A home altar might hold one or several murtis, photographs of deities or gurus, an oil lamp, incense, and fresh flowers. Daily prayer at the home altar — even for just a few minutes — is one of the most common forms of Hindu practice.

In temples, worship takes on a larger, communal dimension. Prayer by a large group in the presence of the deity, accompanied by chanting of mantras, devotional music, the fragrance of sandalwood, and the glow of oil lamps creates an atmosphere that many devotees describe as profoundly moving — even overwhelming. Out of respect, Hindus remove their shoes before entering the prayer area and dress modestly.

The full spectrum

Not all Hindus worship through images. As we discussed in Chapter 9, some prefer to worship Nirguna Brahman — the formless, attribute less divine — through meditation, contemplation, or the chanting of OM. Some connect through a guru or teacher rather than a deity. Some worship through selfless action without any image or ritual at all. Some see the divine in nature be it in a tree, a river, a mountain, a snake, a dog, or even an elephant.

Hinduism honors the entire spectrum. Whether you need a face to look at, a name to call, a mantra to chant, or simply silence — there is a place for you. The tradition trusts that you will find the form

of practice that connects you most deeply, and it celebrates whatever form that takes.

As the Bhagavad Gita teaches in whatever way people approach the divine, the divine meets them there.

Hindus don't worship idols. They worship God, sometimes with using certain media such as images and idols.

Chapter 22

Dharma And Adharma

T*he word at the center of everything*

You've already encountered the word dharma several times in this book — it appeared in the very first chapter, where we learned that Hinduism's traditional name is Sanatana Dharma, "the eternal dharma." But what does dharma actually mean?

The honest answer is that no single English word captures it. Dharma has been translated as religion, duty, righteousness, law, ethics, cosmic order, and "the right way to live" — and it means all of these things simultaneously. If you had to choose one phrase, it might be this: dharma is the moral and ethical foundation that sustains individuals, families, communities, and the universe itself. When people act in accordance with dharma, life flourishes. When they don't, things fall apart.

It is the closest thing Hinduism has to a single organizing principle — and understanding it is the key to understanding everything else in this tradition.

The layers of dharma

One reason dharma is so rich is that it operates on several levels at once:

Universal dharma — the cosmic order that governs nature itself. The sun rises, the seasons turn, rivers flow to the sea. This is dharma at the largest scale — the principle that the universe is not chaos but an ordered, purposeful reality.

Ethical dharma — the moral principles that apply to all human beings, regardless of their role or station. These include truthfulness, non-violence, compassion, self-discipline, generosity, forgiveness, modesty, and contentment. The Yoga Sutras of Sage Patanjali organize these into yamas (restraints — things to avoid) and niyamas (observances — things to cultivate).

Personal dharma (Svadharmā) — the duty that is uniquely yours, based on your stage of life, your responsibilities, and your nature. A parent's dharma includes caring for their children. A doctor's dharma includes healing. A student's dharma includes learning with sincerity. Your svadharmā is not someone else's — and the Gita teaches that it is better to fulfill your own dharma imperfectly than someone else's perfectly.

Situational dharma — the recognition that life sometimes places us in situations where duties conflict, and we must use wisdom and discernment to navigate them. The entire Bhagavad Gita is born from exactly this tension: Arjuna's personal dharma (do not harm your own family) clashes with his social dharma (fight for righteousness). Krishna's teaching is his answer to that impossible dilemma.

Adharma and the six inner enemies

If dharma is what sustains life, adharma is what destroys it — the absence of morality, ethics, and right conduct. Hindu tradition identifies six inner enemies that pull a person away from dharma:

Unchecked desire (kama), anger (krodha), greed (lobha), ego/pride (madha), jealousy (matsarya), and delusion (moha).

Notice that these are not external forces. They are internal. Hinduism does not locate evil in a devil or a demon — it locates it in the unchecked tendencies of the human mind. The battle between dharma and adharma is fought within you, every day, in the choices you make. The yoga tradition prescribes focus of mind, ethical practice, and self-awareness as the means to achieve victory over these enemies.

The Gita's promise

One of the most famous verses in the Bhagavad Gita addresses what happens when adharma rises and dharma declines: "Whenever there is a decline in dharma and a rise in adharma, O Arjuna, I manifest Myself. For the protection of the good, for the destruction of the wicked, and for the re-establishment of dharma, I appear in every age." — Bhagavad Gita 4.7–4.8¹

This is one of the most powerful and comforting promises in all of Hindu scripture. It says that the universe is not indifferent to injustice. When things go wrong — truly, deeply wrong — the divine itself intervenes to restore balance. Hindus understand this not only as a historical claim about past incarnations (the Dashavatar), but as a living principle: dharma will ultimately prevail.

What dharma looks like in daily life

Dharma is not something you practice only in a temple or during a crisis. It shows up in ordinary moments. Telling the truth when a small lie would be easier — that is dharma. Doing your job with care even when no one is watching — that is dharma. Treating a stranger with the same respect you would show a guest in your home — that is

1. *Yadā yadā hi dharmasya glānir bhavati Bhārata Abhyutthānam
adharmasya tadātmānam sṛjāmyaham*

dharmā. Pausing before reacting in anger and choosing a measured response instead — that is dharmā.

Dr. Venkata Raju, inspired by Swami Bodhananda Sarasvati, created a beautiful acronym that captures the spirit of dharmā in daily practice:

D — *Detached Engagement. Give your complete effort but release your attachment to the outcome.*

H — *Happily Work. Work with joy — don't work for happiness, work from happiness.*

A-R — *Act with Response, not Reaction. Pause. Reflect. Choose your response rather than reacting on reflex.*

M — *Moderation in Everything. In eating, in spending, in ambition, in rest — balance is the key.*

A — *Appreciation of Everything, Everyone, Everywhere. Gratitude is not a feeling. It is a practice.*

This is dharmā, simplified. You can memorize it in a minute. You can practice it for a lifetime.

Chapter 23

Status Of Women In Hinduism

Women enjoy good status in Hinduism. A Hindu woman, Mrs. Indira Gandhi holding the highest political position in India as early as 1968 is a testimony to this. India also has had woman Presidents. Hindu scriptures hold women to very high esteem.

There have been many women who have valiantly fought to free India from the British. In fact, it was a women queen, Jhansi Rani Laxmibai, who galvanized the freedom fight in 1857.

In fact, Devi Mahatmyam, one of the Holy Scriptures describe about all the Gods putting together their strengths to create the strongest possible God to fight the evil forces. That strongest god was a Goddess, Devi, also called Adi Shakti, which means eternal strength. Some of the other names and incarnations of this goddess are Mother Durga, Kaali, etc. Mothers hold a very high position in Hindu families and should be served as Goddesses (Matr devobhava).

In Hinduism, earth and one's own country are given feminine status by addressing earth as 'mother earth' and country as 'Mother

India'. Moreover, Hindi speeches begin by addressing ladies as 'Deviyon' which means 'Supreme Goddesses'.

This does not mean that there were no problems for Hindu women. In ancient days, the wives of slain soldiers committed suicide by jumping into the fire during their husbands' cremation. They did so for fear of getting abused and sometimes raped by the men from the enemies' kingdom. Such abuse was very common when Muslim kings ruled India and looted Hindu temples.

During the dark ages, this became a custom to the point of forcing the widows to jump into fire when the husband died even though this is not suggested in any Hindu scriptures. Even now there are instances of women abuse, but this is not a religious issue, it is a social issue all over the world including the developed countries. US has never had a women president!

I could not find a better quote than 'Devi Suktam' to depict womanhood in Hinduism. This is the summary translation of one of the oldest Hindu scriptures, 'Devi Suktam', part of Rg Veda. Rg Veda is at least 5000 years old (3000 BCE or earlier), a few thousand years before most of the other currently practiced religions of the world started. These are the words of the 'Almighty Goddess, Durga' spoken by a female saint:

I am Devi (Female Goddess's name),
I am Shakti ('Energy'),
I am God of the world,
I am the worshipped,
I provide the means to worship,
I have created the world, and human society,
And its riches,
I am knowledge, I manifest knowledge,
I am worshipped by the Gods,

I feed the world and grant divinization.

The sky who is the father, I am the mother to him.

I am spread over the world, the sky and the ocean.

I move through the world as wind.

As freely, I manifest myself as the world.

It's my glory'.

She is the creator (procreative), all powerful and collaborative epitome of feminine excellence, INFINITY! During the 5000+ years since this was written, the world has seen lots of ups and downs for the women society. Hindus, representing one fifth of the world population have also seen their fair share of women oppression as has rest of the world and all the religions of the world. Today is a good day to re-live the feminine excellence that Goddess told in Devi Sukta over 5000 years ago. This prayer reminds us that women were able to be Hindu saints 5000 years ago and Supreme God was worshipped in female form 5000 years ago.

Chapter 24

Non-Violence (Ahimsa)

Non-violence is an essential component of yoga philosophy. The most successful victory for non-violence in the history was in India getting independence from the British government in 1947 under the guidance of Mahatma Gandhi. However, it is wrong to give all the credit to Mahatma Gandhi. Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel needs to be given lot of credit. Many freedom fighters such as Jhansi Rani Laxmibai, Subhash Chandra Bose, Bhagat Singh and many others have fought war against the British and have contributed to freeing India.

Two prominent spiritual and political leaders who were influenced by Mahatma Gandhi are Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. and Dalai Lama. M.L. K. Jr. successfully led the fight for equality for the African Americans in the United States and Dalai Lama, who has been living in India for his safety, is still fighting for justice for the Buddhists in Tibet.

Hinduism recommends different degrees of non-violence such as patience, negotiation and non-violent war (non-co-operation movement, parades, etc.) to settle the conflicts. Non-violence, as a sign of protecting creatures that cannot defend themselves, is also part of the logic behind vegetarianism.

Buddhism and Jainism, two ancient Indian traditions that developed alongside the broader religious culture of ancient India, are very strong supporters of non-violence. Hinduism does support violence as the last resort to protect righteousness if the non-violent ways fail.

The epics in Hinduism, such as *Devi Mahatmyam*, *Ramayana*, and *Mahabharata*, had wars to protect righteousness (dharma, ethics) when the non-violent means failed. In the epic *Mahabharata*, God Krishna had to persuade Prince Arjuna to fight the righteous war. Hindus have to know that Hinduism is not all about being non-violent. It is not. There have been many righteous wars described in the Hindu scriptures. 'Nonviolence' is not the responsibility (inadequately translated as 'swadharma') of a warrior responsible for protecting the nation! But it is a tenet of the one who follows the path of yoga prescribed by Sage Patanjali. We need all kinds of people including warriors.

God Krishna says that fighting a just war is the duty of the warrior when war is the only option left. This is very well described in the 2nd and 18th chapters of the Gita. God Krishna goes on to say that not performing one's obligatory duties from delusion is lazy renunciation, not doing these duties because they are painful is passionate renunciation, and both kinds of renunciations are unacceptable.

One must have the discriminative ability to realize when non-violent means are not working. Hindus, Jains and Buddhists do take some criticism for being too tolerant even when evil forces are hurting them.

Tolerance is a good trait; acceptance is still better, but inaction is not a good quality when action is necessary. When peaceful methods fail, warriors fight war, and sometimes, lives are lost in their attempts to fight for their nation. That is the duty of the warrior.

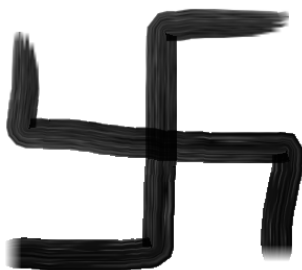
Nonviolence also means compassion and respect for people and the world. This should be our daily practice. Saving the environment and

being earth-friendly is an act of compassion. Moderation in resource consumption is an act of nonviolence. Not hurting the feelings of others is an act of nonviolence.

Chapter 25

Swastika and Hakenkreuz are not the same

Swastika sign (卐 or 卍) is an auspicious sign among Hindus, Jains and Buddhists. This is usually in red color, with some variations.



Swastika



This has to be differentiated from the ‘Hakenkreuz’ sign introduced by Adolph Hitler as the Nazi symbol. ‘Hakenkreuz’ is considered a symbol of hatred and the US government bans ‘Hakenkreuz’. This is usually in black surrounded by red circle.



Hakenkreuz (not Swastika)

This is ‘Hakenkreuz’ and it should not be called ‘Swastika’. They are as different as ‘+’ and ‘X’ signs in mathematics! Swastika is a sign of ‘auspiciousness’ and ‘Hakenkreuz’ is considered a sign of hatred.

Chapter 26

Bindi: Dot on the Forehead

It is common for Hindu women to wear a dot, vermillion on their forehead with a maroon-colored powder consisting of mixture of turmeric, saffron, sandal wood and some other powders with medicinal properties.

This is called Bindi. Men also apply the holy powder or paste on their forehead. Besides being decorative, it has special significance. God Shiva has a very powerful third eye in his forehead. It is believed to have supernatural powers.

In spiritual sense, this represents spiritual command center (Aajna Chakra: Aajna = command, Chakra = plexus or wheel). This is also called Third eye or the sacred fire. Medically speaking, this likely refers to areas of the brain which control the emotions, hormones secretion, sleep and sexual behavior. *Sindoor is a pride of Hindu women.*

Often widows don't wear it as a sign of mourning. Many western Hindu women have stopped wearing bindi in order not to look different and to avoid getting unnecessary attention in the public areas.

However, they usually wear it when they wear Indian dress and attend formal Hindu functions or religious occasions.



Woman wearing 'Bindi on her forehead

Chapter 27

Gayatri Mantra

Gayatri mantra is from Rg Veda and is believed to be a very powerful and the most sacred mantra for Hindus. There are many interpretations of the meaning of this mantra. This mantra was originally chanted by sage Vishwamitra. It is generally chanted during dawn but can be chanted at other times too.

The simplistic meaning that I could find is:

'O effulgent light that has given birth to all the worlds and spheres of consciousness,

O God, who appears through the shining Sun, illumine our intellect'.

Verbatim translation of the verse is:

Om: Om (The primordial sound/mantra)

Bhur (Bhuh): The earth, representing the physical human body, physical existence

Bhuvah: The space, vital energies, heaven, consciousness

Svah: The spiritual realm

Tat: That (That divine reality)

Savitur: The Sun, the source of all lights

Varenyam: To choose, the best, adore

Bhargo: Effulgence, self-illuminating, divine light

Devasya: The divine, radiant

Dhimahi: meditate upon

Dhiyo: the intellect

Yo: may this light

Nah: Our, of us

Prachodayat: Illuminate, inspire

One can further simplify this as a prayer to Sun to enlighten our intellect. It is hard to describe Gayatri mantra without complicating this book with details and hence I would recommend the interested readers to refer to *Gayatri, The Highest Meditation* by Sagduru Sant Keshavdas. To experience the effect of chanting, I would recommend chanting this mantra for at least 11 times everyday morning for at least 3 weeks at a stretch and then continue forever if you like it.

Generally, fathers teach (whisper) this mantra to their sons when they celebrate ‘growing up (graduating to adult life)’, a ceremony called ‘Upanayanam’, also called thread ceremony. This ceremony is generally done in families with priests, but Gayatri mantra is a universal and very powerful prayer that can be chanted at any time by anybody of all genders, all ages and all backgrounds.

The full Gayatri mantra is as follows:

‘Om bhoor bhuvah svah; Tat Savitur varaenyam

Bhargo devasya dheemahi; Dhiyo yo nah prachodaayaat’

SECTION IV

And in section four, we walk through the wisdom of the Bhagavad Gita chapter by chapter as sections dedicated to introduction, first six chapters on path of Karma, second six chapters on the path of devotion and a final section on chapters 13-18 dedicated to the path of knowledge of the Divine Self. Since the Bhagavad Gita has 700 verses, only the take home message from each chapter and important verses has been explained.

Chapter 28

Wisdom from Bhagavad Gita: Introduction

The Vedic scriptures are vast, but three of them have traditionally been called the Prasthān Trayī (three points of commencement for understanding Vedic thought). These are the Upanishads, the Brahma Sutras, and the Bhagavad Gita.

The Bhagavad Gita provides a comprehensive and easy-to-understand summary of the Vedic wisdom. Bhagavad Gita means “Song of God.” It is a dialogue that took place between the Supreme God Shri Krishna and His devotee Arjuna in the middle of battlefield, at the beginning of the Mahabharata war. The purpose of the Bhagavad Gita is to impart the science of God-realization (~experiencing God), The Absolute Truth, in day to day life to common people like us. Gita is a problem solver and provider of knowledge and remover of darkness of ignorance. It is a practical guide of leading a moral life, a ‘Human Resource Manual’. When you study it carefully, you will realize that it is very contemporary and applicable in this 21st century.

The Bhagavad Gita was originally compiled by Veda Vyasa as a part of a bigger story called Mahabharata. The Mahabharata is the largest

poem in the world consisting of one hundred thousand verses. It is three times bigger than the Holy Bible.

All its eighteen chapters are designated as different types of Yoga because they deal with methodologies for the application of spiritual knowledge to practical life.

Setting: The setting in which the Bhagavad Gita was spoken was the onset of the Mahabharata, a colossal war that was about to begin between two sets of cousins. On one side were five noble brothers, Arjuna being their supreme hero. They were saintly and virtuous—the epitomes of morality, sacrifice, devotion, and compassion. Most importantly, they were great devotees of the Supreme God Shri Krishna who became the charrioteer for Arjuna. On the opposite side were one hundred brothers who embodied cruelty, injustice, vice, oppression, and irreligion. When all the peaceful dialogues failed, war became inevitable. Just before the combat was about to begin, Arjuna requested Shri Krishna to pull his chariot between the two armies. On seeing the warriors who had arrayed themselves for combat, Arjuna lost heart. As an act of despondency, he threw down his bow and refused to fight. Arjuna surrendered to the Supreme God and supplicated for guidance on what the proper course of action for him was. In this state of Arjuna's moral confusion, Shri Krishna set out to enlighten him.

Our approach in studying the Gita must therefore be to not make it a scholastic or academic scrutiny of its message, nor an effort to place its philosophy in the context of contending schools of thought. The Gita is not a treatise of metaphysical philosophy, despite the profusion of metaphysical ideas that arise from its pages. Instead, it seeks the highest truth for the highest practical utility, not for intellectual or even spiritual satisfaction, but as the truth that saves and opens to us the passage from our present mortal imperfection to an immortal perfection. We must therefore approach it for help and light in receiving

the living message that can benefit human beings attain the highest welfare and spiritual perfection.

Eighteen chapters of Gita are divided into three sections. The first six chapters describe about experiencing God through performing duty in an unselfish manner as a service to God, as a service to humanity without attachment to the result of action. This is called Karma path. Chapters seven to twelve focus on unwavering love and devotion to God as a path to experience God. This is called 'Bhakti' (devotion) path. The final set of six chapters 13-18 describe the importance of knowledge of God, both the divine nature of True Self and the Universal God. This is the path of knowledge (Jnana), another way of experiencing God. However, there is lot of overlap of these paths since they are not mutually exclusive.

Chapter 29

Wisdom from Bhagavad Gita: Section One` (Chapters 1-6): Path of Action (Karma) to Experience God

Chapter 1: Despondency and self-doubt

This chapter shows the mental distress of Arjuna in facing tough situations in life, his modesty to surrender to God and seek solutions to his misery. God Krishna, shows us his skill of listening without interruption.

What is there for me? When you are in trouble, have the courage to recognize and acknowledge it, have the humility to seek help even if you are the king, leader or a celebrity. Another lesson to learn from this chapter is about power of silence and listening.

Initial Steps in facing a big problem:

1. Pause and think
2. Admit that there is a problem to solve
3. Ask questions and seek guidance, both human and divine, to get the best solution possible

Chapter 2: Analytics

Arise, awake, stop not till your goal is reached:

Chapter 2:2 The Supreme God said: My dear Arjuna, how has this delusion overcome you in this hour of peril? It is not befitting an honorable person. It leads not to the higher abodes, but to disgrace.

2:3 O Partha, it does not befit you to yield to this unmanliness. Give up such petty weakness of heart and arise, O vanquisher of enemies.

Life is immortal (Do not fear about death of the body):

2:11 The Supreme God said: While you speak words of wisdom, you are mourning for that which is not worthy of grief. The wise lament neither for the living nor for the dead.

2:13 Just as the embodied soul continuously passes from childhood to youth to old age, similarly, at the time of death, the soul passes into another body. The wise are not deluded by this.

2:17 No one can cause the destruction of the imperishable soul.

2:18 Only the material body is perishable; the embodied soul is indestructible, immeasurable, and eternal. Therefore, fight, O descendant of Bharat.

2:19 The soul neither kills nor can it be killed.

2:20 The soul is neither born, nor does it ever die; nor having once existed, does it ever cease to be. The soul is without birth, eternal, immortal, and ageless. It is not destroyed when the body is destroyed.

2:21 How can one who knows the soul to be imperishable, eternal, unborn, and immutable kill anyone or cause anyone to kill?

2:23 Weapons cannot shred the soul, nor can fire burn it. Water cannot wet it, nor can the wind dry it.

2:24 The soul is unbreakable and incombustible; it can neither be dampened nor dried. It is everlasting, in all places, unalterable, immutable, and primordial.

2:25 The soul is spoken of as invisible, inconceivable, and unchangeable. Knowing this, you should not grieve for the body.

2:27 Death is certain for one who has been born, and rebirth is inevitable for one who has died. Therefore, you should not lament over the inevitable.

2:28 All created beings are unmanifest before birth, manifest in life, and again unmanifest on death. So why grieve?

2:30 The soul that dwells the body is immortal; therefore, you should not mourn for anyone.

God is Omniscient, God transcends time, space and object:

2:12 Never was there a time when I did not exist, nor you, nor all these kings; nor in the future shall any of us cease to be.

How to be great?

2:15 O Arjuna, noblest amongst men, that person who is not affected by happiness and distress, and remains steady in both, becomes eligible for liberation.

Defending righteousness is an opportunity. Perform your rightful duty with equanimity.

2:32 Happy are the warriors to whom such opportunities to defend righteousness comes unsought

2:38 Fight for the sake of duty, treating alike happiness and distress, loss and gain, victory and defeat. Fulfilling your responsibility in this way, you will never incur sin.

Transcend the material world to experience the pure consciousness:

2:45 Rise above the three modes to a state of pure spiritual consciousness. Freeing yourself from dualities (right and wrong, pain and

pleasure, hot and cold, happiness and unhappiness), eternally fixed in Truth, and without concern for material gain and safety, be situated in the self.

Do your duties without attachment to results, do not give company to inaction, work with best of the skills you have:

2:47 You have a right to perform your prescribed duties, but you are not entitled to the fruits of your actions. Never consider yourself to be the cause of the results of your activities, nor be attached to inaction.

2:48 Be steadfast in the performance of your duty, O Arjuna, abandoning attachment to success and failure. Such equanimity is called Yoga.

2:50 Therefore, strive for working skillfully (in proper consciousness).

2:51 The wise endowed with equanimity of intellect, abandon attachment to the fruits of actions, which bind one to the cycle of life and death. By working in such consciousness, they attain the state beyond all suffering.

What are the features of a wise, enlightened, equipoised person?

2:55 When one discards all selfish desires and cravings of the senses that torment the mind, and becomes satisfied in the realization of the self, such a person is said to be transcendently situated.

2:56 One whose mind remains undisturbed amidst misery, who does not crave for pleasure, and who is free from attachment, fear, and anger, is called a sage of steady wisdom.

2:57 One who remains unattached under all conditions, and is neither delighted by good fortune nor dejected by tribulation, he is a sage with perfect knowledge.

2:58 One who is able to withdraw the senses from their objects, just as a tortoise withdraws its limbs into its shell, is established in divine wisdom.

2:59 Aspirants may restrain the senses from their objects of enjoyment, but the taste for the sense objects remains. However, even this taste ceases for those who realize the Supreme.

2:60 It is not easy to be equipoised in the middle of distractions

2:61 They are established in perfect knowledge, who subdue their senses and keep their minds ever absorbed in Me.

2:62 and 2:63: Ladder of self destruction from desires

Contemplation in sense objects leads to attachment to them, attachment to sensual objects lead to desire for them, desire leads to anger if the desire is not fulfilled; anger leads to delusion, delusion leads to loss of memory and loss of memory leads to destruction of discriminative capacity; and loss of discrimination leads to self-destruction.

CONTEMPLATION ON SENSE OBJECTS □ ATTACHMENT TO SENSE OBJECTS □ CRAVING (LUST) □ ANGER □ LACK OF JUDGEMENT □ BIVILDERMENT OF MEMORY □ LOSS OF INTELLIGENCE □ SELF DESTRUCTION

Focused mind is a happy mind:

2: 64 One who controls the mind, and is free from attachment and aversion, even while using the objects of the senses, attains the Grace of God.

2:65 By divine grace comes the peace in which all sorrows end, and the intellect of such a person of tranquil mind soon becomes firmly established in God.

2:67 Just as a strong wind sweeps a boat off its chartered course on the water, even one of the senses on which the mind focuses can lead the intellect astray.

2: 68 Therefore, one who has restrained the senses from their objects, O mighty armed Arjun, is firmly established in transcendental knowledge.

2:70 Just as the ocean remains undisturbed by the incessant flow of waters from rivers merging into it, likewise the sage who is unmoved despite the flow of desirable objects all around him attains peace, and not the person who strives to satisfy desires.

2:71 That person, who gives up all material desires and lives free from a sense of greed, proprietorship, and egoism, attains perfect peace.

Think of God at least at the time of death to realize God:

2:72 O Such is the state of an enlightened soul that having attained it, one is never again deluded. Being established in this consciousness even at the hour of death, one is liberated from the cycle of life and death and reaches the Supreme Abode of God.

What is there for me?

This chapter has lots of life lessons. I almost see this as the abridged version of the whole book. These are highlights.

1. Live your role in the world. If you are the king, be the king. If you are the warrior, be a great warrior. Don't run away from

the battlefield. Don't run away from your responsibilities.

2. Do your duties focusing on the duty, the act and the utmost skill, without focusing on the end result.
3. Don't fear death. You are immortal. Your 'truth' is immortal and your 'truth' cannot die.
4. Attachment and greed lead to spiraling events leading to self-destruction.
5. Be equipoised in all situations.
6. Think of God all the time including the time of death by making everything you do as a divine act.

Chapter 3: Karma

Doing one's duties is a path to enlightenment:

3:3 God Krishna tells his devotee (Arjuna): The two paths leading to enlightenment were previously explained by Me: the path of knowledge, for those inclined toward contemplation, and the path of work for those inclined toward action.

Is action (Karma) predestined?:

3:5 There is no one who can remain without action even for a moment. Indeed, all beings are compelled to act by their qualities born of material nature.

3:8 Action is superior to inaction

3:9 Work must be done as an offering to the Supreme Lord; otherwise, work causes bondage in this material world. Therefore for the satisfaction of God, perform your prescribed duties, without being attached to the results.

Donate:

3:10 "Prosper in the performance of these *yajñas* (sacrifices), for they shall bestow upon you all you wish to achieve."

3:12 The celestial gods, being satisfied by the performance of sacrifice, will grant you all the desired necessities of life.

3:13 The spiritually-minded, who eat food that is first offered in sacrifice, are released from all kinds of ill effects.

Circle of life, food and nature:

3:14 All living beings subsist on food, and food is produced by rains. Rains come from the performance of sacrifice, and sacrifice is produced by the performance of prescribed duties.

Lead by doing your duties for greater good:

3:1 Giving up attachment, perform actions as a matter of duty because by working without being attached to the fruits, one attains the Supreme.

3: 20-21 By performing their prescribed duties, King Janak and others attained perfection. You should also perform your duties to set an example for the good of the world. Whatever actions great persons perform, common people follow. Whatever standards they set, all the world pursues.

3:30 Performing all works as an offering unto Me, constantly meditate on Me as the Supreme. Become free from desire and selfishness, and with your mental grief departed, fight!

3:36: Devotee (Arjuna) asked God: Why is a person impelled to commit sinful acts, even unwillingly, as if by force?

3:37-43:

The Supreme God said: It is lust (desire) alone, which is born of contact with the mode of passion, and later transformed into anger. Know this as the sinful, all-devouring enemy in the world.

Just as a fire is covered by smoke, a mirror is masked by dust, and an embryo is concealed by the womb, similarly one's knowledge gets covered by desire.

The knowledge of even the most discerning gets covered by this perpetual enemy in the form of insatiable desire, which is never satisfied and burns like fire.

The senses, mind, and intellect are said to be breeding grounds of desire. Through them, it clouds one's knowledge and deludes the embodied soul.

Therefore, in the very beginning bring the senses under control and slay this enemy called desire, which is the embodiment of sin and destroys knowledge and realization.

The senses are superior to the gross body, and superior to the senses is the mind. Beyond the mind is the intellect, and even beyond the intellect is the soul.

Thus knowing that soul to be superior to the material intellect, subdue the lower self (senses, mind, and intellect) by the higher self (strength of the soul), and kill this formidable enemy called desire.

What is there for me?

1. If you do your duties as an offering to God, you will not do anything wrong. Be 'fully detached and fully engaged' (This is from Swami Bodhananda).
2. If you eat as though you are feeding God, you will only eat healthy food.
3. Desire hides knowledge. Hence control the senses and slay the enemy called desire.

Chapter 4: Righteous knowledge and action.

God says, I am teaching you the same eternal science that I taught Sun God and his descendants including saints, kings and you. When asked, God tells him that he remembers events in his past lives and that he comes to this earth to re-establish righteousness ('Dharma'), as and when there is increase in unrighteousness.

Author feels that prophets and people like Sage Vyasa, Sage Patanjali, Chaitanya Mahaprabhu, Jesus Christ, Adi Shankara, Ramakrishna Paramahansa, Ramana Maharshi, Dr Martin Luther King Jr and many more are some such incarnations of God who took birth to re-establish righteousness in the earth.

Author also reminds that Sun worship is also prevalent in other faiths such as Zoroastrians, Aztecs and Mayans.

God went on saying that 'Karma' is another path to realize God. Righteous action unaffected by happiness or distress, success or failure, heat or cold and done as a sacrifice to God leads us to union with God.

4: 24: Do everything as an offering to God:

(Brahmaarpanam brahmahavir, Brahmaagnau brahmaNaabutam; Brahmaivatenagantavyam, Brahma karma samaadhinaa)

The literal meaning of this verse is 'The oblation is Brahman, the offerings are brahman, the sacrifice is Brahman, the absorption in action is Brahman, Brahman alone shall be reached by him by sacrifice.'

God, Shri Krishna, says that such knowledge has to be acquired from God-realized saints. God asks Arjuna to discard ignorance with knowledge.

What is there for me?

Doing righteous action with equanimity of mind is another path to experience God.

Divinize everything in life, every action, divinize the act of eating, divinize the act of sacrifice. When we divinize everything, there is no room to do anything wrong. When we divinize eating, there is no room for eating unhealthy food.

Chapter 5: Besides the path of devotion, there is another path to unite with God. That path is the path of action (Karma)

In this chapter, God tells that out of doing Karma with devotion vs doing Karma with renunciation of action, doing karma with devotion is a better way for humanity. But he also said that there is no need to separate these two approaches.

What is there for me? Those who do action as a service to God without ego and see divinity in every action conquer the cycle of death and birth and get united with God.

Chapter 6: This is the path of meditation to unite with God

In this chapter, God describes meditation as a means to focus the mind. He talks about the importance of being moderate in food, sleep, work and recreation for the mind to be tranquil. He admits that uncontrolled mind can be one's worst enemy. When the devotee questions God that focusing the mind that he is suggesting is impractical and impossible, God admits that controlling the mind is indeed difficult and says that it needs regular practice of austerity and detachment from the fruits of action to control the mind and to be in infinite bliss. When questioned about what happens to those who try to focus on God, but fail, God says that such people will continue their efforts in the next birth. God assures that the good deeds accumulate over several births and are not lost.

BG 6.16: O Arjuna, those who eat too much or too little, sleep too much or too little, cannot attain success in Yog.

This state of being established in the real self by transcending the body, mind and intellect and being in infinite bliss is called Samadhi.

In this chapter, the need for sitting upright in a comfortable seat which is neither too high nor too low, with gaze at the tip of the nose without allowing the eyes to wander is described to sit for meditation.

6:30: For those who see Me everywhere and see all things in Me, I am never lost, nor are they ever lost to Me.

In the 31st verse of the 6th chapter, God says: "He, who is established in oneness, worships Me abiding in all beings, that yogi lives in Me, whatever may be his mode of living". The message is God is everywhere, not just in heaven (if heaven exists), not just 'up there', including here, in you and me, right now, not after death, not after

going to heaven. God is not just the 'man up there'! God is **in everyone, everywhere and at all times.**

What is there for me?

Mind is very difficult to control

Meditation is a method to focus the mind and have transcendental experience of God

You have to sit upright in a quiet and comfortable place gazing at the tip of the nose to meditate

Moderation in eating, sleeping and everything in life leads to success in life. Meditation helps in being moderate in life.

Chapter 30

Wisdom from Bhagavad Gita: Section two (Chapters 7-12) The Path of Devotion to Experience God

Chapter 7: This chapter is called ‘yoga of knowledge and realization’.

In this chapter, God says the essence of everything is him and his devotees who focus on him and who surrender to him are able to overcome the worldly obstacles and experience God realization. God

says that he is both material and energy that drives the material. God is like the thread that holds the beads together in a garland. He is the taste of the water, radiance of the sun and the moon. He is the sacred syllable OM in the vedic mantras, he is the sound in ether, fragrance of the earth, brilliance in fire and life in all beings. He is the intellect of the intelligent, splendor of the splendid. He is the seed of all beings. Those who know this divine knowledge excel and are dear to God.

God says, 'whatever form any devotee with faith wishes to worship, I make that faith of his steady'.

Chapter 8 is called ‘Yoga of Imperishable Brahman’ (Imperishable God):

This chapter starts with the devotee asking, “What is Brahman?”, “What is Individual soul” and few other related questions. In this chapter, God tells that ‘Absolute Reality is Brahman and it transcends time, space and causation. He also says that the divine element of the self (Atman) is imperishable. He says that those who remember him even at the time of death will attain him. God suggests the devotee to think of him all the time to be able to come to him. He also says that once one reaches the Abode of God escapes of cycle of birth and death.

Author’s comments: God realization is the ultimate goal of life in all sects of Hinduism. One saint Kabir says, “When I walk, I think I am circumambulating the God; when I work, I think I am serving God, and when I sleep, I think I am offering HIM obeisances. In this manner, I perform no activity other than that which is offered to HIM”

There is mention of suggestion to fixate the entire life energy in the middle of the eyebrows to reach HIM. There also is mention in this chapter that OM is Brahman and the spiritual content of this vibration experienced while chanting OM is Infinite Bliss and brilliance of Pure Consciousness.

Chapter 9: Yoga through the King of Sciences: In this chapter,

God Shri Krishna declares that he is the Supreme God who has taken human form. He says that all animate and inanimate creations dwell in HIM. **He also assures that there is only one God.** He says, **“I am the Father of this world, the mother, the dispenser, the Grandfather; I am the knowable, the purifier, I am OM and**

I am the scriptures (Vedas), I am the Goal, the supporter, the abode, the shelter, the foundation and the Seed Imperishable”

9:22: God guarantees to take care of his devotees: This verse is very often quoted. In this God Shri Krishna assures his devotees that ‘Those who are exclusively devoted to Me with their minds absorbed in Me are provided what they lack, and I preserve what they already possess’.

God takes full responsibility to protect his devotees who completely surrender to him. God says, ‘I personally carry the burden of my devotees’.

In verse 27, God says, “Whatever you do, whatever you eat, whatever you offer as sacrifice, whatever you gift away, whatever meditation you do, do it as an offering to me” (Author’s comment: this is a very practical verse. If one practices this there is no room to do anything wrong in life because one would not offer anything bad to God.)

Chapter 10: Opulences and Glories of God (God is the essence of everything):

The previous chapter revealed the science of loving devotion (called 'bhakti' in Sanskrit) of God. In this chapter, Shri Krishna describes His infinite glories and opulences. The verses are pleasing to meditate on God by reflecting upon His magnificence.

Lord Krishna reveals that He is the source of all that exists.

10:3:

I am the Supreme Lord of the universe.

10:4-5:

From Me alone arise the varieties of qualities in humans, such as intellect, knowledge, clarity of thought, forgiveness, truthfulness, control over the senses and mind, joy and sorrow, birth and death, fear and courage, non-violence, equanimity, contentment, austerity, charity, fame, and infamy.

10:6 and 8:

The whole human race is born from me.

10:7, 10

Those who know my glories and divine powers with one pointed devotion, become undoubtedly united with Me and obtain the divine knowledge to attain Me.

I dwell the hearts of my devotees and destroy their ignorance.

Arjuna is now fully convinced that Shri Krishna is the Supreme Divine Personality and requests Him to describe further His divine glories, which are like divine nectar.

10:12-18: Arjuna said: You are the Supreme Divine Personality, the Supreme Abode, Purifier, the Eternal God, the Primal Being, the Unborn and the Greatest.

O Krishna, I totally accept everything You have told me as the Truth.

O Lord of the universe! Please describe to me your divine glories and manifestations.

10:19-40: God Krishna spoke:

I shall now briefly describe My divine glories to you, of which there is no end.

I am seated in the hearts of all living entities. I am the beginning, middle, and end of all beings.

I am Vishnu.

I am the sun.

I am the moon.

I am the best of the scriptures.

I am the mind.

I am the consciousness among the living beings.

I am the Himalayas among the immovable things.

I am the best among the priests, seers and the warriors.

I am the ocean among the water reservoirs.

Among the sounds, I am the primordial sound, OM.

I am the massive trees, I am the peepal tree.

I am the thunderbolt amongst weapons and wish fulfilling sacred cow, Kamadhenu, amongst the cows. Amongst dispensers of law, I am the lord of death. Know me to be the lion amongst animals, and Eagle amongst the birds (US Flag!).

Amongst purifiers, I am the wind, and amongst wielders of weapons, I am God Rama. Of water creatures, I am the crocodile, and of flowing rivers, I am the holy river Ganges.

O Arjuna, know Me to be the beginning, middle, and end of all creation. Amongst sciences I am the science of spirituality, and in debates I am the logic.

Of the letters, I am the beginning letter “A”.

I am the endless Time, and I am the origin of those things that are yet to be.

Of the feminine qualities I am fame, prosperity, fine speech, memory, intelligence, courage, and forgiveness.

Of the seasons, I am Spring that brings flowers. I am the victory of the victorious, the resolve of the resolute, and the virtue of the virtuous.

I am Krishna (~God), I am Arjuna (~you and me, all of us)

I am the just punishment.

Amongst the secrets, I am silence.

I am the wisdom of the wise.

I am the seed of all living beings. There is nothing living or non-living that can exist without me.

O conqueror of enemies, what I have declared is a sample of my glories. Whatever good, glorious, beautiful and glorious that you see arises from the spark of my splendour. Know that I pervade and support the entire creation. (Author’s confession: I have skipped more glories and paraphrased the meaning in few places to keep it simple for readers who may not be aware of many details about India).

What is there for me?

God is the essence of everything we deal with everyday. God is available for us to experience in this life, in this world, today, right now! God is the good of anything good. God is the sound of music, God is the fragrance of the scent, God is the breath of air, God is the taste and nutrition of the food, God is light of the lights and Sun, God is love of the lover. God is this, that and all! God is here, there and everywhere!

God has names, God transcends names too! God is with attributes and without attributes! God is in the idols and outside the idols! God is not just up there! God is here too, right here! God is in you, me and everybody! God is He, God is also SHE, God is IT too! God is you, me and all!

Chapter 11: Seeing God in the Cosmic Universal form:

Hearing about his infinite glories from Shri Krishna himself, Arjuna gets more curious. Hearing that what he heard is only a spark, acknowledging Shri Krishna's compassion, Arjuna requests Shri Krishna to show him His infinite cosmic form. Shri Krishna grants Arjuna divine vision to be able to see his universal form. Arjuna sees the entire universe, entire creation in Shri Krishna's body. He sees the God of Gods with infinite arms, faces and stomachs. It had no beginning, and no end in all directions. His radiance was more than that of a thousand suns blazing together in the sky (referenced by Oppenheimer when he saw the atomic explosion). His hair stood on end. He witnessed the three worlds trembling with fear. He saw several sages offering prayers and singing hymns exalting God. He saw his enemy side rushing into the deadly mouth of that fearsome form of God similar to moths perishing in fire.

Seeing this Universal form, Arjuna realizes that Shri Krishna that he knew as his friend, relative, teacher and charioteer is not an ordinary human being and asks him to introduce himself.

Shri Krishna declares that he indeed is the God of the Universe. He told Arjuna that he has already 'killed' his enemies and Arjuna has just to be a 'vehicle'. Hence he tells him 'get up and fight'. Seeking forgiveness for addressing him as friend and relative and for not respecting him as God, Arjuna pleads God to for his grace and change from the fiery Universal form with over thousand arms to a gentler form with four arms.

Shri Krishna then manifests in his gentle four-armed form with disc, mace, conch and lotus flower in each arm. Soon thereafter he

resumes his two armed human form. He tells Arjuna that with pure devotion, one can see God and unite with God. God further asserts that ‘those who perform their duties for My sake, who depend upon Me and are devoted to Me, free from attachment and are without malice towards others, such devotees certainly come to Me’.

What is there for me?

If chapter 10 is the audio version, chapter 11 is the video depicting God in everything we see. God is the essence of everything we see and everything we experience. God is everywhere, including here, right now, in this life, in you.

Ramakrishna Paramahansa told his future student Narendra, who later became Swami Vivekananda, ‘God can be seen just like I can see you, even better than that’. Ramakrishna used to talk to God in the form of Mother KALI. One of the great sentences of Hinduism is ‘Tat Tvam Asi’ which means ‘you are that divine reality’. The other two great sentences are ‘prajnanam Brahman’ which means ‘consciousness is God’ and ‘aham Brahmasmi’ which means ‘I am God’. If we see divinity in everything and everybody, we can see God every day, everywhere. God can be experienced in this world’

Chapter 12 shows the path of devotion to experience God:

In this chapter, upon inquiry, God tells Arjuna that, of the two types of devotees, he prefers those who are devoted to a finite and personal form of God compared to attribute-less God. He says that it is the highest form of uniting with (~experiencing) God. However, in the very next verse, he says that it is more difficult to experience the formless Absolute truth that is imperishable, un-manifest, all pervading, undefinable, unthinkable, unchanging, immovable and eternal that transcends senses and mind. But those who can do it can unite with Him.

Author's comments: This is a good chapter to read if you are curious about why millions, maybe more than a billion Hindus worship God with attributes. This is a good chapter to study for those who look down upon 'idol worshippers'. 'Idol worshippers' do not worship the idol. They see God in everything including an idol, parents, teachers, animals, every living and inanimate being. It is not limiting God to the 'idol'. It is recognizing God everywhere including an object. Denying God in an 'idol' is denying that God is everywhere. It is like saying God is everywhere except where I can see! What is the point in worshipping 'formless God' if you don't recognize God here, in front of you, right now, in this birth and not after death, not just in heaven? Saying that God is omnipresent without recognizing God in the idol is contradictory and oxymoron! Being able to see God in every being, in every situation and everywhere including now is a privilege Hindus experience and everyone has that choice! Non-Hindus have that privilege too if they wish to experience! In fact, many non-Hindus do recognize God in idols and forms without realizing it! There are

idols of Buddha everywhere. There are images of Jesus Christ and Mother Mary everywhere including pendants, that people revere with devotion.

God says that the devotees who worship his personal form perform all actions and dedicate the results of action to Him with their mind and intellect always surrendered to him. Such souls get liberated from the cycle of birth and death.

God asserts that even devotion takes practice. God says that if it is difficult to focus on God and live in Him, one can focus on the action (day to day activities) and dedicate it to God as though you are working for God. If that is also difficult, you can just work, renounce the fruits of action and be situated in the self. God Shri Krishna says that renunciation of the fruits of action is the higher method of practicing love of God, higher than meditation which is higher than knowledge and knowledge of the divine nature of the self is higher than the mechanical practice.

Subsequently God describes his devotees as those who have no malice towards all living beings, who are friendly, all compassionate, free from egotism, free from attachment to possessions. They have equanimity of mind when they are faced with happiness or sorrow, pleasure or pain, gain or loss, honor or dishonor and cold or heat. They are always content and firmly dedicated to God irrespective of the situations. Such wise people unconditionally love God.

What is there for me?

Not everything in a scripture can be secularized. This is a chapter that talks about divine love of God where God guarantees to take care of his devotees. Love toward God is pure unconditional love or work as an offering to God or anything beyond. This chapter is for those who have faith in God and for such people, the contents are self-explanatory.

Real devotees unconditionally love God. Prayers can be transactional or non-transactional. There is nothing wrong in transactional prayers. But non-transactional prayer leads to a better transcendental experience. Your type of prayer follows your needs similar to Maslow's hierarchy of needs. I have written more about this topic in my book, 'The Power of Infinity'.

Chapter 31

Wisdom from
Bhagavad Gita:
Section Three
(Chapters
13-18)

Knowledge of
the Divine Self
and the
Universal God
(Brahman)

Chapter 13: Union with God by knowing the ‘field’ and the ‘knower of the field’:

In this chapter, when requested by Arjuna, God Shri Krishna describes the concepts of ‘field’ and ‘the knower of the field’. The human body where the action takes place is considered the ‘field or the playground and the soul as the ‘knower of the field’. Human body consists of the five sensory organs (eyes, nose, tongue, ears and skin), five organs of action (tongue, hands, feet, excretory organs, reproductive organs), the mind, ego and intellect including all the ‘matter’ part of human beings. Shri Krishna says that he is the knower of the fields of action. He also said that the soul (‘Purusha’ or ‘Atma’) and the Supreme Soul (‘Ishwara’ or ‘ParamAtma’) are the knowers of the field.

God is all pervading and sits in the heart of every living being.

He is the Supreme Soul.

After describing the Supreme Soul, the soul, and the material nature of the living beings, Shree Krishna explains which of these is responsible for their actions. Also, who is responsible for the cause and effect in the universe at large. Those who understand these differences and identify the correct causes of actions are the ones who see the ultimate truth; and are situated in divine knowledge. They do not degrade themselves by the illusions of their minds and perceive the presence of the Supreme Soul in every living being. In the same material nature, they are able to identify a variety of living beings and look at all existence pervaded by a common spiritual substratum. With this knowledge, they attain consciousness of the Brahman or God-realization.

God describes different attributes of the ‘knower’ as humility, freedom from hypocrisy, non-violence, simplicity, serving Guru, cleanliness of the body and the mind, steadfastness, self-control, dispassion, lack of egotism, knowing the evils of birth, death, disease and old age, non-attachment, absence of clinging to family and house, equanimity of the mind in good and difficult situations, constant and exclusive devotion to God, tendency to be in solitary places and aversion from mundane activities, constant quest for spiritual knowledge, pursuit for the Absolute Truth. God also declares that lack of these to be ignorance.

God then described the nature of the ‘knower’ as the infinite in everything, omnipresent, omniscient and omnipotent. He is the creator, sustainer and the dissolver. (Since this overlaps a bit with chapter 9, 10 and 11, I did not go into details here). He asserts that this Supreme God resides within the body as the witness, controller, supporter, and the experiencer. Those who know the divine nature of the Self do not degrade their mind and the body.

God also states that Supreme God can be experienced by the paths of meditation, action or knowledge. He also states that the one who knows the nature of the field, knowledge of the divine nature of the True Self and the knower of the field attain union with God.

God re-states here that the material body is perishable and the Soul is imperishable. Those who know this reach the supreme state of being.

What is there for me?

You can use this chapter to know who you really are!

One way to understand this chapter is to know ‘Who Am I?’. You can know that by running this exercise in yourself with the basic understanding that ‘the one who sees/experienced’ is different from

‘that which is seen/experienced’. If we agree with that ‘me’ and ‘mine’ can never be the same.

When I say, ‘this is my body’, my body cannot be me, because what is mine cannot be me.

Similarly, when I say, ‘this is my mind’, my mind cannot be me, because what is mine cannot be me.

What about my intellect? Again, when I say, ‘this is my intellect’, my intellect cannot be me because my intellect cannot be me, because what is mine cannot be me.

If I am neither my body, nor my mind nor my intellect, then ‘Who Am I?’. ‘I’ am that which is neither the body, nor the mind, nor the intellect. I am that ‘divine consciousness’ that runs my body, mind and intellect.

This exercise is called ‘Self Inquiry’ by the 20th century saint Ramana Maharshi. I would refer you to two little books, one is ‘Who Am I’ by Ramana Maharshi and another is ‘Knowledge of the seer and the seen’ (called ‘Drk Drshya Viveka’ in Sanskrit by Shankara; commentaries in English are available by Swami Chinmayananda and others)

Chapter 14: Knowing the three modes of the material body:

The material body consists of body, mind and intellect. All these can be in three modes: *sattva* (good: peaceful, moral, serene), *rajas* (passionate, desirous, ambitious, worldly good) and *tamas* (ignorant, lazy, sleepy, deluded, intoxicated). Although all three gunas are present in everyone, one or another may predominate in a person's state of mind and behavior.

One can transcend these three modes by spiritual practice of attaching the mind to God. When Arjuna asked the characteristics of those who have transcended these three modes, God says that such people are equipoised in easy and difficult situations knowing that these modes only affect the body and that these modes do not affect the imperishable Self, the Soul. Such people treat honor and dishonor, friends and foes, happiness and distress, heat and cold alike and rise above these three modes. God asserts again that such people reach him and attain immortality and escape the cycle of birth and death. Even though, this is a section of the path of knowledge, devotion leads this divine knowledge culminating in union with God.

What is there for me?

Constant spiritual practice of chanting, singing about God, studying the scriptures, contemplating God in a secluded place or in everything we do in life can lead to Godly experience. Similarly practicing vigorously for years and years helps us be in the 'flow' and experience excellence that can sometimes defy logic. We see that in some legends in various fields who do the 'impossible'. We have seen that in legends like Michael Jordan, Sachin Tendulkar, Kapil Dev, MS Dhoni, Lionel Messi, Roger Federer, Einstein, Dr Martin Luther King, Steve

Jobs, Shri Narendra Modi and many others. Most of these legends are self-made people. They defy logic not from some magic or accident. It comes from a lot of self-study, hard work, contemplation, good will from teachers/coaches/parents, and divine grace. This privilege is available to all of us, including you!

Chapter 15: Knowing the Supreme Imperishable Divine Personality, Imperishable Souls and perishable beings:

In this chapter God Shri Krishna explains about detaching the material world from the mind in order to attach it to God. He compares material world to an upside down fig tree called '*Ashvatth*' tree in Sanskrit language and many other Indian languages. This tree is a massive tree grows wide and drops down roots from its branches as well to support the branches. In this example of upside down *Ashvatth* (fig) tree, the main stem represents the Soul, the branches represent the physical body with different modes of nature of the material world along with the soul of the individual body. On those branches, the embodied souls wander up and down, from lifetime after lifetime. As God is the source of this tree, the roots extend upwards from the main stem. Its leaves represent the divine activities described in the Holy Scriptures. The objects of the senses created by the different modes are the buds on the branches which sprout more roots from the branches that spring upwards. As different bodies (branches) grow thick, one is unable to see the Supreme God, the main stem. In order to see/experience the Supreme God, one has to cut the material bodies with an axe of 'detachment'. That allows the self to surrender to the Supreme God, the main stem, and reach the Abode of God further up to remain there united with God without having to return to the material world. As the branches (material bodies with soul) are cut, the soul reappears in the new branches (new bodies). Here the branches representing the material world represent the perishable bodies, stem and roots directed upwards represent the imperishable Soul and the

eternal space that the roots are supported by represent the Supreme Imperishable Divine Universal God (Brahman or Ishwara), called *Akshara Purushottam*.

The Universal Brahman, like the Sun and the Moon, nourishes the soul and bodies via the roots that are growing upwards. Detaching from the modes of the material world allows one to transcend the worldly activities to be with the Supreme Universal God. One who knows that soul is imperishable realizes that soul moves from dead branch (one physical body) to a new branch (new body).

God, while describing his Infinite nature, describes his glories in his role as the digestive fire and breath force in the 14th verse that is very widely quoted and is often chanted before having a meal. The actual translation of the verse is, 'I take the form of digestive fire in the stomachs of all living beings and combine with inhaling and exhaling breaths, to digest and assimilate the four kinds of foods'.

A person who has the knowledge of me as the Supreme Imperishable Personality for both the perishable material world and the imperishable souls will be enlightened and fulfil everything that is to be fulfilled.

(Author's comments: Since this chapter stresses the imperishable nature of the True Self in more depth, many chant this chapter if someone dies in the family)

What is there for me?

As a spiritual being, know that the real you are imperishable. Life is a constant interaction between God and you. Since 'the real you' (Soul) are imperishable and the soul moves from one body to another, one should not be and need not be afraid of death. Be fearless! You are a small part of the infinite tapestry of births and deaths.

Make eating a spiritual practice. Pray God before eating and express gratitude before and during eating.

CHAPTER 16: Enlightenment through differentiating the Divine and Demoniatic Natures:

In this chapter, God Shri Krishna explains there are two kinds of people- the divine and the demoniac. He then describes the divine and demoniac qualities. He describes methods to acquire saintly qualities and discard demoniac qualities to unite with God.

God Shri Krishna says, O Arjuna, the saintly virtues are:

- fearlessness
- purity of mind
- steadfastness in spiritual knowledge
- charity
- control of senses
- sacrifice
- study of the sacred books
- austerity
- straightforwardness
- non-violence
- truthfulness
- absence of anger
- renunciation
- peacefulness
- restrain from fault-finding
- compassion
- absence of covetousness
- gentleness
- modesty
- lack of fickleness
- vigor

-forgiveness

-fortitude

-cleanliness

-bearing no enmity on anybody (unconditional love)

-absence of vanity.

Then he describes the demoniac qualities and they are:

-hypocrisy

-arrogance

-conceit

-anger

-harshness

-ignorance

-inability to differentiate right from the wrong actions

-lack of purity

-bad conduct

-not telling the truth

-not believing in God

-over indulgence in sexual gratification

-threatening the destruction of the world

-insatiable lust

-working with impure values

-over indulgence in sense gratification and wealth accumulation by

unjust means

-egotism

-delusions

-addictions

-self conceit

God describes greed, anger and lust as the three gates to hell and advises that one should avoid them.

God says that the divine qualities lead to liberation and the demoniac qualities lead to continuing rebirths in inferior and unhappy lives.

He asserts that Arjuna is born with saintly qualities. He recommends scriptural readings in choosing saintly qualities and in avoiding demoniac qualities in choosing the actions. He continues saying that such saintly people attain supreme goal of uniting with God.

What is there for me?

This commentary is easy and self explanatory. Just be good! Desire, anger and greed are the gateways to unhappiness. Controlling the desires is the most important part to avoid anger and greed. Follow the spiritual injunctions. Scriptures guide determining what should be done and what should not be done. Knowing this, perform action as ordained by scriptures and gain supreme powers, happiness and the supreme goal of experiencing God. Being content is important. Action without knowledge and knowledge without action is not desirable.

CHAPTER 17: Difference Between the Three Types of Practising Faith, AKA Three ways of Leading Life; Different Types of Worshipping, Austerity, Eating, Sacrifice and Charity:

In this chapter, God Shri Krishna describes the three modes of material life that were described in the fourteenth chapter in various day to day activities in more detail. The chapter starts with Arjuna asking Bhagawan Shri Krishna about what people do if they want to practice faith but don't want to follow scriptures.

The three modes of practicing faith and day to day activities are mode of goodness (*satvik*), mode of passion (*rajasik*) and mode of ignorance. The way we practice life depends upon the mode or nature of the person's body and mind.

Starting with worshipping, Bhagawan Krishna says that those in the mode of goodness worship celestial gods, those in the mode of passion worship celestial beings (yakshas) and demons and those in the mode of ignorance worship ghosts and spirits.

Similarly, those in the mode of goodness do austerity (meditation) on Supreme God according to the scriptures with purity of mind, body and speech, those in the mode of passion meditate based on hypocrisy and egotism without scriptural help to gain fame and name, and those in the mode of ignorance meditate to torment the body and God (like black magic or torturing the body!).

People in the mode of goodness eat foods that are fresh, juicy, succulent, nourishing and naturally tasteful that promote life span, increase health, happiness and satisfaction. Those in the mode of passion eat bitter, sour, salty, hot, pungent, dry and spicy hot foods

and they produce pain, grief and disease. People in the ignorant mode eat foods that are overcooked, stale, putrid, polluted and impure.

Sacrifice performed according to scriptural guidance without expectation of rewards as a matter of duty is of the goodness mode. Sacrifice done for material benefit is in the mode of passion. One in the mode of ignorance does sacrifice devoid of faith and contrary to scriptural guidance without chanting or donation.

Charity done for the right people at the time of need is a good charity. Charity done for name and fame without respect for the recipient comes under the mode of passion. Disrespectful charity to a person not in need and at the wrong time falls under the mode of ignorance.

What is there for me?

This chapter teaches us about the right and the wrong ways of practicing charity, sacrifice, eating, meditation and worshipping. The specifics are self-explanatory.

OM TAT SAT, the symbolic representation of SUPREME ABSOLUTE TRUTH:

The last few verses of this chapter explain about OM TAT SAT. Many prayer sessions end with chanting OM TAT SAT which means Supreme Absolute Truth. After explaining the three modes of practicing life, specifically 'worshipping', 'eating', 'sacrifice' and 'charity' in our mundane life it was made clear that 'ignorant' way is inferior to 'passionate' way and 'goodness' way is better than 'passionate' way. But still better than 'goodness' is to transcend all the three methods and dwell in 'Supreme Absolute Truth', 'Om Tat Sat'. This is a spiritual experience many human beings are seeking.

'Om' is the primordial sound and denotes 'Formless Supreme Reality/God/Brahman' and is usually chanted as the 'seed' mantra at the beginning of doing anything auspicious among Hindus, Buddhists, Jains and Sikhs to invoke auspiciousness.

‘Tat’, in Sanskrit literally means ‘that’ in English. ‘That’ refers to ‘God/Brahman’ again. Here by chanting ‘tat’, the chanter is offering the fruits of any action such as sacrifice, austerity, eating and charity to God.

‘Sat’ literally means ‘Truth’, The Absolute Truth. The only unchanging truth of the universe is ‘God/Brahman’. Anything and everything ‘material’ in the world is perishable, temporary and hence is not the Supreme Absolute Truth. That would mean that ‘Sat’ also refers to ‘The Supreme Absolute Truth’, i.e., ‘God/Brahman’. In this verse, being established in performing sacrifice, penance and charity in the mode of goodness, the auspicious action is referred as ‘Sat’ to transcend the material world.

God Shri Krishna ends the chapter by stating that not doing anything as a divine act is futile and hence is considered ‘untruth’.

What is there for me?

Message is anything we do should be done as a divine act. This makes us put our best foot forward with the best of the intentions without any attachments to the results and hence is a way for optimal performance.

Chant ‘OM TAT SAT’ at the beginning and end of doing anything for optimal performance.

CHAPTER 18: Experiencing God Through the Perfection of Renunciation and Surrender to God:

This chapter covers several topics summarizing the teachings from the previous chapters and they are self-explanatory. Hence there is no ‘what is there for me’ section here.

1. Difference between two words related to renunciation with similar appearing meanings. In response to a question, God Shri Krishna explains the meaning of ‘Sanyas’ as renunciation of actions and that of ‘tyag’ as renunciation of desires. One who practices ‘sanyas’ renounces family and social life to practice spiritual discipline and the one who practices ‘tyag’ renounces desire for fruits of action. Then, Shri Krishna recommends that one should never renounce the prescribed duties, sacrifice, charity, penance, etc. and must perform them as a divine duty without attachment to their results. Consequences of such divine actions (karmas) do not continue in the next birth. But the consequences of selfish karmas or actions with attachment to the fruits of actions continue in the future births as well. The importance of doing actions with good intentions as a matter of duty without being attached to the fruits of action is described multiple times in Gita. Swami Bodhananda of Sambodh Ashram, a saint of twentieth and twenty first century calls it **‘being fully engaged and fully detached’**. That means that our actions should fully engage us in the community, they should be relevant to the world, but we should be fully detached from the fruits of action. The fruits of action should be offered to God, doer-ship should be attributed to God. This

is a recipe for optimal performance.

2. Shree Krishna gives Arjuna a detailed analysis of the five factors that contribute to action, the three constituents of action, and the three factors that inspire action. The five factors that contribute to action are the body, the soul, five senses, the many kinds of efforts and Supreme God (Ishwara) (verse 13 onwards).
3. Those who do their duties with full detachment to doer-ship neither kill nor are they bound by the actions. God is telling Arjuna that he (God) is the 'doer' even when Arjuna fights the war as an 'instrument' of God. A soldier fighting for his or her country does not accrue 'sin' for his/her actions in the warzone even if that involves loss of lives.
4. Constituents of action are knowledge of action, the act itself and the doer. All these constituents in good mode (sattva) free from ego (doer ship) and attachment, endowed with enthusiasm and determination with equanimity of mind irrespective of the result, result in *optimal performance*. If these constituents are in the modes of passion (rajas) or modes of ignorance (tamas), the performance will be suboptimal. The performer is said to be in the mode of goodness, when he or she is free from egotism and attachment, endowed with enthusiasm and determination, and equipoised in success and failure.
5. There is a similar analysis of three modes of intellect, willpower and HAPPINESS. Summary of this again is that if one is aware that the 'true Self' is supremely divine, we will

be able to act with confidence and experience true happiness unconditionally as our default state irrespective of the situation. (Author's example: A child is always happy and smiling unless there is a reason to unhappy such as soiled diaper/under garment, pain or hunger. For some reason, when we grow up, paradigm changes and we look for means and reasons to be happy. Adults seek money, wealth, food, music, partner, sex, alcohol, smoking, drugs and many different things to chase happiness and become unhappy when they see 'something better' that they don't have. In other words 'seeking happiness gives us more unhappiness'. This is again from Swami Bodhananda.

6. Four types of people (varnas): (Verses 41-44): In these verses, Krishna describes the duties associated with the four varnas in terms of qualities and work. The relationship between this scriptural framework and the hereditary caste system that developed historically is complex and has been interpreted differently across Hindu traditions.
7. *DHARMA* TO ATTAIN PERFECTION: Here God Shri Krishna stresses the importance of doing one's *dharma*. And he states that it is better to perform your own dharma than someone else's *dharma*. *Dharma* here refers to one's innate skill and responsibility. The term dharma has other meanings as well. Dharma also refers to ethical living. A person attains perfection by doing one's innate duties. Some people see this verse to explain why Hindus do not have missionaries or a system to convert people from other faiths to Hinduism. One should not abandon one's dharma (faith), just like you don't abandon your mother. Nothing is perfect in life. Even

fire comes with smoke!

8. TRANSCENDENCE FROM PERFECTION TO EXPERIENCING GODHOOD (Verses 50-55): God Shri Krishna says: O Arjuna, I shall now explain how one who has attained perfection can attain Brahman ('Godhood') by being firmly fixed in knowledge of transcending. One becomes eligible to attain Godhood when she or he attains purified intellect (that 'Self is divine') and firmly restrains the senses, abandons the sense objects like sound and others, casting aside attraction and aversion. Such a person enjoys solitude, eats lightly, controls body, mind and speech, and is always in meditation, practices dispassion, free from egotism, violence, arrogance, desire, excessive possessiveness of property. Such a tranquil person is fit for 'Self Realization (as Self is divine)' or realization that 'Absolute Truth of the Self is divine Brahman/God'. The one who has realized Godhead as the True Self becomes mentally serene, neither grieving nor seeking, equipoised towards all living beings. God now declares that such a yogi attains supreme devotion towards Me. (Authors comment: This is a perfect interplay and interdependence between the path of knowledge that Self is Brahman and the path of devotion).

9. LEAVE EVERYTHING AND COME TO ME WITH LOVING DEVOTION: God says, 'Only by loving devotion does one come to know that I am the Truth, after coming to Me, my devotee fully realizes Me. In spite of performing all actions ('being fully engaged in the world'), my devotees take full refuge in me and attain eternal and imperishable abode. Dedicating every action of yours unto Me, making me

your supreme goal, be absorbed in Me always. By my grace, you will overcome all your obstacles and difficulties. Your own nature will make you fight. (Remember that Arjuna is a warrior by nature and duty!). The Supreme God dwells in the heart of every living being and directs the 'body machine' to perform. O Arjuna, surrender unto the Supreme Godhood, you will attain perfect peace and eternal abode.

10. FINAL CONVERSATION: HOW GOD, SHRI KRISHNA

CONCLUDES: Just like any effective conversation, God concludes by asking his student if he was paying attention and if his doubts are cleared. God also tells Arjuna, 'at the end, do as you wish'. True teacher does not impose himself, he helps his students make independent decisions! That is what Shri Krishna did! The student, devotee, Arjuna replies respectfully: O Infallible One, by Your grace my ignorance and illusion has been dispelled, and I am situated in knowledge. I am now free from doubts, and I shall act according to Your instructions.

11. FINAL STATEMENT IN THE FINAL VERSE BY SAN-

JAYA, THE COMMENTATOR (18:78): Wherever there is God (Shri Krishna) and a sincere devotee (Arjuna), there will certainly be victory, goodness, excellence, joy, prosperity and sovereignty.

SECTION V

This chapter is dedicated to meaning of OM and the Power of Infinity.

Chapter 32

Meaning of OM (AUM)

OM (AUM), is the primordial sacred syllable in Hinduism. Sometimes spelt as OM, AUM represents the beyond 'The Three' (Trimoorthy representing Brahma, Vishnu and Maheshwara; tri=three, moorthy=statues), the Universe, the combination of The Creator (Brahma) represented by A, The Preserver (Vishnu) represented by U and The Dissolver (Shiva or Eeshwara or Maheshwara) represented by M.

AUM can be recited repeatedly as a method of invoking God and achieve a meditative state. Generally, one would sit upright, take a good breath and as you exhale recite aaaa, uuuu and mmmm, each over 2 to 3 seconds, preferably longer and experience the silence thereafter representing the supreme 'fourth' (*Turiya*) state.

One can repeat this as many times as one wants to experience a higher state of mind. Some use a garland of special beads (called Rudrakshi Mala or Japa Mala) with 108 beads to recite it 108 times.

But many do it thrice as follows:

(INHALE).....

As you exhale chant:

AAAAAAUUUUUUMMMMMM.....

(INHALE).....

As you exhale chant:

AAAAAAUUUUUUMMMMMM.....

(INHALE).....

As you exhale chant:

AAAAAAUUUUUUMMMMMM.....

It causes vibrations in the navel first, chest and throat next and inside the forehead and up, at the end moving sacred energy to the highest part center/chakra of the body. This sounds mystic, but please do it yourself in a quiet place irrespective of your faith at least twenty-one times and feel it; experience the internal peace, the Bliss.

Aum is also the holy symbol of Hinduism just like the Holy Cross for Christians, Menorah for Jews, star and half-moon for Islam, Swastika sign for Jains and Khanda for Sikhs.

The Upanishads consider Om as the basis of every other mantra. It is the sound of the origination and dissolution of the universe. The past, present, future and all that transcends time are all included in this sound. According to Taitreya Upanishad the origin of language is assigned to Prajapati, from whose meditation originated the divine syllable of OM, which coordinated all speech and represented the totality of the world.

Om comes from the Greatest upanishads, Mandukya is one short one among them...The mmmm part is the most important part, it forms NADA!! It is said when Nada (sound) and Bindu (Singularity) are even, then sadasivam rises and he unites with Shakti who is the material cause of Maya and then create Brahma, Vishnu/Indra(sustainer) and Rudra as per shaiva siddhanta...Ommmm can either refer to soul (Atman) which is eternal or it can refer to the supreme itself... Ommmm also refers to 4 states, waking state, dreaming state, deep sleep state,

and one which is not explained much, Turiya (where one experiences pure consciousness).

For starters, it's all about sacred threes. Most faiths have trinities in their roots and Hinduism, where OM was born, is no different. Even though it's usually pronounced seamlessly so it rhymes with "home," OM is made up of three syllables: A, U, and M, or, phonetically, "aaah," "ooo," and "mmm." Experts say these syllables can represent a series of trios, including: the heavens, earth, and the underworld; the Hindu gods Brahma, Vishnu, and Shiva (aka creator god, sustainer god, and dissolver god); and the waking, dreaming, and dreamless states -- "to represent all of consciousness,"

The three syllables also represent the three Vedas-Rig Veda, YajurVeda and Sama Veda.

It is the sound of Brahman. It is the predominating force and power. For this reason, chanting Om before every auspicious activity is recommended. Most mantras start with Om and much is written on this topic in the scriptures.

Most of the Upanishads have sections dealing with Om. Om is also discussed in the Bhagavad Gita, Yoga Sutras of Patanjali, Devi Mahatmyam and Upanishads.

The *Mandukya Upanishad*, which is entirely devoted to OM, begins like this and describes Om as the Eternal Syllable. The first verse of Mandukya Upanishad, goes as follows.

All is OM

"Om is the imperishable word. Om is the universe, and this is the exposition of OM. The past, the present, and the future, all that was, all that is, all that will be is OM. Likewise, all else that may exist beyond the bounds of time, that too is OM."

The Katha Upanishad states in 1:44:

"The goal which all the Vedas declare, which all austerities aim at, and which men desire when they lead the life of continence ... is Om. This syllable Om is indeed Brahman. Whosoever knows this syllable obtains all that he desires. This is the best support; this is the highest support. Whosoever knows this support is adored in the world of Brahma."

Meaning of OM:

Meaning of OM from Mandukya Upanishad (verse 7) is similar to the meaning of Sikh Mool Mantra (Sikh root/original *mantra*) '*Ik Onkaar*'.

But the whole Mandukya Upanishad is about OM and it only has 12 verses. The meaning of these 12 verses is as follows. This is close to exact translation of the verses. I have truncated some verses. It is a profound experience to read these verses at a stretch to experience OM:

1. Hari Om. The entire universe is the syllable OM, the following is the exposition of Om. The past, present and future is all Om. That which transcends time, space and object is OM.
2. All this, seen here, there and everywhere is Brahman. This very self, Atman, is Brahman, the Absolute Reality. This Atman has four aspects.
3. The first aspect is the wakeful state. In this state, consciousness is turned to the external. With its seven instruments (Sky, Sun, Moon, Earth, space, Heaven, Ocean) and nineteen channels [five sense organs (eyes, nose, tongue, ears and skin), five motor organs (arms, legs, tongue, reproductive organs and excretory organs), five life forces called '*praanas*' (*Praana, apaana, samaana, udaana and vyaana*) and four internal instruments (mind, intellect, ego, and storehouse of

memory)) that experience the gross world.

4. The second aspect is the dream state, '*tejasa*' state. In this state, consciousness is turned inward. It also has seven instruments and nineteen channels which experience the subtle mental impressions.
5. The third aspect is deep sleep, *prajna*, when there is no desire and no dream. All experiences merge into the pure undifferentiated consciousness. The sleeper is filled with bliss and finds way to knowledge or the two prior states.
6. The experience of these states of consciousness is the God of all. This one is all knowing, it directs everything from within. This is the womb of all. All things originate from and dissolve into this.
7. This is the fourth, which is the *Turiya* (the fourth). In this state, consciousness is not turned inward nor outward nor both. It is undifferentiated, it is beyond the spheres of cognition and non- cognition.

This cannot be experienced through senses or known by comparison or inference; it is incomprehensible, unthinkable and indescribable. This is pure consciousness. This is the real Self. It is the cessation of all phenomena; it is tranquil, blissful and ONE WITHOUT A SECOND. This real self is to be realized.

8. This Atman, Self or Pure consciousness has four states. It is OM (AUM). The letters A, U, M are waking, dreaming and sleep states. When you transcend these three states, the fourth (Turiya) state is experienced in silence that follows chanting A, U and M.

9. The consciousness experience during the wakeful state is A, the first letter of OM (AUM).

10. The consciousness experience during the dream state is U, the second letter of OM (AUM).

11. The consciousness experience during the sleep state is M, the third letter of OM (AUM), a state subtler than A and U.

12. This aspect of consciousness is the soundless aspect of OM, which is not comprehended by the ordinary mind or senses. It is the state of cessation of all phenomena. This is the 'nondual' state, one without a second, the fourth state, also called real 'Self',

Seventh verse is the most important one and summarizes the meaning of OM. The original verse in Sanskrit language is mentioned in chapter 37.

The 'fourth state' (Turiya) is not that which is conscious of the internal (subjective) world, nor that which is conscious of the external (objective) world, nor that which is conscious of both, nor that which is a mass of all sentiency, nor that which is simple consciousness, nor that which is insentient. (It is) unseen (by any sense organ), not related to anything, incomprehensible (by the mind), un-inferable, unthinkable, indescribable, essentially of the nature of Consciousness constituting the Self alone, the negation of all phenomena, the peaceful, all bliss and the non-dual. This is what is known as the fourth (Turiya). This is the Ātman and it has to be realized.

According to *Mandukya Upanishad* and *Ashtavakra Gita* (another small scriptural text), OM is beyond cognition and beyond absence of cognition. It cannot be sensed by the senses, it is not known by comparison, deductive reasoning, or inference; it is indescribable, incomprehensible, and unthinkable.

It is pure consciousness, the pure self that witnesses the self in the wake, dream, and sleep states. It is serene, tranquil, and blissful. It is

the ONE, one without a second. It makes us realize that material life is an illusion and temporary.

It transcends time, space, and object. This is the real or true Self that is to be realized.

‘Ik Onkar’ is the root mantra for the people of the Sikh faith. It is also chanted by people from other faiths. The meaning of this mantra is very profound, and it goes in line with the meaning of OM described in other scriptures. It is almost similar to what is described as the ‘fourth state (*turiya*)’ which is a state beyond the finite states of the self in the wake, dream, and sleep states (*Mandukya Upanishad*, verse 7). Apparently, this root mantra is mentioned 100 times in the holy book of Sikhs, ‘*Guru Granth Sahib*’.

I have not studied ‘*Guru Granth Sahib*’ enough to claim expertise, but I have read about it from different sources and chanted ‘Ik Onkar’ enough times to briefly explain this here as a way to experience ‘Infinity’. I have studied a book on ‘Ik Onkar’ (written by Swami Swaroopananda of Chinmaya Mission).

Please correct me and pardon me if I make any mistakes. This is the verbal transliteration of the root mantra. I have added a few additional words to explain and understand it better. But please know that ‘Ik Onkar’ is beyond my finite capacity to explain. It is ‘Infinity’.

Root mantra of ‘Ik Onkaar’ is as follows:

“Ik Onkaar, satnaam, kartaa poorakh, nirbhau,

nir vair, akaal moorat, ajooni sai bhang,

Gur parsaad, Jap,

Aad sach jugaad sach, Hai bhi sach, Naanak hosi bhi sach”

God is ONE, one without a second, the essence of the universe, the originator of the Universe, accessible to the entire universe.

This is the transliteration of this sacred mantra, Ik Onkaar:

Name is true (Truth, the absolute Truth)

The creator

One without fear

One without enemy (meaning all-loving, all-compassionate)

Beyond time: beyond death and birth

Self-effulgent

Blessing from the Guru as his grace

Chant (Meditate)

The truth today

The truth for the eternal future

Also, the truth

Guru (Nanak) says it is truth.

This was the first verse ('sound') the Guru of the Sikhs (Guru Nanak) spoke when he was enlightened. If you keep on chanting and studying 'Ik Onkar', you will advance to experiencing 'Infinity' within yourself in this life.

'The experience of OM', is available to you in this life. It does not have to be an after death experience; it does not have to be an experience 'up there'! You are that 'Unmanifest Transcendent One.' You are the universal, transcendent and transpersonal existence, right now, right here!

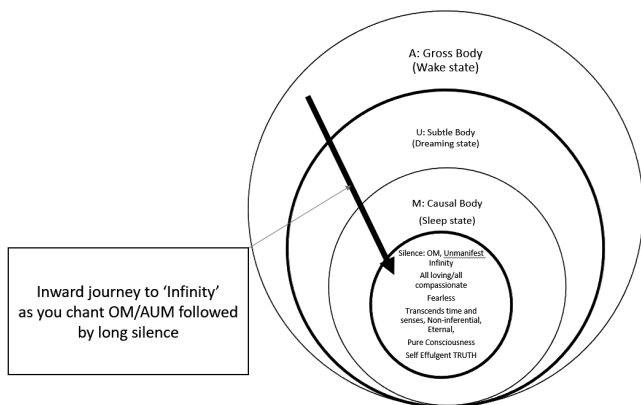


Figure: OM to experience Infinity (reproduced with permission from ‘The Power of Infinity’ by Anupkumar Shetty)

For regular people who want to try this, I would recommend you to sit upright cross-legged, with one of your heels gently touching the space between the two inner thighs (the part behind your genitals and in front of the anus) if you can do it comfortably without pain for long period of time.

Be in a quiet room, with lights off, with no ambient sound (switch off radio, TV, and phone), wearing comfortable loose clothes. Chant Om 21 times every day at the same time and same place. Do this for at least a month or more at a stretch and continue forever if you like the experience.

“Om is the symphony of silence” —Swami Bodhananda

‘Om is the sleepless sleep’ —Prakash Keshaviah Ph.D. who quotes Swami Rama

AUM (Om)

by Dr Raju

The name of the “Nameless”, AUM. The form of the “Formless”,

AUM.

The sound of the “Silence”, AUM. Pervading all this Universe,

AUM.

The sound that is virtuous, AUM,

The sound that is harmonious, AUM, The sound that is precious,

AUM, The sound that is auspicious, AUM.

The sound that is self-illuminating, AUM, The sound that is ever inspiring, AUM, The sound that is energizing, AUM, The sound that is enlightening, AUM.

The chariot of life,

with a great velocity,

The raft that takes us to the eternity, The medium to reaching the extreme, The podium on which stands the supreme, AUM.

The root of meditation, AUM.

The route of meditation, AUM.

The seat of meditation, AUM.

And the heart of meditation, AUM.

Like roaring ocean, it is evident, AUM, Like touching wind, it is latent, AUM, Like taste of water, it is prevalent, AUM, Like scent of flower, it is fragrant AUM.

AUM TAT SAT

References

Srimad BhagavadGita & Uttara Gita Mandukya, KaTha, Taittiriya and other Upanishads.

Chapter 33

The Power of Infinity for Inner Peace, Stress Relief, and Spiritual Clarity

‘Infinity’ is the word I chose to describe that ‘entity’ or ‘power’ or ‘spirit’ within us and outside us all over the universe. The various synonyms of ‘Infinity’ are ‘Brahman’, ‘Supreme Lord’, ‘Supreme God’, ‘God’, ‘One’. Eckert Tolle calls it ‘NOW’. Sikhs call it ‘Ik’ (which means ‘one’) or ‘Ik Onkar’. Hindus, Jains, Sikhs, Buddhists, and many others call it ‘OM’.

He who chooses ‘The Infinite’ has been chosen by ‘The Infinite’

Sri Aurobindo

Rig Veda, one of the ancient sacred Hindu scriptures states, 'The Supreme is One, sages call it different ways.' Christians may call 'him' as 'Jehovah', Muslims call it/him 'Allah', Jews, Baha'is, and people of other faiths call 'him' in their own ways. Many Hindus call 'it' with different names, some of them being Krishna, Krishna consciousness, Rama, Vishnu, Shiva, Brahma, Durga, Mother, Amma, Hanuman, Murugan, Ganapati, Surya, etc. Of note, some disagree with those who worship God/Infinity in form and names. But according to one of the sacred Hindu scriptures, *Tulsi Ramayana*, it is a privilege to be able to see and sing about the attribute-less God in form and names. Some see it as a necessity to experience God with attributes to access the attribute-less God. You need to have a glass if you want to offer water to somebody. You cannot offer water to your friend or guest without glass or bottle. (This example was given to Swami Chinmayananda by his Guru, Swami Tapovan Maharaj and the details of the story are available online). It is a common practice among Hindus to worship God with attributes. Invoking the form of Jesus Christ and Mother Mary is a common practice among Christians by having the respective 'idols' in the forms of sculptures and paintings in churches and small personal idols or 'cross' in pendants and photos. Buddhists keep Buddha's idols in their houses and monasteries. Many see Infinity in prophets. Sometimes 'Infinity' comes into our lives as mother, father, guru, and friend. In the verse, 'Matr Devobhava, Pitr Devobhava, Gurur Devobhava and Atithi Devobhava', Hindus admit to treating Mothers, Fathers, Gurus and Guests like God. 'Infinity' might show up as food, water, air, shelter, or a 'divine voice' from somebody known or unknown. In the movie '*Life of Pi*', the main actor playing 'Pi Patel' expresses gratitude to God Vishnu for appearing as 'fish' when he had nothing else to eat except the fish in the middle of the ocean after the shipwreck. In Hindu scriptures, God

Vishnu had once incarnated as a divine ‘Fish (*Matsya*)’. Some of the secular words to indicate ‘Infinity’ are ‘pure consciousness’, ‘witness consciousness’, ‘the truth’, and ‘awareness’. The experience of ‘Infinity’ is also described as ‘truth-consciousness-bliss’ (*‘Sat-chit-ananda’*).

Here is a peace chant on ‘Infinity’ from Kenopanishad and Chandogya Upanishad (#2 in the glossary):

May my limbs, speech, life-force (Prana), sight, hearing, strength, and all my senses, gain in vigor. All is the Brahman (Supreme Lord, Infinity) of the Upanishads. May I never deny the Brahman/Infinity. May the Brahman/Infinity never deny me. May there be no denial of the Brahman/Infinity. May there be no separation from the Brahman/Infinity. May all the virtues manifest in me, who am devoted to the Atman (Higher Self). May thy manifest in me.

OM! PEACE! PEACE! PEACE!

This chant ends with the prayer for protection from three-fold miseries affecting the human body and mind, miseries affecting other living beings, and miseries such as natural calamities like earthquakes, floods, wildfires, tsunamis, etc.

What is Infinity/God?

‘Ye, Children of Immortal Bliss’

Swami Vivekananda

‘God’ is well described in Kenopanishad (or Kena Upanishad), one of the Hindu scriptures, and in many other places. Kena in Sanskrit means ‘by what’, referring to the various things that we experience happen. A very brief description of this is that what is the command behind what makes the mind think, life force (Prana) move, eyes see, ‘speech’ speak, ears hear. That ‘thing’ is referred to as ‘Brahman/Infinity’. I am calling it ‘Infinity’ in this book. Others have done it too.

‘Infinity’ is also described as OM. Transliteration of the most sacred mantra (also called root mantra), ‘Ik Onkar’, chanted by the Sikhs is

‘true name, without fear and enmity (all-compassionate), one which transcends time, birth and death, self-existent, true today, true eternally and realized by Guru’s grace.’

‘Infinity’ is also described as the ‘Fourth (turiya) state’, one beyond the wake, dream, and sleep states of the self. It is an experience of consciousness that is neither inwards, nor outwards, nor both. It is beyond cognition and beyond the absence of cognition. It cannot be sensed by the senses, it is not known by comparison, deductive reasoning, or inference; it is indescribable, incomprehensible, and unthinkable. It is pure consciousness, the pure self that witnesses the self in the waking, dream, and sleep states. It is serene, tranquil, blissful. It is the ONE, one without a second. It makes us realize that material life is an illusion and temporary. This is the real or true Self that is to be realized. It is also described as AUM followed by silence. ‘A’ represents the waking state of the self, ‘U’ represents the dream state of the self, and ‘M’ represents the sleep state of the self and silence represents the pure, infinite truth of the unmanifest self that witnesses the self, manifesting in the waking, dream, and sleep states. (Ref: Mandukya Upanishad inverse 7 and Ashtavakra Gita 1:12). OM is described in a lot of other scriptures. Sadhguru claims that Om (Aum) has found its way in the more recent Abrahamic faiths as well. Om is chanted by many yoga practitioners and hence OM is easily the universal message of peace to be united with the universal ONE and has transcended all faiths. More curious readers are recommended to read the book, “Enlightenment without GOD” (ISBN 13: 978-089389-084-1).

A more precise definition of God is...

‘The all consummate definition (Ref: *Taittiriya Upanishad* 2.1.1) of ‘God/Ishwara/Brahman/Infinity is Truth, Knowledge, and Infinite’ (*Satyam, Jnanam, Anantam Brahma*). To put it in simple terms, ‘Infinity is God’. Infinity is experienced as ‘truth, cosmic intelligence,

and bliss' (*Sat, Chit, Ananda*). Truth, is the eternal, unchanging truth that exists for forever. Body and mind change every day and hence are not the eternal truths. *Jnanam* means 'knowledge', referring to the knowledge of pure consciousness in which my body is situated, in this context. *Anantam* or Infinity means 'one without a limit', referring to 'unlimited in space, time, and object'. 'Unlimited in space' means God/Brahman is all-pervading, omnipresent, not just 'up there', not just in heaven, but everywhere including here. 'Unlimited in time' means God/Brahman is eternal without a beginning or end, Brahman is available to experience now, today, tomorrow, and every day in this life, not just after death. 'Unlimited in object' means that God/Brahman is beyond the definition of an object. Wave is nothing but water, there is no 'second thing' other than water. Brahman is 'ALL', ONE without a second, non-dual, infinite.

For ease of understanding to the secular and spiritual but not religious (SBNR) readers, I described Brahman or God as 'Infinity', knowing that 'Infinity' does not describe it all. 'Infinity' is not my discovery or invention. This term is used by others as well. For the secular and SBNR people, Brahman is the Godless 'Infinity'. That is why the scope of 'Infinity' is infinite. That is the power of Infinity!

Simple Methods of Experiencing Infinity:

These are mainly faith based practices to experience 'Infinity' 24/7. Sant Kabir Das, an Indian mystic and poet of the 15th century CE, said, "When I walk, I think I am circumambulating the Lord; when I work, I think I am serving God; and when I sleep, I think I am offering Him my obeisances. In this manner, I perform no activity other than that which is offered to Him."

Path of love toward God (devotion): Prayer and devotion to God to experience Infinity. This is not unique to Hinduism.

Path of action (karma): Performing day to day activities with gratitude as an offering to God to experience Infinity. This is somewhat unique to Hinduism.

Path of contemplation (Yoga): Unconditional happiness and unconditional love to experience Infinity. This is from Hinduism, but also comes from other eastern cultures and has been embraced widely by the west as a physical or spiritual, but not religious practice.

Path of knowledge: Healing with knowing that 'true self is divine' to experience Infinity. This is somewhat unique to non-dualistic path of Hinduism, but there are less obvious shades of non-dualism in all the faiths if you look for it.

Repeating any Maha-mantras (Great Mantras) or God's names daily: Chanting names and mantras for hundreds and thousands of times at a stretch on a regular basis till one experiences the transcendental state is a way to experience 'Infinity'. Now many can do this without getting distracted. Few get the experience quickly, these are few and far in between. Examples include Ramakrishna Paramahansa (Ramakrishna Mission and Vedanta Society), Ramana Maharshi, Avadoota Swami Nityananda of Ganeshpuri, and others). HH A C Swami Prabhupada of ISKCON took a risk and was successful in having commoners including some drug addicts experience the transcendental state by chanting Hare Krishna Mahamantra (Hare Rama Hare Rama, Rama Rama Hare Hare, Hare Krishna Hare Krishna, Krishna Krishna Hare Hare) at least 1728 times daily, 16 rounds of 108 repetitions daily. Many drug addicts felt the same experience that they used to get from recreational drugs and hence were able to quit drugs. They were able to experience the spirit from spirituality without consuming the real spirit! He took the risk of testing his mantra in the drug addicts and not everyone were able to quit drugs. But that was

the risk he took. But, today, ISKCON has the large following around the globe.

One can choose to repeat other mantras like 'Om Namo Narayanaya Namah', 'Om Namo Vasudevaya Namah', 'Om Namah Shivaya', 'Om Namo Durgaya Namah' or any mantra of your choice.

Some choose to repeat names like 'Rama', 'Krishna', 'Durga', 'Ganesha', etc thousands of times.

Some chant the monosyllable and powerful mantra, 'OM' thousands of times.

Some chooses to chant the greatest of the mantras, 'The Gayatri Mantra' (please refer to the chapter dedicate to Gayatri mantra).

Choices are many, choose one, stick to that.

Experience based and Knowledge based Contemplative Methods of Experiencing Infinity:

A little bit more profound ways of experiencing 'Infinity' are by following the paths of self-experience and acquiring knowledge that the 'Self is Divine.' Some of these methods include knowing the methods of self-inquiry and yoga from the eastern Hindu wisdom. I also brought in 'I am the Awakened (Buddha)' from Buddhist philosophy and chanting 'Ik Onkaar' mantra after knowing its meaning from Sikhism since these faiths evolved from the original Sanatan Dharma (now called Hinduism).

1. **Six verses leading to Infinity (Nirvana Shatkam):** There 6 verses were answers by Adi Shankara to his Guru's Guru, when he was asked 'Who Are You?' Each verse ends with 'Shivoham', which means 'I am Shiva'. Here Shiva refers to Universal Brahman.

2. **Self-inquiry to experience Infinity:** Ramana Maharshi,

a twentieth century saint recommend asking oneself 'Who am I?' till one finds out that what is left at the end is 'the divine self'. A set of answers given by Ramana Maharshi are available as a book called, 'Who AM I?'

Eventhough Adi Shankara and Ramana Maharshi lived about 1300 years apart, the answers by both were the same. They both said that we are not the body, mnd or intellect since they are impermanent. They said that we are the permanent witness consciousness that witnesses the body, mind and intellect that changes from birth to birth, death to death.

When we realize that we are only the observer, and then we are motivated to refocus on the self as the observer. That 'observer' is referred to as 'That', 'One', '*Sat*', 'The Truth', 'Pranava', 'Now', 'Pure consciousness', 'Witness consciousness', 'Awareness', or 'that Being-ness'. I am the ever-pure blissful consciousness. And as Adi Shankara has taught us, this is the realization, which leads to the true feeling of Oneness with the Universe, Oneness with Nature, and Oneness with God. 'Oneness with Infinity'!

Short summary of both 'Six Verses to Nirvaana' and 'Who Am I' is:

'I am not the body, I am not the mind, I am not the Intellect

I am not what my sense organs feel

I am not what my motor organs do

I am the form of consciousness and bliss,

I am the eternal Shiva, I am the eternal Shiva

I am Brahman

I am the Infinity'

3. Buddhist approach to experience Infinity: I am the 'awakened (Buddha)'

4. Yoga and meditation to experience Infinity: Follow the eight steps mentioned in the dedicated chapter on Yoga. The ultimate experience of Samadhi is same as Infinity.

5. Chanting Ik Onkar/AUM/OM hundreds and thousands of times to experience Infinity.

I want to end the chapter with a universal prayer from *Isha Vasya Upanishad* stressing the infinitude of “The Infinitude” here:

“Om, That is Infinity, This is Infinity, from the Infinitude comes the Infinitude

If Infinitude is taken away from Infinitude, Only Infinitude remains,

Om, Peace, Peace, Peace.”

(For more details the reader is referred to read 'Navigating Cancer with The Power of Infinity' by the same author)

SECTION VI

*In part **six** we go through a potpourri of four great sentences, six philosophies of Hinduism and on holy Gurus. This section is rich in words from Sanskrit knowledge and may be difficult to comprehend unless you are comfortable in Sanskrit or one of the many Indian languages rooted in Sanskrit.*

Chapter 34

Four Great Sentences of Hinduism

The Four Great Truths (The Mahavakyas)

If the vast ocean of Hindu philosophy were to be condensed into four drops, those drops would be the *Mahavakyas*. Some of this chapter is repetition of chapter 17 to stress the message that the core of Hinduism is seeing divinity in everything and everybody, a radical teaching that is very relevant to today's world.

The word *Mahavakya* literally means "Great Sentence" (*Maha* = Great, *Vakya* = Sentence). These four profound statements are pulled from the Upanishads—the philosophical core of the Vedas. They are not merely religious slogans; they are "blueprints" for human consciousness. They are designed to act as a mirror, helping the individual realize that they are not a separate, small ego, but part of a grand, infinite reality.

In Hindu tradition, each of these four sentences is tied to one of the four Vedas, acting as a pillar for the entire framework of Advaita (Non-dual) philosophy.

1. "Consciousness is the Ultimate Reality" (*Prajñānam Brahma*)

Found in: *The Rig Veda*

Many people ask, "What is God?" Hinduism often answers that God is not a person sitting in the clouds, but the very "stuff" of awareness itself. This sentence tells us that the universe is not just matter and energy; it is, at its core, pure, intelligent consciousness. You are not a human being having a spiritual experience; you are consciousness itself, experiencing the world through the lens of a human life*

2. "You Are That" (*Tat Tvam Asi*)

Found in: *The Sama Veda*

This is perhaps the most famous piece of advice in Indian history. A teacher says this to his student to remind him that the "That"—the cosmic, infinite power that runs the galaxies—is the same "You" sitting right here. It is the ultimate equalizer. It suggests that there is no fundamental difference between the creator and the creation. You aren't "getting to" God; you are already that. You have to realize it, not as an abstract theoretical construct, but as experience through listening to it, contemplating on it and realizing it as an inner experience.

3. "This Self is the Ultimate Reality" (*Ayam Ātmā Brahma*)

Found in: *The Atharva Veda*

This sentence brings the divine down from the abstract heavens and plants it firmly inside your own chest. It tells us that the "Self" (*Atman*) you feel within—your inner voice, your awareness, your witness—is exactly the same as the "Brahman," the force that sustains the entire universe. It encourages us to stop searching for the divine in distant temples and start looking within.

4. "I am Brahman" (*Aham Brahmāsmi*)

Found in: *The Yajur Veda*

If "You are that" is the theory, this is the personal realization. It is the declaration of the person who has looked inside and found that the "I" they were talking about—the ego, the name, the personality—is just a mask. Behind the mask is the same infinite, unchanging reality. It is the ultimate state of empowerment: the realization that your true nature is limitless.

Why do these matter today?

In our modern, fast-paced world, we often feel small, isolated, or disconnected. We identify with our jobs, our anxieties, or our social media profiles.

The great sentences serve as a spiritual "reset button." They challenge us to look past the surface of our lives. They offer a radical form of confidence, love, coexistence and divinity: if the source of the universe and the source of your own consciousness are one and the same, then you are never truly alone, never truly powerless, and never truly separate from the rest of existence.

The takeaway: You are not a drop in the ocean; you are the entire ocean in a drop.

These four sentences are the essence of Hinduism, and they come from four original secret texts of Hinduism called Vedas. Most of the details of the practice of the religion are non-essential rituals. But these sentences are very practical and summarize the ultimate result of studying and contemplating upon Hinduism in minimum words.

Chapter 35

Six Philosophies of Hinduism

Six philosophies of Hinduism have been described. The goal of all these philosophies is to end human suffering and attain liberation from mundane things. I added this chapter to the second edition to make it a little bit more complete at the risk of making it appear complicated. But the main reason for adding this chapter to emphasize the diverse ways of practicing Hinduism.

These are:

- ‘Nyaya (~Justice)’ Philosophy: This offers rational and scientific approach to end human suffering. It is about how to gain right knowledge and not seek wrong knowledge to end human suffering.
- ‘Sankhya’ Philosophy: This philosophy distinguishes Purusha (pure consciousness) from Prakriti (nature or matter). Liberation comes through realizing that our true nature as consciousness is distinct from the changing body, mind, and material world.

- ‘Yoga’ Philosophy: This is somewhat similar to Sankhya, but mainly focusses on methods to still the mind to experience divinity of the self. It adds the ‘almighty being (Ishwara)’. This offers eight limbs of Yoga that are described in a separate chapter since it is becoming very popular all over the world in a non-theistic way.
- ‘Vaisheshika’ Philosophy: This is metaphysics. Here the universe is described as cluster of atoms and ‘Brahman/God’ is the force that holds the atoms (the universe) together.
- ‘Purva Mimamsa’ Philosophy: This school believes in the supreme authority of the ‘Vedas’, the original Hindu scriptures. In this school, the focus is on rituals consisting of chanting mantras and worship in front of fire. This method is practiced by many Hindus.
- ‘Uttara Mimamsa (Vedanta)’ Philosophy: Most Hindus follow this school of Hinduism which mainly follows the Upanishads, which are the summarized versions of Vedas. There are three main ways of practicing ‘Vedanta’: Non-dualistic (Adwaita) school, Dualistic (Dwaita) school and Qualified non-Dualism school. There is a separate chapter to describe these schools.

However, many other subbranches are described. These different schools of Hinduism offer different ways to practice Hinduism, but they are not mutually exclusive.

These are some suggestions to personalize the path to ‘Divinity’:

If a person wants the conventional devotional relationship with God, the path of duality (Dwaita) offers that. This is how most faiths

of the world are practiced. This school has those who want to go to heaven after death, those who want to merge with God after several rebirths or people who simply want love, grace and company of God forever without necessarily liberation or 'heaven'.

If a person wants to practice his duties as an offering to God (Karma Yoga), you have that option too. This path can be theistic or non-theistic depending upon your choice.

If a person wants to practice focused mind and experience the transcendent God (Ishwara), one can follow the path of Raja Yoga (Yoga Philosophy). This is the 'experiential approach'. This is an opportunity for people who want to experience 'God' in this life. This is also an option for 'Spiritual, but not religious/SBNR' people.

If one wants to study the knowledge of the 'Pure Self', and realize that 'Pure Self' is not separate from 'Impersonal God', one can practice non-dualistic (Adwaita) path. This is an option for those who have problem with 'imagery worship' or 'idol worship'. This is for people who want to experience God in this life. This is an opportunity to experience 'God' in this life. This also is an option for 'Spiritual, but not religious/SBNR' people.

If one believes in having a 'personal God' within the 'self' that is separate from the 'Almighty God', one can follow 'Sankhya Philosophy'.

If one believes that the self is part of God, but that God is separate from the self, one can practice the path of 'Qualified Monism' (Vishisht Adwaita).

The paths of 'Action (Karma)', 'Focused mind/meditation (Yoga)' and 'Non-Dualism with inquiry of the divinity of the Self' can be theistic or non-theistic.

Chapter 36

Holy Gurus

I brought this section to appendix to respect the people who may be uncomfortable pronouncing Hindu names. Some of the saints who have revived Hinduism include Shankaracharya, Ramanujacharya, Madhwacharya, Nimbarkacharya, Thiruvalluvar, Swami Narayan, Chaitanya Mahaprabhu and Vallabhacharya.

More recent saints who have helped a lot of Hindus understand Hinduism include Sri Ramakrishna Paramahansa, Swami Vivekananda, Sri Aurobindo, Ramana Maharshi, Swami Chinmayananda, Shiridi Sai Baba, Puttaparti Sai Baba, Shree Madhav Sadashiv Golwalkar, Swami Tejomayananda, Swami Prabhupada, Swami Ganapati Sacchidananda, Amma Amritanandamayi, Swami Dayananda Saraswathi, Sri Sri Ravishankar (Art of Living), Sri Mahesh Yogi (known for his Transcendental Meditation movement), Swami Bodhananda, Swami Sarvapriyananda and many others.

Gandhiji, even though was not a religious leader, has written and taught about Gita. Gandhiji has lived by example by showing the might of non-violence. Writings of Deepak Chopra, MD a prolific writer on spirituality, are to a large extent based on Hindu scriptures.

Some of these leaders contribute in spreading Hindu philosophy, but not necessarily the religion. Among these the all-time great Jagadgurus (Teachers of the world) who stand out are Veda Vyasa, Budha, Adi Shankaracharya and Swami Vivekananda.

Even though Buddha was the founder of Buddhism, he was a Hindu by birth and his deeds. He gets credit for spreading the importance of meditation and spirituality to the masses irrespective of their educational background.

SECTION VII

In this section, some popular quotations and prayer for special occasions are explained. *This section also is rich in words from Sanskrit knowledge and may be difficult to comprehend unless you are comfortable in Sanskrit or one of the many Indian languages rooted in Sanskrit.*

Chapter 37

Some Popular Quotations and Prayers

1. A prayer to Lord Ganesha to remove all the obstacles and provide peace:

*'S*huklaambaradaram Vishnum Shashi Varnam
Chaturbbujam Prasanna Vadanam Dhyayate
Sarva Vighnopa Shaantaye'

2. Only truth wins, never the untruth:

'Satyam eva jayate na anritam'

3. Truth is God and truth is beautiful:

'Satyam Shivam Sundaram'

4. I salute to the God within you: *'Namaste'*

5. You are that (Divine Reality).

'Tat tvam asi'

7. Brahman (God) is the infinite ocean, Atma (Divine self) is a wave in it. They are not different from each other, both are water.

He who sees divinity in all beings and himself, hates nobody, loves everybody and is ever happy.

May He protect us both, teacher and pupil. May that cause both to enjoy the bliss of Liberation. May we both exert to find out the true meaning of the scriptures. May our learning be brilliant. May we never quarrel with each other. OM Peace Peace Peace.

*'Om, Saha naavavatu,
Saha nau bhunaktu
Saha veeryam kara vaava hai
Tejasvinaa vadhitam astu
Maa vid vishaava hai
Om Shaantih Shaantih Shaantih'*

8. Teacher is like almighty God, the creator, the preserver and the dissolver:

*'Guru Brahma
Gurur Vishnuh
Gurur Devo Maheshwarah;
Gurur Sakshat Parar Brahma
Tasmai Shree Guruve Namaha'*

9. Mother, father, teacher and guest are like God:

*'Matr Devobhava,
Pitr Devobhava,
Acharya Devobhava,
Atithi Devobhava'*

10. Food is God:

'Annam Para Brahman'

11. May all be happy,
may all be healthy,
may all enjoy prosperity,
may no one suffer.

*'Sarve bhavantu sukhinaha
sarve santu niraamaya*

*Sarve bhadrani pashyantu
ma kashchit dukha-bhag bhavet'*

12. God, lead me from unreal (Asat = untruth) to real (Sat = truth), from darkness (tamas ~ ignorance) to knowledge (jyoti = light), and from death (Mrtyu) to immortality (amrt)

*'Om asato maa sadgamaya
Tamaso maa jyotirgamaya
Mrityor-maa amrtam gamaya'*

13. Spirituality begins where science ends; contemplation begins where logic ends. (Modified from Swami Vivekananda)

14. Mind, go slowly and slowly. The tree will not give fruit until the season arrives even if the gardener pours 100 pots of water in one day.

*'Dheere dheere Re Mana,
Dheere sub kuch hoi,
Maali seenchei sow gadha,
Rthu ai phal hoi'*

15. Salute to Lord Shiva for enhancement of strength and victory over (untimely) mortality (Mrtyunjaya Mantra):

*'Tryambakam Yajaaamabe
Sugandhim Pushtivardhanam,
Urvaaru Kameeva Bhandhanaat Mrityor
Muksheeyamaamritaat'*

16: *Prayer to the Goddess of Food: Annapoorne Sadapoorne
Shankara Prana Vallabhe*

Jnana Vairagya Siddhyartham Biksham Dehi cha Parvati)

17. Succinct definition of God from Taittiriya Upanishad:

Sathyam Jnaanam Anantham Brahma

Brahman/Infinity is Existence-Knowledge/Consciousness-Infinite.

18. Relationship between devotee and god:

Relationship between devotee and God is well described in the epic Ramayana. In this epic, the Devotee (Hanuman, who is a devotee and God) tells God (Shri Rama) about their relationship as follows. This actually denotes different ways of approaching God by different people.

“At the body level, I am your servant (this is the path of devotion/non-dualistic philosophy).

At the level of individual soul (Jiva), I am your part (qualified non-dualism) and

At the level of ‘my true self’ (Atma), you and I are the same (non-dualism)”

In Bhagavad Gita (Ch 4: 7 and 8), God Krishna tells his friend and devotee, Arjuna that ‘whenever and wherever there is lack of righteousness in the world, I come to the earth to re-establish righteousness’. This can be interpreted as ‘whenever I have problem, God will appear to me and help me’. God can appear as a doctor, parent, spouse, child, sibling, relative, friend or teacher in our lives. God can be a real experience in this life instead of being an after-death experience ‘up there’. This is the beauty of these teachings!

If you read God Krishna’s stories in ‘Bhagawatam’, you will find God as a naughty son who also shows the ‘universe’ in the back of his throat to his mother. He also appears as a handsome and divine lover for thousands of lovers who only want his everlasting company without ‘Moksha’ (they just don’t want the simple and divine loving company to end!).

He appeared as a friend and mentor to Arjuna and he is seen as the Guru (mentor) to the universe by delivering the life lessons in the form of ‘Gita’ (Song of God) to Arjuna, that is available to us. The teachings of Gita are very much current and relevant in today’s life.

19. Quotes from Swami Vivekananda:

“Take up one idea. Make that one idea your life – think of it, dream of it, live on that idea. Let the brain, muscles, nerves, every part of your body, be full of that idea, and just leave every other idea alone. This is the way to success.”

“All power is within you; you can do anything and everything. Believe in that, do not believe that you are weak; do not believe that you are half-crazy lunatics, as most of us do nowadays. You can do anything and everything, without even the guidance of anyone. Stand up and express the divinity within you.”

“Arise, awake, and don’t stop till you reach your goal.”

“Nirvana is the realization of the Self; and after having once known that, if only for an instant, never again can one be deluded by the mirage of personality.”

“Each soul is potentially divine. The goal is to manifest this divinity by controlling nature, external and internal. Do this either by work, or worship, or psychic control (yoga), or philosophy (knowledge that self is divine) - by one, or more, or all of these - and be free. This is the whole of religion. Doctrines, or dogmas, or rituals, or books, or temples, or forms, are but secondary details.”

“There is only one God, not the second; not at all, not at all, not in the least bit.” (Ekameva adviteya Brahma...)

20. “Supreme God (Brahman) itself is real, non-dual, extremely pure, the essence of knowledge absolute, taintless, supremely peaceful, without beginning or end, beyond all activity, always of the nature of bliss absolute, transcending all diversities created by illusion, eternal, the essence of joy, indivisible, immeasurable, formless, unmanifest, nameless, immutable, and self-effulgent”. (Vivekachoodamani, Verse 237 and 238)

21. Seventh verse of Mandukya Upanishad that summarizes the meaning of OM. Meaning has been explained in the book chapter on OM

nāntaḥprajñam na bahiḥprajñam nobhayataḥprajñam na prajñānaghanam na prajñam nāprajñam | adṛśyamavyavahāryamagrāhyamalakṣaṇamacintyamavyapadeśyamekāmapratyayasāraṁ prapañcopaśamaṁ śāntaṁ śivamadvaitaṁ caturthaṁ manyante sa ātmā sa vijñeyah

22. Do everything as an offering to God:

*BrahmaarpaNam brahmahavir
Brahmaagnau brahmaNaabutam
Brahmaivatenagantavyam
Brahma karma samaadbinaa*

23. Statement of Infinity: *Om poornamadah poornamidam poornaat poornamudachyate*

Om poornaasya poornamaadaaya poornamevaa vashishyate

Om Shaantihi Shaantihi Shaantihi

Everything is Infinity:

Om, that is Infinity, this is Infinity, from the Infinitude comes the Infinitude,

If Infinitude is taken away from Infinitude, Only Infinitude remains,

Om, Peace, Peace, Peace.

This prayer suggests the interconnectedness of everything in life and the ultimate nature of reality. It suggests that everything in the world is a manifestation of the same Infinite God, Brahman, divine reality, pure consciousness. Even if we take something away from the infinite consciousness, Infinity remains.

Source: Isha Upanishad of Yajur Veda. (*Om poornamadah poornamidam poornaat poornamudachyate; Om poornasya poor-*

namaadaaya poornamevaa vashishyate; Om Shaantihi Shaantihi Shaantihi)

24. Ladder of spiritual progress in life (Source: Baja Govindam verse 9)

The company of good people and truth leads to non-attachment; from non-attachment arises freedom from delusion, freedom from delusion leads to immutable reality, and immutable reality leads to the state of liberation or freedom.

GOOD COMPANY/COMPANY OF TRUTH □ NON-ATTACHMENT □ FREEDOM FROM DELUSION □ IMMUTABLE REALITY □ STATE OF LIBERATION

(Source: Baja Govindam verse 9: *Satsaṅgatve nissāṅgatvaṃ nissāṅgatve nirmohatvaṃ* |

Nirmohatve niścalatattvaṃ niścalatattve jīvanmuktiḥ ||)

25. May all be healthy!

Lokaah samastah sukhino bhavantu

Chapter 38

Prayers for Special Occasions

A Prayer for Healing and Strength (e.g. if someone develops cancer or heart attack and wants you a pray for that person)

O God,
You are the source of life, the quiet strength within every breath,
the light that shines even in the darkest moments.
We come before You with a humble heart, asking for healing for this dear soul who is suffering.

Please bring comfort to their body, peace to their mind,
and courage to their heart.

Where there is pain, bring relief.

Where there is fear, bring calm.

Where there is weakness, bring gentle strength.

As You (Bhagawan Krishna) teach us in the Bhagavad Gita:

“You have a right to action alone, but not to the fruits of action.”

(Chapter 2, Verse 47)

Help us to do our best with faith, and to surrender the results to You.

And again, You remind us:

*“To those who are always devoted and who worship Me with love,
I give the understanding by which they can come to Me.”* (Chapter 10,
Verse 10)

May Your wisdom guide every doctor, every caregiver, and every decision.

God, please place Your healing presence within every cell of this body.

Let the medicines work well.

Let the treatments bring benefit.

Let the body respond with resilience and renewal.

Give strength to the family and loved ones.

Hold them together with hope and patience.

Let them feel that they are not alone.

Above all, remind us that beyond the body, there is a deeper Self—
untouched, peaceful, and whole.

Help this person feel that inner peace, even now.

We trust in Your grace.

We rest in Your presence.

We place this life in Your loving hands.

Om Shanti, Shanti, Shanti.

A Prayer for Strength in Stressful Times

O God (Bhagawan Krishna/Vishnu/Shiva/Devi/Ishwara),
 You are the calm in the storm, the steady presence within every heart.
 In this time of stress and worry, we turn to You for peace and strength.

Please quiet the restless mind.

Ease the burden of anxious thoughts.

Help this person breathe a little easier, think a little clearer, and feel a little lighter.

As the Bhagavad Gita teaches:

“You have a right to action alone, but not to the fruits of action.”

(Chapter 2, Verse 47)

Help us focus on what we can do, one step at a time, without fear of the outcome.

And You also say:

“Let a person lift themselves by their own mind, and not degrade themselves.

For the mind alone is the friend, and the mind alone is the enemy.”

(Chapter 6, Verse 5)

O God, guide the mind to become a friend.

Replace fear with trust.

Replace doubt with quiet confidence.

Replace confusion with clarity.

Give strength to face each moment with courage.

When things feel too much, remind us to pause, to breathe, and to return to You.

Let Your presence be a safe place within.

Help this person feel supported, even in uncertainty.

Surround them with the right people, the right thoughts, and the right actions.

Teach us to accept what we cannot control,
to act wisely where we can,
and to trust that everything is unfolding with purpose.

O God, hold this heart gently.
Fill it with peace that does not depend on circumstances.
Let there be steadiness within, even when life feels unsteady.

We place this stress in Your hands.
We choose faith over fear.
We walk forward with Your guidance.

Om Shanti, Shanti, Shanti.

A Prayer for Peace After Passing (This can be part of eulogy)

O God,
We bow our heads in silence and love as we remember this Atma (soul)
who has left the body.
Our hearts feel heavy, yet we turn to You for comfort and understanding.

As the Bhagavad Gita teaches:

*“Just as a person puts on new clothes, giving up old ones,
the Atma/soul accepts new bodies, leaving the old and worn-out ones.”*
(Chapter 2, Verse 22)

Help us remember that this Atma (Soul) has not ended, but has simply moved on.
The body has returned to the earth, but the true Self continues its journey.

And again, You remind us:

“The Atma/soul is never born, and it never dies.

It is eternal, ever-existing, and beyond destruction.” (Gita, Chapter 2, Verse 20)

O Lord, please guide this soul on its onward path.
 Surround them with Your light.
 Grant them peace, rest, and freedom from all suffering.
 If there are any burdens from this life, gently release them.
 If there are any fears, replace them with calm.
 Lead this soul toward higher understanding and closer to You.
 Give strength to those who remain behind.
 In our grief, remind us of the deeper truth—that love towards you
 does not end.
 Help us honor this life with gratitude, not only sorrow.
 Let us remember the kindness, the moments shared, the love given
 and received.
 May these memories become blessings in our hearts.
 O God, hold this Atma (Soul) in Your infinite compassion.
 And hold us too, as we learn to accept, to heal, and to trust in Your
 divine plan.

Om Shanti, Shanti, Shanti.

Prayer to Mother Durga (English translation of seven important verses of Devi Mahatmyam, also called Durga Sapta Shloki) in any difficult situations

Even the minds of the wise are drawn into delusion by the Divine Mother.

She, the Supreme Goddess Mahamaya, can overpower and attract even the learned into illusion through Her divine power.

O Durga, when remembered by those in fear, You remove all their fears.

When remembered by those who are peaceful, You grant pure wisdom and auspicious understanding.

Who other than You removes poverty, sorrow, and fear?

Your heart is ever filled with compassion and devoted to the welfare of all beings.

O Narayani,

You are the most auspicious among all that is auspicious.

You are the embodiment of goodness and the fulfiller of every noble purpose.

O refuge of all, Three-eyed Goddess Gauri, I bow before You.

O Narayani,

You are wholly devoted to protecting those who seek refuge, the distressed, the helpless, and the suffering.

O Goddess, remover of the afflictions of all beings,

I bow before You.

O Goddess Durga,

You are the essence of every form, the Sovereign of all, endowed with every divine power.

Protect us from every kind of fear. Our salutations to You.

When pleased, You remove every disease and suffering.

When displeased, You destroy all selfish desires.

Those who take refuge in You never perish.

Indeed, those who seek Your shelter become a refuge for others.

O Supreme Ruler of the three worlds,

Please pacify every obstacle and affliction affecting all creation.

Likewise, we pray that You remove and destroy the forces that oppose righteousness and hinder our spiritual progress.

Suggested Reading

1. The Essentials of Hinduism by Swami Bhaskarananda
(ISBN 1-884852-04-1)

2. Am I a Hindu? The Hinduism Primer by Ed Viswanathan
(Rupa & Co)

3. *What is Hinduism?* (ISBN 978-1-934145-00-5) published by the Himalayan Academy, Hawaii.

4. *Hindu Culture and Dharmic Traditions from India*
(ISBN 9781934192009) This is a masterpiece, collection of portrayal of India's glorious past, put together by Hindu Swayamsevak Sangh, USA (www.hssus.org)

4. *Srimad Bhagavad Gita Sadhaka Sanjivani* by Swami Ram-sukhdas (Gita Press, Gorakhpur, India)

5. *The Holy Geeta* by Swami Chinmayananda available in any Chinmaya Mission branches all over the world.

6. *Gayatri, The Highest Meditation* by Sagduru Sant Keshavdas (ISBN 81-208-0697-2)

7. *The True History of the Religion of India* by Swami Prakashanand Saraswati (ISBN 0-9673823-1-9). This is a good reference book to get the specifics of Hindu lineage and history.

8. *I Am All, A Cosmic Vision of Man* by Sudhakar S. Dikshit (ISBN 81-85300-30-5), a follower of Nisarga Datta. You can feel the cosmic energy when you read this book. A very readable book with lots of facts.

10. *Art of God Symbolism* by Swami Chinmayananda (ISBN 81-7597-058-8)

Concluding Remarks

My Dear Divine Brothers and Sisters, thank you for reading this. If you are a Hindu, I hope you are proud of your lineage and philosophies. If you are not a Hindu, I hope you know the richness of Hinduism a little better now.

I bow to the divine in all of you (Namaste). You belong to the same lineage that Lord Rama and Lord Krishna spent their lives in the earth as human beings, you belong to the lineage that respects all cultures with divinity, you belong to the lineage that described plastic surgery of the nose in 600 BC, you belong to the same lineage that taught nonviolence to the world including Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. and Dalai Lama, you belong to the lineage that worships divine women, and finally you belong to the lineage that sees divinity in everything and everybody irrespective of their faith.

From your Divine Brother,

Wishing peace, peace and peace to the world.

Anupkumar Shetty, MD FASN

Other books by the Author:

1. Navigating Cancer with The Power of Infinity



2. The Power of Infinity: Health, Wellbeing and Anticancer Lifestyle

3. Peritoneal Dialysis Simplified: Over 65 Case Scenarios

4. Cancer Devotional for Women: My Dialogue with God

5. Cancer Devotional for Men and Women: A Picture Book-My Dialogue with God

About the author

Dr. Anupkumar Shetty is a Nephrologist (Kidney specialist) from Texas, USA. He is also the author of, 'The Power of Infinity: Health, Wellbeing and an Anticancer Lifestyle', 'Navigating Cancer with the Power of Infinity', 'Peritoneal Dialysis Simplified', 'Cancer Devotional for Women' and 'Cancer Devotional for Men and Women'. He has published over 25 research papers in peer reviewed medical journals. Originally, he is from a small place near Udupi and Mangalore, in southern part of India. Having had a normal childhood with parents, two brothers, two sisters he grew up with love, books, cricket and a very altruistic Grandmother.

Marriage blessed him with his wife Mala Shetty, two children Eesha and Krishna, in-laws and lots of love. At the age of 41 years, when everything was looking good, he was struck with rectal cancer from which he has recovered. As his father-in-law told him, the prayers and goodwill from family and friends had a lot of power. Hindu philosophies of feeling the God from within and realizing that 'We Are That (Divine Reality)' helped him recover and move on with his life. But he has taken up the task of educating people about healthy living with Modern Science, Hindu philosophies, meditation and healthy eating habits. At the time of completing this book in 2026, he is dealing with

another cancer, possibly related to radiation that he received for rectal cancer in 2005.

Dr. Nakta Venkata Raju, who contributed poems is a practicing Neonatologist (doctor for the newborns) from Texas, USA. He is also the author of 2 books of poems covering wide range of Hindu scriptures. He is a very sought-after speaker on Bhagavad Gita and Neonatology. He was inspired by his Gurus to spread the message of Bhagavad Gita and he does it irrespective of whether he has time or not. Dr Raju is an avid traveler and a doting grandpa to Eesha.